Bound till the Thaw

The Winter Passes, Book 1

Mira Sangla

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Adult (18+). All characters are adults.

Chapter 1

The Count

Nine. Ten. Eleven.

Meera laid each packet on the oilcloth as she said its number, out loud, in the cold top room of the salt house. Her mother had taught her that a number spoken was a number kept. The one time Meera counted in her head, she carried eleven packets over the Long Saddle and called them twelve. Nobody in Ranu let her forget the missing one.

"Twelve."

Redbark, twelve packets of it, each the size of a palm and tied with waxed thread. Enough for one village, if the healer was stingy and the sick were patient. Meera folded the oilcloth over them once, twice, three times, and tapped the roll against her knuckles to check the folds. Three. Good.

The crate sat open at her knee, and she did not like the lid.

A pale patch, broad as a hand, marked the place where the crown stamp should have been. Someone had scraped it down to bare deodar, then rubbed the wood with ash to dull the new colour. The other three lids were the same.

She ran her thumb over the patch. Careful work. It was the work of someone who wanted crown goods to look like nobody's goods.

Then she shrugged. Redbark came to her from the lowlands through a man she had never met, and she had never once asked whose cart it fell

off. Questions cost coin. Children's lungs cost more. She pulled the waxed notebook into the lamplight and wrote with the bone stylus.

Twelve packets redbark. Crate lids scraped, four of four. Then the price, and the hour.

Kiran called it the most criminal thing about her: a woman who spat at the Closing Law and still kept books like a tax clerk. She called it arithmetic. The count didn't care what she thought of a thing. It only held it.

She turned back to the last delivery. Seven crates had waited at the mill below the village, left by a carter who had given her one instruction and one object. The object was a brass button. Whoever brought the next load would carry its twin, and no twin meant no crate. She had written that down too.

The button was small and domed and bright as a new coin, with a shank so stiff it had never been sewn to anything. It bore no crest. She threaded her needle and stitched it into the spine of the ledger, between the third and fourth gatherings, where only a person who unpicked the binding would find it. A button was a stupid thing to hide a drop in. That was the point.

She was biting off the thread when boots sounded on the outer stair. One set was heavy and one dragged, the gait of two people who had been roped together for days and disliked it.

Roop and Chand came in white to the eyebrows. They were the last pair Meera had sent across and the last to come back. Until the thaw they couldn't stand more than a rope's length apart, and they had opinions about that.

"Kiran's," Roop said, and held out a folded scrap of redbark sacking.

Charcoal, in her brother's slanting hand.

Didi. Grey cough in Ranu since the new moon. Nimmi's counting: forty-one sick, nine of them under ten, six buried. We boil walnut leaf and it is about as much use as a prayer. Come before the children go.

Under it, in Nimmi's square hand, a list. *Grey phlegm. Blue lips. Children first. No redbark left.*

And a last line, back in charcoal, because Kiran could not end anything on a bad word. *P.S. Nobody here will kiss me. I've decided it's the ear.*

Meera read it twice. The second time her thumb found the edge of the paper and pressed until the nail whitened.

The ear. Two winters ago he had come back from a crossing with his left ear black along the rim, the colour of burnt bread. He joked about it the same day. The mountain took a bite and spat it out, he said, no taste. He had told that joke forty times since. In all that time he had never said where the crossing was, or who had been on the rope, and when she asked he asked about the goats.

She hadn't pushed. Some things you let a person carry until they set them down.

"Is he well?" she asked.

"He's the one holding the lamp," Chand said. "He coughed once while we were there. Once."

Once was how it started.

Meera folded the note into her coat, then stood and rolled the oilcloth under her arm.

"Wardens come up the valley every tenth day," she said. "Today is the tenth. We're at the cairn by noon, and over the first ridge before dark."

"Roop," said Chand, "she's using the voice."

"Eat something," Meera told them. "Then go sit in separate corners, as far apart as the rope lets you. It'll improve your marriage."

*

The goat pen under the salt house smelled of warm wool and old dung, and it was the one room in Kothi Shilak that never smelled of salt.

Jassi stood in the middle of it with a hay fork in one hand and a goat's ear in the other, delivering a lecture.

"Pomegranate, I know you've got the cold shoulder, so does everyone. Auntie, don't look at me like that, you bit the last man. Sheriff, move your rump." He saw Meera on the ladder and did not stop. "Third run

this month. My knees are as old as the Closing Law and they hold the same opinion of the crown."

"Then stay," Meera said.

"Stay? And who holds Sheriff on the Saddle? Magistrate won't walk beside him. Judge won't walk behind." He dropped the ear, slapped the nearest flank and began harnessing, still grumbling. "My sister keeps asking when I'll come to the orchard. I tell her, after this one. I've been telling her that for six winters."

"You volunteered."

"I did not."

"You were up before me. You've got the harness oiled."

Jassi looked at the harness in his hands as if someone else had put it there. "Forty years old," he said, "and a girl half my age catches me in my own kindness. Ten winters of this, you've done, and you still count your fingers on the stair like a clerk. Twenty-nine and no sense."

"Twenty-nine and paying for your orchard," Meera said. "Stop telling me about your knees."

From the far corner came a soft, tuneless chant. Bindu sat on a wool bale with the red rope across her lap, walking her hands along it and singing the knots under her breath.

Two over, one under, the third one tells the truth.

"Thirty-four winters," Jassi said, nodding at her, "and she's never once looked a customer in the eye. Put a rope in her hands and she'd shout down the mountain."

Bindu went pink to the ears and sang louder.

The rope was eight arm-spans of wool dyed madder-red, spun in the house of a Taravan trader, Lata, who sold to them at a fair price and asked nothing. It was the right rope: hand-spun, no longer than the spirits would stand, and soft enough that it did not cut when it caught a wrist. Bindu measured it again, hand over hand.

"Eight," she said. "Still eight. It wanted to be nine."

"It can want," said Meera. She crouched beside her and took Bindu's hands, the knuckles cracked open from the wind. Without being asked,

she dug a pot of goat fat from her coat and worked it into the splits. “It’ll want a lot of things before the thaw.”

Bindu looked at the fat, then at Meera, and said nothing, which was how she said thank you. She went back to her knots.

That was the whole crew, nearly. A man who hated his knees, a woman who sang to rope, two bickering runners and a brother in a fever village.

*

The Taravan salt merchant was waiting in the weighing room with his boots on the salt scales, which she took as a mark against him.

He wore a good pattu and a better opinion of himself. He wanted a load of rock salt put over the pass to Neshar on the next run, off the Guild’s books, and he was willing to pay for the privilege. He set a purse on the scale, then a second one beside it.

“Double your price,” he said. “For the first place after this crossing.”

Meera looked at the purses. She did not count them. She could see from the way they sat that the second had been added after he saw the stairs.

“Double buys you the place,” she said. “It also buys the widow Puja’s son a free crossing next run. His mother needs him across before spring. Yours is the coin that pays his rope.”

“I wasn’t aware I was a charity.”

“You aren’t. You’re a customer who can afford to be.”

He raised his eyebrows. “It would help the transaction, you know, if you said please.”

“Please costs extra,” said Meera. “You’ve already paid double.”

He laughed, which was the right thing to do, and left the purses where they lay. She had left the count and the oilcloth roll on the table upstairs, and she did not like that, but she walked him out through the village herself because she wanted to see the road.

Kothi Shilak had one gate, a gap in a stone wall that kept out nothing but goats. The Closing Law was nailed to the left post on a board gone

grey with weather. She didn't need to read it. She had learned it before she learned her letters.

Between first snow and first thaw, no person shall cross any high pass of Hemkot without the writ of the queen's hand. Whoever so crosses, and whoever shelters, feeds or warms him, shall be hanged.

The hanging tree stood beyond the post, a single old deodar with a low arm. The wardens had hammered a peg into the trunk for every rope it had borne. The old pegs were grey and split. Two were pale and fresh, from last winter. The bark had not grown over the holes yet.

The merchant looked at the tree and then, very carefully, at the road.

"Good morning," he said, and went down the hill faster than he came up.

Meera stayed a moment longer. There was a third place on that trunk, bare wood, and she knew whose name it was waiting for. The Salt Fox. Hers, and Jassi's, and Bindu's, and Kiran's, but the wardens would start with the head. She turned her back on the tree and counted paces to the salt house instead. Twenty-two.

At fourteen the horns came from the lower road: three blasts, long, then one short. The sound hit the valley wall and came back doubled.

Not noon. Not the tenth day's lazy counting of goats. She was already running.

*

She took the stair two at a time. The count lay open on the table in the top room, wet ink still shining, with the brass button sewn in its spine and a scraped lid at the foot of the table. She snapped the ledger shut and shoved it inside her coat, hard against her ribs, and belted the coat over it. Then she caught up the oilcloth roll and went down while the horns were still echoing.

Bindu had the bale open when Meera came in. She never said a word and never needed to. The two of them worked as if they had rehearsed it, because they had, four winters running. The roll went into the heart of

the raw fleece. Greasy wool closed over it, then more wool, and Bindu sat on top with the red rope in her lap and her face as blank as a stone.

"Twelve," Meera said, once, under her breath, and stood back from the bale. She would not look at it again.

Jassi had a hay fork in his hands and the look of a man who had never wanted to be anywhere else. Roop and Chand had vanished upstairs to be married in a cupboard. The pen was quiet except for the bells.

Boots came up the path outside, and in the yard someone shouted an order. A goat bleated, then bleated again in a different key. Something thudded.

"Corporal."

The voice was not loud. It did not need to be. The yard stopped.

Meera went to the door and put her shoulder to the frame, as if she had only been passing.

A young warden in a grey coat had Sheriff by the harness and one boot drawn back. Another stood behind him with a spear he held as if he'd never asked it a question. Eight wardens in all, snow on their shoulders, breath smoking. At the centre of the yard stood a ninth man, in the same coat, and he was looking at the corporal's boot.

"It is a goat," said the young warden.

"It is a goat," the man agreed, "and it has not been charged with anything." He turned his head. "Put your foot down."

The boot went down.

That was Captain Rohan. She knew him by the grey of his coat and the way the yard bent around him. Three winters she had heard about him: the hunter, the man who hanged two smugglers and seized her crew's loads twice, the one the lowlanders said never slept. She had pictured someone loud.

He did not look like a man who enjoyed anything. He looked like a man who had read the law, checked the arithmetic, and found it came out as written. He was about thirty-five, lean through the face, with a stillness you could rest a ladder on. When he turned, it was all at once, without wasted motion, and he looked straight at her.

It was a short look. It took in her hands, her boots, the doorframe she leaned on, and the way she did not move. He gave her no time to arrange her face. His gaze stopped, very briefly, on the wax at the edge of her thumbnail. The ledger sat against her ribs like a second heartbeat, with the button in its spine and every scraped lid written down inside. Then his eyes moved on.

She pressed the waxed nail into her palm and began, as she always did when she was afraid, to count. Eight wardens. One captain. Six paces from the yard gate to the door. She said the numbers into her teeth.

"I'm told," he said, in the measured voice of a man reading from a page, "that the guide Jassi keeps this house."

Jassi lifted the hay fork a fraction and put it down again. "I keep the goats," he said.

"Then you are the man I am looking for."

Jassi opened his mouth. Meera could see him searching for his sister's orchard and finding only a rope.

"He's got the cold in his chest," she said, and stepped out of the doorway. "He's deaf in the left ear and rude in the right. I answer for him."

The captain regarded her. Not the way wardens usually did, with the flat contempt of a man deciding whether a woman could be ignored. He looked at her the way she looked at a crate lid. Carefully. Waiting to see what had been scraped away.

"Then you will do," he said. "Guide."

Not girl. Not woman. Not mistress of the house.

"What does the captain of the wardens want with a guide," Meera said, "in a month when the pass is shut by his own law?"

"A crossing," said Rohan. "Of the Long Saddle."

Behind her, in the dark of the salt house, a bale of wool sat very still with twelve packets in its heart. Against her ribs, the count held her name for every crossing the law had ever hanged for. The goat Sheriff bleated once and was quiet.

Meera did not say please. She did not say anything at all.

Chapter 2

The Writ

The fourth plank in the weighing-room floor came up with a groan. Under it lay dust, a dead mouse and nothing else.

Rohan set the plank back and pressed it flat with his boot. He had been in the salt house two hours. His wardens had gone through the three timber floors and the loft, and the corporal had pulled every stair tread to look behind it. They had found goat harness, forty sacks of rock salt wearing the Guild's mark, and a whole wall of pass rope coiled by length on pegs. The pen below he had kept for last. A pen could not be searched fast, and a man who hurried one missed things.

Pass rope was legal to own. That was the trouble with the law. It hanged a man for crossing and let him keep the rope.

The woman who answered for the goat-keeper had followed him from room to room, never closer than six paces, hands folded before her. Her lips moved. He had noticed it on the first floor, and by the second he had stopped pretending he hadn't. She was counting, and not the salt sacks or the wardens. Eleven steps from the stair head to the pen ladder. Nine across the weighing room. Her murmur kept time with his boots, as if she were learning the length of his stride.

Recruits counted when they were afraid. Few counted a stranger.

The pen was warm and low and stank of wet wool. Goats shifted in their stalls, and a man with a hay fork stood among them. In the far corner six wool bales stood against the wall, corded and pressed. A thin

woman sat on the nearest with a red rope across her lap and her eyes on her knuckles. Rohan walked within an arm of her. Behind him the counting stopped, started again and skipped a number.

"Probe," he said.

The corporal drew the iron spike wardens used to find salt in grain and drove it into the first bale to the hilt, then the second, then the third. Each time it came out with greasy wool on the tip and no more.

"Cut one open, sir," the corporal said. "They pack the heart."

"They do." Rohan looked at the fleece. It was the village's winter: every sock, every pattu, every rope between here and the lowlands. "Leave it."

The corporal's face said what he thought of that. Rohan let it. The thin woman did not look up, and neither did the guide, and it was the way she didn't that he remembered.

*

The whole village stood in the yard when he came up, in a thin white light: shepherds and rope-twisters, women with babies on their hips, an old man whose left hand ended in three fingers. They had the look of people waiting to learn which of them would be taken.

Rohan drew the writ from the leather case at his belt and unfolded it so the back rows could see the brown ink and the crown's red border.

"I am Rohan, captain of the queen's wardens on this side of Shilak. This is a writ of passage in the queen's own hand. It makes my crossing lawful, between first snow and thaw, when no other crossing in Hemkot is." He let them look at the signature. "I go on crown business to the Snow Fair. I must be there in twenty days. That is all I will say of it, and all you need."

It was not all.

Under his collar, in a pocket sewn into the seam at the nape of his coat, lay a lapis stone the length of a thumb joint, cut with a mountain goat. The queen's seal. Regent Pritam meant to stand on the Snow Fair ground at midwinter and be invested lord of Neshar, on the claim that

the queen was dying. The queen was ill. She was not dead, and the seal pressed before the assembly would say so in the only voice the hill lords obeyed. Without it, Rohan was a captain with a story, and Pritam had captains of his own.

Inside his coat lay a second paper, sealed. One line in it he had read until the words went smooth. *Bring in the Salt Fox at the thaw.* For three winters he had followed that crew's tracks, found their crates and never their faces. He did not know why a queen who signed a hanging law wanted the fox delivered and not hanged. He had not asked. A captain who asked why was halfway to deciding not to.

"Two wardens cross," he said aloud. "Myself and my lieutenant. With two guides to tie the rope. The rest of my men return to the post."

"Two guides," said the woman from the doorway. She had come up behind him without a sound. "Those are the rules, are they? One pair for the Saddle?"

"Two pairs. The mountain's rules, Guide, not mine."

"Then you know them better than most wardens." She said it as if she were entering it in a book.

"One question before we speak of guides," Rohan said, "and I will say what it is for. Two winters ago a warden of mine, Dilan, died on the ice below the Saddle, chasing a smuggler in a storm. He was twenty-three. The report of it runs four lines. It says that where the chase ended there was blood on the ice, and a curl of frozen cartilage no longer than a fingernail, as if someone had left part of himself behind." He kept his hand away from his coat pocket. "A man who loses the rim of an ear leaves that. Who in this village froze an ear on the pass?"

Nobody spoke. A goat bell clanked in the pen. Rohan had asked a great many yards a great many questions, and he knew the quiet of people with nothing to tell. This was another kind. It was a village looking at its boots.

"Captain," said the guide.

He turned.

"Half this village has lost something to that pass." She did not gesture, and she did not raise her voice. "Hakam there has three fingers. The woman beside him buried her husband in the autumn, and he never came down to be buried. My mother died of the grey cough ten winters ago, because the medicine stood on the wrong side of your law. If you want ears, you'll need a bigger rope."

"The law does not choose who it stops."

"No," she said. "That's what's wrong with it."

"Open the gate and the grain men and the regent's riders use it as well as your sick. A gate has one lock."

"Then make a better lock. Don't leave a village on the wrong side of it."

He had made that argument himself, in a council room, and it had seemed enough. Out here, with a woman's breath smoking before him, it sounded like what it was: a man explaining a noose to the people it hung.

She had not answered his question. She had set a bigger one in front of it, and every person in the yard had let her. Rohan marked that, and put it aside. He had one pass to cross.

"Your name," he said to her.

"You called me Guide in there. You said it as if you'd checked it." One corner of her mouth lifted and went flat again. "I'd keep it. It's the one you can prove."

He could have pressed. A warden had the right. But a name given under a writ was a name entered somewhere, and he found he did not want hers by force, not yet. He noted the refusal beside the other things she had not answered.

"Jassi," he said. "You will take my party over the Saddle at first light."

Jassi had stood through the whole exchange with his hay fork upright like a flag. "No," he said.

The corporal's hand moved. Rohan lifted two fingers and it stopped.

"I don't cross without my second," Jassi said. He had gone grey around the mouth. "That's how it's done in this house. Ask anyone."

"Who is your second?"

Jassi's eyes slid sideways, and he did not manage to stop them.

"I am," said the woman.

"No." Rohan said it before he had thought it through, and then he gave the reason, because he had one. "A guide who argues with a warden before her whole village will argue with him on the ice. Or she will lie to him there. I have no use for either."

"I've argued with you in front of everyone," she said, "and I haven't told you one false word. Count them. Then tell me who else walks the Long Saddle in winter. Name him."

He didn't. There was no one. The wardens had hanged the ones they caught and the rest had learned to be somebody else. If he took Jassi and left her, Jassi would stay in the yard. If he took Jassi in chains, a bound pair needed a willing hand on the other end of the rope. And a guide who would not lie to his face was a rarer thing than a guide who knew the mountain. He had hunted this village three winters and had not met one.

"Cross with a captain who hangs smugglers," he said, "and you may not come back."

"Neither might he." She nodded at Jassi. "He's forty. His knees are as old as your law. He'll walk the Saddle with a stranger over my dead body, Captain, and that's the plain arithmetic."

Jassi muttered something about his knees. She did not look at him.

Rohan studied her. He did not like that she wanted to go. He liked less that he understood why. An old man, a killing pass, and a person who would rather walk beside him than let him walk it alone. He knew that sum. He had done it for Dilan, and the answer had come out as a rope end in his pocket.

"Jassi crosses with me," he said. "My lieutenant takes the second. Each pair watches the other's guide. If either guide turns for the lowlands, I still have the other."

"Fair," said the guide. Her mouth moved, a count of something, and then she added, "Captain."

She had said the word twice already, and both times it had been a blade. This time it sounded less like respect than like a name written down so it would not be lost.

*

Varun was in the mill billet, sitting on an upturned bucket with a rag and a lamp, rubbing at his coat.

"Captain-ji." He looked up with the warm, lopsided smile that had got him through the officers' mess and ten years of Rohan's temper. "You've the look of a man who found rope."

"I found rope."

"They'll hang us with theirs one day." Varun held up the coat. On the front, in a row of pewter buttons dulled by weather, sat one of brass. Cheap, bright, wrong, its shank still stiff. "Don't say it. I know. Lost one on the stair this morning. A pedlar had this in his tray, and the quartermaster's stores are two weeks away. It matches nothing and it offends me."

"It offends the regulation," Rohan said.

"I am the regulation's last friend." He breathed on the brass and polished it against his sleeve. Varun had once made a recruit unpick a seam for being a finger-width off. It was why Rohan trusted him. A man who cared that much about buttons did not cut corners with lives.

"While you were pulling up floors," Varun said, "I walked both approaches to the Saddle. The face has a cornice you could hang a cow from. The gully is longer and ugly, but it sits out of the wind. I've chosen the gully. Safer."

"The guides will have a view."

"The guides will have a view of the face, because it's shorter and they're proud. I walked it in summer, sir. I know what's under that snow."

Rohan thought of the cornice, and of his own twenty days, and found nothing to object to. "The gully," he said. "Tell the guides at first light."

"Captain-ji." Varun went back to his button.

*

The fine for Puja's house was eighteen silver, and the notice had been nailed to her door since the last sweep.

Rohan had read it that morning, passing. Salt found in a lean-to, a dead husband's stock, taken and sold. The Closing Law allowed the crown to take the goods and the fine, or the house in place of the fine. After nightfall the village was quiet except for coughing behind shutters and a dog complaining about the cold. He walked down the lane alone, without a lamp, and knocked once.

She was small, grey-haired and sharp-boned, and she opened the door the width of her face.

"Captain." Her voice did not shake. "The fine is due at the next sweep. I've not forgotten it."

"No." He held out the purse. It was a plain leather one, heavier than he liked, and he had counted it twice at the billet. "Eighteen. Pay it to the corporal's clerk when we have gone. Say it came from a cousin."

She did not take it. Her eyes went from the purse to his face and back, as one reads a price that cannot be right.

"I have no cousin who has eighteen silver."

"Then you have a cousin with a good heart, and you will not tell anyone his name." He put the purse in her hand and closed her fingers over it. "Especially not mine. If the village learns wardens pay fines, the next widow will wait for me instead of for the harvest."

"That's not why you're saying it."

"It is a great part of why."

She was quiet. A cough started in the next house and stopped. "My boy says you hang them for the sport," she said.

"Your boy has not seen it done."

He turned up the lane. The cold took his breath as he went. Halfway to the mill, he felt the look before he saw her.

The salt-house door stood open a hand's breadth, with lamplight behind it. The guide stood in the gap with her arms crossed, awake at that hour and watching him. She had seen him leave Puja's step. He could not tell what she had seen him do.

He might have said something. A smuggler's accomplice knew better than to ask a warden questions, and a warden knew better than to answer them.

He walked past. She let him. Neither of them said a word.

*

It was grey before dawn when he came out into the yard. Frost glazed the cobbles. Jassi was loading the goats by lantern, swearing at each one by name. The thin woman from the pen, the one with the red rope, was going from pack to pack with armfuls of raw fleece, stuffing it under the straps to keep the loads off the animals' backs.

She did it without a word and without looking at him. She kept her face to the work.

Rohan took a pace toward the nearest goat, to check its girth. A tuft of fleece had slipped from under the strap and hung over his wrist, damp and warm from the animal's side. He lifted it, to put it back.

Something dark clung in the grease.

He turned his hand to the lantern. A single grain, smaller than a sesame seed, rust-red against the yellow wool. He rubbed it between thumb and finger. It crushed to powder and left a stain on his skin, and when he raised his fingers to his face, the smell was bitter and resinous, and he knew it at once. Every warden post kept a pot of it for the winter coughs.

Across the yard the ropemaker bent over the next pack with her back to him, humming a knot-count under her breath.

Rohan did not look at the stalls below the salt house, or at the stair, or at the guide, who was just coming through the doorway with a coil of red rope on her shoulder. He folded the tuft of fleece back under the strap, rubbed his fingers once more against his palm, and put what was left of the powder in his pocket.

By the letter of the Closing Law, a warden who knew of a load and let it cross was harbouring it, and the rope was the same for a captain as for a goatherd. He had written no report and would write none. But the powder was going where the Fox's crew was going, and the Fox was the one name his sealed orders gave him. If he followed the medicine, it might lead him to the hand behind it.

Then he went to find his lieutenant, and said nothing.

Chapter 3

The Second Slide

The gully was wrong, and Meera had known it since the first step.

She stopped at the lip of the upper bowl and put her glove flat on the snow. It sat hard on top and hollow beneath, like a drum skin stretched over nothing. She pressed down. A hand's depth of crust held, then sank with a soft, sick sigh.

"Wind slab," she said.

"Say it so a warden can follow," said Rohan, a pace behind her.

"Last night's wind blew snow off the face and dumped it here. It's lying on old snow that doesn't want to hold it." She pointed up the bowl at the long, smooth shoulder above them. "Your lieutenant says the gully is out of the wind. It is. That's why the wind put everything it was carrying in here."

Rohan studied the slope as if he were reading it aloud in his head.

"Varun walked it in summer," he said.

"In summer it was rock."

"The face has a cornice."

"The face has a cornice I can see. This has a cornice I can't." She heard her own voice go flat and made it flatter. "We cross singly, thirty paces apart, no stopping, no shouting. Then we're under the rock band and it's the cairn by dusk."

"We cross as you say," said Rohan. "I do not turn back on a guess."

"It's not a guess."

"Then tell me what it is, and I will weigh it."

That was fair, which annoyed her. She had no number for it. She had a feeling in the soles of her feet and ten winters of being right at the wrong moment.

"Odds," she said. "One in four it slides today. If it does, we lose whoever's under it."

"One in four." He nodded slowly, as if she had given him a price. "And the face?"

"One in three. The cornice is real." She hated saying it. "Your lieutenant picked the lesser killer. I just don't like either."

"Then we go the way I can defend," said Rohan, and went to find his lieutenant.

Meera stayed at the lip, flexing her cold hands. Behind her the goats came up in a string, five of them, bells knocking. Jassi walked at their head with his breath smoking and his hood pushed back, because he hated it over his ears.

He dropped back to walk beside her. He did that on a bad slope. He never said why.

"Pull your hood up," she said.

"I can't hear the goats."

"You can hear them in your sleep." She fished in her coat, found the spare mitten liners she had stitched in autumn, and shoved them at his chest. "Wear these under the gloves. Your hands were blue at the last halt, and don't tell me it's your age."

"It's my age." But he put them on, and his face loosened as the wool warmed him. "My sister has apricot trees. Did I tell you?"

"Twice a day for six winters."

"Forty trees. They bloom white, in the third week of spring, and you sit under them and the petals get in your tea." He grinned. "Badami will like it. She's too old for this run, so I left her in the pen. She'll walk the whole orchard like she owns it. She'll eat the fallen fruit and be sick, and she'll deserve it."

"Badami has your bell?"

"She has her own. This one's from her kid days." He pulled a small, dented brass bell on a thong out of his collar, and it gave a tinny little clunk. "I take it for luck. When I'm done, she goes to the orchard with me, and so does this. Retired. Both of us."

"After this one."

"After this one." He tucked the bell away, slapped her shoulder and went forward, calling to Sheriff in a voice of deep personal grievance.

Meera watched him go. She counted the goats, because she counted everything. Five. Jassi made six on the slope.

*

They crossed the bowl as she had said, one at a time.

Jassi went first with the goats, a dark string on white. Then Meera. Rohan was to hold thirty paces behind her, and Varun thirty behind him.

At the halfway mark she glanced back, as she always did, to check her spacing. Rohan was not thirty paces off. He was ten, and coming on, his eyes on the slope above and not on his feet, one hand pressed to his side. When she looked again, he was eight.

She opened her mouth to snap at him. Then she shut it, because shouting on that slab was stupid, and turned her face to the rock band. She resented every step he gained. Her rule was her rule. He was a warden who had never once been told what to do by a smuggler, and he had decided that on this slope he would stay close.

Behind them, far down the line, Varun's voice carried up, easy and unhurried. "Captain-ji! Strap's gone on my pack. Go on, I'll catch you."

"Quickly," Rohan called back, from only a few paces behind her.

"Quickly, sir."

The rock band was forty paces ahead, where the snow thinned and the slope stopped being a drum. Jassi was nearly there. His bells made a thin bright clatter. Her breath came in short counts. Twenty-nine. Thirty.

Behind her, down the line, iron struck.

Not a probe in snow. A clean, bright ring, metal on rock, once. A hammer's note, or an ice-pick set against stone.

Then, above her, the whole slope answered.

The sound was a crack like a rifle shot, long and flat, running away across the bowl. It travelled under her boots first and hit her knees. The drum skin tore open from one side to the other.

"Down!" she screamed. "Jassi, leave them, come!"

Jassi turned. His face was small and white at thirty paces, and he lifted his hand. Then the shoulder of the mountain slid down onto him and the goats, and there was no bowl and no Jassi, only a roaring wall of white.

A hand fisted in the back of her coat and she left the ground.

He had run the last of the gap. She understood that later, when she could think. Then she only flew, and had time to think, with great clearness, that she was being thrown. Her shoulder struck rock and she was in a hollow behind a boulder as big as a cart, and something heavy came down across the world.

The first slide poured over the boulder and went on. It was loud. The second was quiet, and worse. The snow came in a long dense roll, like a wet fleece pulled over a face, and over her head rose a sound that was a man taking it across the back.

Then there was no sound at all.

She lay with her cheek against stone, in the small dark of the lee, with a pocket of air no bigger than her two fists around her mouth. She counted. One. Two. She got to forty before her hands moved. Then she dug, clawing up through snow packed like wet clay, until her fingers broke into cold light and she dragged herself out onto the surface.

The bowl was gone. In its place lay a field of broken white blocks, some as big as doors, steaming faintly in the sun. A single goat bell rang somewhere under it, then quit.

Rohan lay half across the boulder's flank, buried to the shoulders, one arm flung out.

She went to him on her knees.

*

He was breathing. That was the first count she took, and it held her up.

His eyes opened when she cleared his mouth. They found her face, and he said in a thin, careful voice, "Guide. Are you hurt?"

"No."

"Good." He drew in a breath, and his whole face closed on it. "Then I would be grateful if you stopped looking at me and dug for the others."

She did.

Meera dug until her gloves were wet through, and then she dug without them. The wardens' iron probes were in the slide with the goats, so she used her bare hands and a flat piece of stone, and Rohan used his good arm and swore in the cold, formal way of a man who disliked swearing. She called Jassi's name until her voice cracked. After that she called it quietly, at the places where the snow had a certain give.

Rohan worked at the other end of the field. He had found the place where his lieutenant dropped back, a flat patch beside a rock where a pack strap would be mended. He dug there until the light turned yellow.

"There's nothing," he said. "No pack, no print, no cloth. The slide came through here and took the line."

"The line goes down. He would have been taken down the bowl."

"Yes." Rohan stood a while with his good hand pressed to his side. "We dug the bowl. We have dug everything below."

"Then he's deeper," Meera said, because there was nothing else to say. She did not look at his face. He had walked beside the man for years.

The sun was down behind the ridge when her stone hit cloth.

She knew it by the colour. A strip of wool, goat-brown, dyed with walnut husk. Bindu's weave.

Her hands did the rest. They uncovered a sleeve, a shoulder, the hood Jassi had hated. She cleared his face, and it was calm. The snow had packed his nose and mouth, and nothing else had touched him. Beside him lay Pomegranate and Auntie, both dead, still harnessed. Nothing had found the other three.

His right hand was shut.

She had to work the fingers open singly. They were stiff and still warm in the middle. In the palm lay a small dented brass bell on a broken thong, its clapper wedged with snow.

Badami's kid bell.

Meera sat back on her heels.

She had thought she would shout. She had thought something in her would break open, and instead it went quiet, like a lamp turned down. Six on the slope. Six, and Bindu singing, and the orchard in the third week of spring. Forty trees.

"Guide," Rohan said, behind her. He did not touch her. He stood a careful distance off, one hand pressed to his ribs.

"Don't."

"I only—"

"I know what you only." She cleaned the bell with her thumb, set it in her coat against the note from Ranu, and buttoned the flap over both. Her hands shook so that the button took three tries. "He wanted to retire. After this one. He said it every crossing for six winters."

Rohan said nothing, and she was grateful, a little, in a hard, ungenerous way.

She made herself get up. First she put her hands into her pack, under the rope and the sattu, to the bottom, where the oilcloth roll lay as heavy and square as a loaf. She had pulled it from the fleece under the goat straps at the last halt, because she trusted no animal on a bad slope. Now she closed her fingers on the folds. Three rows of four. Twelve packets, dry. She did not look at Rohan while she did it.

The redbark was safe. Jassi was dead. She stood in the blue dusk with her brother's medicine in one hand and an old man's bell against her chest, and she could not make the two numbers come out the same.

*

"Your mountain," said Rohan.

He had lowered himself onto a rock, and the way he did it, one slow inch at a time, told her what the slide had done. A hand held his side. Grey showed round his mouth.

"Ribs?" she said.

"Some. I have had worse."

"Breathe in."

He did. It stopped halfway, and he waited, and let it out in small pieces.

"Two cracked at least," she said. "Maybe three. Don't lift your left arm over your shoulder."

"I will not."

"You'll try."

"Yes." The corner of his mouth moved, and it hurt him, so he stopped. "Your mountain, Guide. I am a captain on someone else's ground, and I have lost my lieutenant, and the line behind us is under forty feet of snow." He nodded at the bowl, where the gully they had climbed was now a slope of white blocks with no mark of any path. "There is no way back that I can see. Give the orders. I will follow them."

She looked at him, waiting for the catch, the clause, the warden's hook under it. She found none.

"Leave your spear," she said.

He unslung it and laid it on the snow.

"Leave the tent poles. They're two pounds of nothing."

He did.

"Walk in my steps. Not near them, in them. Where I put a foot, you put a foot, and if I stop you stop and don't ask why."

"Understood."

"And you stay behind me. Not at my heels. Where I told you, this morning."

"Where you told me," he said, "I would have been under the snow with the rest."

She had no answer to that. "No talking until the rock band. Wind carries it and I want to hear the slope."

He nodded once and got to his feet by the long way round, with a small hiss through his teeth. He took each order the way a man takes a wage, quietly and in full, all the way up the last of the gully, and never once raised his voice or his eyebrow. She kept glancing back for the catch. It never came.

The rock band came and went. Beyond it the ground flattened, and the wind changed, and at a turn of the ridge, with the stars coming out like salt on slate, the cairn stood waiting.

*

It was a chest-high ring of flat grey stones, no wider than a threshing floor. A low note ran through it, the hum of the wind in its cracks, the sound the spirits made when they were listening.

Meera stepped over the lowest course and felt the hum fold round her ankles. Rohan stopped at the edge.

"One rope, one pair, until meltwater runs at this cairn," he said slowly, in the voice of a man quoting a text. "Our post archive says as much. It is thin on the rest."

"The rest is short." She unslung the rope. "Behind us the approach is buried. In front of us is the pass, and the Long Saddle in winter is a lie without a line to follow. Nobody crosses alone. A single person loses the path inside an hour, and then the mountain takes them." She let out the red coil in her hands, eight arm-spans of madder-dyed wool, soft as a sleeve. "It takes a pair, with this. Both ends. Both names."

Rohan looked at the rope. He did not look like a man who loved it. He looked like a man who had hanged people for owning one.

"If I refuse, I stand here alone."

"If you refuse, you stand here until the cold finishes. I'll go on and I won't be able to stop." She said it flatly because it was the truth. Not a threat, a count. "I'm not asking you to like it. I'm saying it's the only road with both of us alive at the end."

"And the medicine in your pack?"

She stopped.

The question was quiet, light as a cough. For a moment she heard only the hum. Then her mind ran the sum fast and cold. He knew. He had said it with her pack on her back and the whole mountain empty around them, and he had not seized it, not in the yard and not on the slope, where he could have taken it from a woman too tired to fight. A warden who knew and did nothing was a warden who wanted something, or had already chosen. She could not tell which. She could not even tell when he had learned it.

Answering would tell him what it was for. Silence told him she had heard. Either way, he now knew what she carried, and she knew he knew.

Silence was free. She had learned that at six winters old, from a mother who kept the family's every secret in her teeth. She took it. It cost her the one thing she had wanted to keep, which was that he did not know she was hiding anything.

"Give me your left wrist," she said.

He held it out, bare, the glove stripped off. The bones were fine and the pulse jumped at the thumb. She looped the red wool twice and tied the knot Bindu sang. Two over, one under, the third one tells the truth. The wool was already warm from her hands.

"Now yours," she said.

His fingers were steady, despite the ribs. He tied the knot precisely, slowly, with the look of someone writing a signature. His thumb brushed the inside of her wrist when he pulled it snug, and neither of them moved.

"The name and where you're going," she said. "To the stones. Say it as if you mean it."

She went first, because she had to. She faced the ring and spoke into the hum.

"Meera. Ranu."

Rohan turned toward the stones.

"Rohan," he said. "Garh Neshar."

For a breath nothing happened. Then the low hum rose through the cairn, climbing, until it tightened into a clear singing note. Pale light

began to seep from between the stones, thin and blue as ice at the edge of a lake. It lifted off the cairn in threads. It ran out from the ring along the ground, a faint line of cold fire, and where it went the snow showed a path she had only seen in the dark of her own head.

The winter line. The mountain's road. It stretched out ahead of them, bright, and went up.

Rohan stared at it. He had gone very still.

"I have seen a hundred cairns," he said. "I have never seen one light."

"You never stood in one tied to a smuggler," said Meera.

He turned to look at her. In the blue light the lines of his face were hard and tired, and the bruise along his jaw had already started to come up. He was the man who hunted the Salt Fox, and she was the Salt Fox. He would hang her at the thaw if he ever put the two together. She was on a rope with him, and she owed him her life, and the rope would not let her step beyond eight arm-spans from his side.

"Why Ranu?" he said. "You gave the stones that name. I want to know why."

She could have said nothing. It was free. She could have said *I'm a guide, and a guide takes the work that's offered*, and let the cairn listen for a lie and ring.

She held the bell through her coat, a hard small lump over her heart.

"Because my brother is dying there," she said.

The stones did not ring. The hum went on, steady and low, and then it dropped half a note, the way a bowl's song falls when a wet finger leaves the rim.

It was the first true thing she had given him for nothing. Nothing in the world would take it back.

Chapter 4

Watch My Hands

"There are three rules," Meera said. "Count them, because I won't say them twice."

She walked ahead along the winter line with the red slack looped between them. The blue light ran at her heels like a stream, and it lit nothing else. Rohan kept his boots in her prints. Every third step his left side told him what the slide had done to it.

"One is distance," she said. "Eight arm-spans of rope. The rope is the measure, whether it's on your wrist or in my pack. Go past it and the heat leaves you fast. Both of us, at once. Go twice as far and the line goes out, and the mountain keeps whoever is standing there."

"And if the rope is untied?"

"Untie it to sleep, to wash, to climb. The distance still holds. Cut it, burn it, it makes no difference. It lasts until meltwater runs at the cairn where we tied it."

"The thaw."

"The thaw." She did not turn. "Two is lies. Any lie you tell the one on the other end of this costs you heat. A lie is something you believe is false, said so that you'll be believed. The size is how much the truth would change what I do next."

"And the price?"

"Small, your fingertips go white for an hour. Middling, frostnip and a night of shaking. Great, you lose what freezes." She stopped there. He noted where. "Fire won't warm it. Only time does."

"A lie about life or death?"

"Kills the liar. And a promise made on this rope is a contract. Break it while we're bound and it strikes you like a great lie." She said it as flatly as she had said the odds on the gully. "Three is what's free. Silence. Refusing to answer. A joke we both know is a joke. Anything you say to someone who isn't on this rope. And the truth, which is the cheapest thing on the mountain and the one nobody wants to buy."

Rohan walked a while. Under his boots the snow squeaked, dry and fine.

"I would like to see it," he said.

"You would." She stopped and faced him. "You don't trust a rule till you've seen the bill."

She pulled off her right glove with her teeth and held the hand out into the blue light, palm up. It was a worker's hand, scarred across the knuckles and cracked at the thumb. The fingertips were pink.

"Jassi hated those goats," she said.

Rohan had heard the old man in the yard that morning, cursing every animal he loaded. He had no way to know what lay beneath the curses. For the space of a breath he believed it, which was what the sentence was built to do.

Then the white came. It rose from the tips of her fingers like frost on a window and took the nails, bloodless as candle wax. She watched it climb with a face that gave him nothing.

A moment later her face gave him something. Her mouth went crooked, and she looked away up the line.

"He named every one," she said. "Sheriff. Magistrate. Judge. He talked to them like a bench and then complained when they wouldn't mind him."

Rohan, who had sat on benches, said nothing.

"That's a small one," she said, her voice almost level. "An hour. You'll see the white go. Then you'll know I'm not showing you a trick."

"Why that lie?"

"Because you'd believe it. It has to be believed or it isn't one."

"I am sorry for him."

"Don't be sorry. Carry something." She pulled the glove back on over the white. "You've been breathing like a leaking bellows since the rock band. If you're going to be of any use, be of use."

*

She stopped on a flat of wind-packed snow and unslung the pack. Rohan lowered himself to one knee, a thing his ribs allowed in stages, and took the sattu, the spare liners, and the coil of thin line. Those she let him have. Then she dug to the bottom for the oilcloth roll and her hands slowed.

"Give it here," he said. "My legs are sound, and the right arm is the better one."

"It's mine."

"It is a third of the weight in this pack, Guide. I am not asking whose."

She held it a moment longer and then let it go. It was heavier than it looked, and a corner of the oilcloth gave under his thumb. He did not mean to open it. The fold came away on its own, and the blue light fell across what lay inside.

Three rows of four. Small packets, waxed paper tied with thread, each the size of a man's palm. A rust-red dust had worked through one seam. The smell was bitter and resinous. It was the smell on the grain he had crushed between his fingers in the salt-house yard.

Twelve. He counted without wanting to.

"What is this?" he said, though he knew.

"Medicine." She did not hesitate, and he watched her hands as she said it. The fingertips were already white, and he saw what that meant.

For this hour they could not testify to anything. She could say what she liked, and her body would keep no record.

He noted that she had to know it. He noted that she answered anyway.

"Redbark. For the grey cough, in Ranu," she said. "Forty-one sick there. Nine of them under ten. Six already buried. That's from a note I carry, and I've no reason to doubt the man who wrote it." She met his eyes. "They're not for sale, and not for the Guild. And they are not for you. I will walk off this mountain before you take them."

"At eight arm-spans, I would be walking with you."

"I've done the arithmetic."

It was nearly a joke. Perhaps it was one. She did not smile.

"The law is plain," Rohan said. His voice came out as it did in council, which he disliked. "A load carried over a closed pass is seized where it is found. The carrier answers to the rope. At the thaw, if I am to be exact. I will not say otherwise to you because you can hear me say it."

"Then arrest me at the thaw, Captain." Her chin lifted. "Today you carry half."

She was right. That was the part he could not get around. He had a lapis seal in his coat, a deadline, and a broken side, and the only road to the first lay through a woman who wanted the second dead. He could hold the law up in front of her like a lamp. It would not carry him one step along the line.

He had also seen the gully go. He did not intend to forget what it had taken, or how the first order of the night had come from her mouth and the second from his.

"Are you the Salt Fox?" he said.

Her face did not change. The rope lay slack on the snow. She stood in the blue light, perfectly still, and said nothing at all.

It cost her nothing. That was the thing. Silence was free, she had told him so herself, and he had just been given a demonstration of how free.

"Silence is an answer, Guide," Rohan said. "Watch my hands, and I will watch yours."

He meant it to land as a threat, and it did. She had the grace to let him see it hit.

"Mine are white," she said.

"For the hour."

"Then you've an hour's grace." She turned her back on him and shouldered the empty pack. "Count the packets into your coat, Captain. I'll show you where the seam is dry."

Rohan counted six into the inside of his coat, below the collar where the queen's seal lay sewn in its seam, and he did not look at her while he did it. He was a warden holding contraband. That was evidence, in custody, carried in the open by the proper officer, chain unbroken. He built that story with great care and could see through it at once.

The truth stood plainer. The Closing Law gave no word for a man who carried a smuggler's medicine across a closed pass for her. It had one word for a man who sheltered, fed or aided an unlawful crosser, and the rope for that word was the same length as hers.

He had walked into it with his eyes open and a broken side. He did not feel noble about it. He felt the way a man feels at the edge of a frozen river, having decided the ice will hold.

*

They went on in the blue light. The wind came in long, patient pushes off the Saddle, and the ridge on their left stood against the stars like a row of broken teeth.

"I'll bet you," Meera said, "that you can't keep your mouth shut for an hour."

It was the first thing she had said in some time. Rohan said nothing, which was his answer.

"My mouth is generally shut, you'll say."

He said nothing.

"Name the stake, then. I'll name it. The sattu at the next halt. Winner eats the loser's share."

He nodded once.

"That's a yes. That counts as a yes." She seemed pleased to have caught him at it. "Your hour starts when I say, and I say now."

He walked.

She began with the weather, and the state of his boots, and the vanity of lowland cloth. She counted aloud in fours and fives, and then in a language of her own, a sing-song of knot-numbers that ended on a rising note as if it were a question. She asked what a warden did for supper. She asked whether he'd ever been laughed at. She asked, with some skill, whether it was true that wardens' wives only married men they could outrank in the dark. The snow squeaked, and Rohan gave her nothing.

Three winters he had spent not answering the questions of smugglers' wives and the families of the hanged. He had stood in the doorways of widows. A woman talking at him on a mountain, with the wind for company, was nearly restful.

At the start, the fingers of her right glove had no colour in them. By the middle of the hour she took the hand out and flexed it, and he saw the nails had gone from wax to the pale of a tea-rose. The white was leaving.

She talked on. After a time she stopped asking things and only talked, about the knots Bindu sang, and the way goats looked at weather, and a lowland middleman who sold her bad lamp oil. Her voice had a drive in it. It was not quite a joke, and the jokes had thinned out of it a while ago.

Somewhere past the middle of the hour, he understood that she was not playing to win. She was keeping her mouth full of noise so that the quiet could not get in. He did not stop her. It seemed to him a poor use of his silence to spend it on something she needed more.

When her fingertips were pink again, as plain as the day she was born, he said, "The hour is done."

She stared at him. Then she stared at her own hand, and then at the sky, as if the stars might be called to appeal.

"You could have *twitched*," she said.

"I am not given to it."

"I called you a stone with a hat on."

"You did. It was well put."

"I hate this." She shook the red slack in disgust. "That's three hundred winters of rope-craft and I lose the first wager to a man who'd rather be a post."

"The sattu, Guide."

"Yours is on the way," she said between her teeth, and he saw her struggle with the shape of a smile and lose. He had won a ration and a small, ridiculous victory, and for some reason it did not feel like either.

"I will collect it at the halt," he said, with very great gravity.

She made a sound that might have been laughter if it had not been shaken with something else. She turned her face from him, and he let her.

*

Near the end of the night the line brought them to a waystone.

It stood at the foot of the climb to the Long Saddle, a squat grey pillar as tall as a child, furred with lichen on its north side. At its base lay a shelf of flat stones left by earlier crossers. Beyond it the ground rose, white and long, toward a sky going from black to the colour of iron.

Meera slowed. The rope between them drew, and then slackened as he came up beside her.

She did not speak. She went down on her heels at the foot of the waystone and began to choose stones. She took three off the shelf, each flat as a hand, and set the first on the packed snow in front of her. She set the second across it. She worked as he had seen her work on the ice, exact and without wasted motion, and he realised she was building something that would have to stand.

"Forty winters," she said to the stones. "Ten of them with me on the Saddle. Seven goats in his time, and the last five of them the best." She laid the third stone on the pile. Her voice was nearly steady. "He said he was retiring."

That was all. She did not weep. She took the dented bell out of her coat, looked at it, and put it back.

Rohan stood a pace behind her. He had known the man two days. He had stood in the yard and heard him say *no* to the Crown's captain with a hay fork in his hand, and he had seen him laugh once, over a goat. He had not liked him particularly, and the loss ran through him all the same, the plain cold fact of a man who had been walking in the dark and was not.

Dilan had no cairn. They had brought what the ice gave up to the post and buried it in a wardens' row, and there was no mountain stone over it. There was a rope end in the lining of Rohan's coat, cut clean, that he had never put down.

He peeled the glove from his right hand.

The cold took his fingers at once, the wind getting into every joint. He chose a stone from the shelf, a small grey one worn smooth by someone else's hand, and bent over her shoulder, ribs and all, and set it on the top.

It sat. He did not take his hand away at once.

Meera did not look up. She was watching his fingers where they rested on the stone, bare in the thin light. They were reddening, and they were steady.

He let her.

Chapter 5

Two Brothers in Arms

The carving was on the waystone's east face, and Meera found it because she was looking for somewhere to put her hand.

Her knees had gone loose after the third stone of Jassi's cairn. She reached out to the pillar to stand, and her glove slid over a groove, then another. She wiped the lichen with her sleeve. The dawn was grey and dull, with no blue left in it.

Two hands. Worn nearly smooth by three hundred winters of wind, but she knew them. One rope went around both wrists in a figure of eight, and the knot sat between them like a third thing.

She had seen the same carving on the inner face of the Shilak Cairn since she was a child. She had never seen it on a waystone.

Under her palm the stone gave off a faint hum, the sound of wind in a hollow. Old cairns did that near a bound pair. It was one more thing the crews knew and nobody had written down. The stones hummed when a pair lay near them, and they hummed higher when one of the pair lied. They never said which one.

"Captain," she said. "Come here and tell me I'm tired."

He came, slowly, a hand at his side. He stood over her shoulder and she heard him breathe in short, careful sips. He was silent so long she looked up.

"'Two brothers in arms,'" said Rohan, in the voice he used for texts. "'They crossed the closed pass bound by one rope, and the pass has

stood open to the faithful ever since.' It is in the first chronicle of the Shilak post. Every post child learns it."

"Brothers."

"In arms. A phrase of the time. It means comrades of the sword."

"Then the crews have it wrong." She sat back on her heels. "We tell it as a warden and a smuggler. One of each, tied together because neither of them could do it alone. My grandmother told it that way. Bindu sings it that way."

"A smuggler's song."

"A warden's book." She waved her glove at the carving. "Both of them written by people who weren't there."

"Mine was written at the time."

"By the crown, which wanted two brothers and a sword. Mine was kept by the people who needed it to be true." She heard herself and nearly smiled. "You've no more proof than I have."

Rohan crouched, an inch at a time, and studied the rope in the stone. "The hands are worn too smooth to tell apart," he said. "No rank. No sword." He moved his glove along the lower hand. "This one has a cut across the knuckles. Or the stone does."

"Or the carver did it for a reason."

"Or the weather did."

"Or it's a smuggler's scar," she said, "and a warden's book left it out."

"A fine theory, with no evidence."

"And yours has a chronicle and no hands." She looked at the carving, and then, to her annoyance, at him. "If it were your book, would you want the first crossing to be a crime?"

He did not answer at once. Silence was free, and he had made good use of it all night.

"No," he said at last. "I would not."

"Then we're both telling it the way we need it." She got up. "Neither of us can prove a thing. I'll take that over a lie."

*

"The pitch," said Rohan, when she was looking for a lee. "Before we sleep I should like to see the first of the climb. If it is scoured, we move at dusk. If it is corniced, we must plan."

"It's scoured. Wind takes this slope first."

"You spoke of the rock band. The pitch above it is the part I cannot judge from here."

She had mentioned the band once, hours ago, in passing. She suspected he had simply listened to everything she said and kept it. "Look from here."

"The shoulder hides it." He was already moving. "Twenty paces. I will be back before you have found a hollow."

They had untied the wrist knots at the stone, as the rope allowed, and coiled the red length between them. He took his end up in his right hand, looping it through his belt, as a warden would. She had her back to him, scraping the shelf for dung cakes. She counted, because she counted everything. Six cakes. Seven.

"Guide."

His voice had changed.

She turned. He had gone up the slope to where the ridge bent, and he stood very straight, as men do when they are working not to fall. The rope ran from his belt out across the snow and lay taut as a bowstring in front of her boots. He had walked it out to the last span, and then one step more, because the shoulder had not shown him what he wanted.

The cold arrived in her chest before she understood it. It went into her like water through a seam. Her teeth ached. Her fingers lost their heat, and the breath left her mouth in one long smoke. She had felt it once before, fourteen winters back, the winter she was fifteen, on her first bound crossing with her mother. She had gone back for a dropped mitten, a few paces past the rope's length, and her mother had screamed.

"Back," she said. "Captain, now."

"I am attempting—"

"You're not attempting anything."

She dropped the dung and took the rope in both hands. She leaned back and hauled, hand over hand, the red wool running wet and heavy through her gloves, and he came down the slope at her pace, not his. He lost his footing once. The rope bit her palms. She hauled him the last three paces like a sack onto a bank, and when he was within a span of her, and then a step, the cold went out of her as if a door had been shut on it.

Bent over with her hands on her knees, she shook.

"I did not know," Rohan said. His face was pale and wet. "It was nowhere near—"

"It was eight spans. I told you eight." She straightened. "You wanted to see for yourself. That's what you do. That's all right on the plain, where nothing minds if you're wrong. Here it'll cost you your feet."

"It cost you too."

"Yes."

"I am sorry."

"Don't be sorry." She wound the slack round her fist. It took three tries, because her hand was not steady. "Listen. You walk where the rope lets you. If you need to see something, you ask me and I'll tell you or I'll go. Your body's not yours to spend on a look, Captain. It's mine. It's mine to keep alive until the thaw, and you're not going to make that harder."

He did not look away. In the grey light his eyes were the colour of wet slate, and they did not drop.

"Yours," he said, "and mine to keep in turn, I suppose."

She had not thought of that. She opened her mouth and nothing came out.

"I will ask," said Rohan.

*

The shelf at the waystone held more than stones. There was a nest of old dung cakes under the lowest slab, the kind goat-crews left for the next crossers, dry as bread and grey with age. Meera knew it was there. Every

guide on the pass did. It was the oldest law of the mountain, older than the crown's, and no one had ever written it down.

She built the fire in the lee of the pillar on a bed of flat stones, with a ring of snow blocks to turn the wind. Seven cakes, a little juniper bark from her pocket, a spark from the flint. The smoke rose thin and sour. The flame took hold, small and orange, and she held her hands to it and nearly cried at how little it was.

Rohan stood a good way off with his arms crossed.

"This is harbouring," he said.

"Mm."

"A fire shared with an unlawful crosser. By the letter of the Closing Law, I am to report you, seize your goods and carry you to the post. The penalty for a warden who fails to do so is the same as the penalty for you."

"Yes."

"I wish it understood that I know." He looked at the flame, not at her. "The packets I could still call evidence in custody. It was a poor story, but it was a story. A shared fire has none. There is nothing I could tell the post."

"Then it's understood." She fed in a cake. "Your wish is noted. You're letting the heat out."

He stood a moment longer, in his torn coat, with the queen's seal sewn in his collar and six packets of redbark in his pocket. Then he sat down at her fire, by the long way round, and held out his right hand to the flame.

He did not say anything else. Neither did she. A man who had hanged people for this should be allowed a minute.

She melted snow in the tin cup. She mixed the sattu in two portions, set one in front of him, then pushed the other across as well.

"What is this?"

"Your wager. Winner eats the loser's share." She nudged the cup closer. "I'm to go hungry. Eat it."

"I would not take a woman's ration."

"It's a bet, Captain. A bet's the only thing on this mountain I don't resent paying."

He looked at her for a long time. Then he took the second cup, and with some gravity, drank half of it and handed the rest back.

"The winning is enough," he said. "The surplus I decline."

She took it before he could change his mind and was ashamed of how good it tasted.

*

They slept, in turns, wedged against the stone. By late afternoon the light had thickened. The wind fell, and from between the courses of the waystone a thread of blue began to rise, faint as breath on glass. The line would come back with the dark.

Meera woke with her face against the pillar and a stone's rim pressing her cheek. The fire was down to a glow. Across it sat Rohan, awake, with his legs folded under him and his left shoulder held very still.

She watched him breathe.

The right side of his chest moved. The left barely did, taking short, cautious pulls that stopped halfway, as though a hand were pressing down on the top of them. He took one now and his jaw worked before he let it go.

"You're favouring your left," she said.

"I have a stiff side."

"You have cracked ribs."

"You said it yourself last night. Two, perhaps three." He lifted his chin. "I have had worse. There is nothing to be done for ribs but wait."

"You're breathing like a man listening for footsteps."

"I am a warden."

She let that go. It was a dodge, and dodging cost nothing, so she had no right to complain. She fed the last cake into the fire.

"A question for a question," she said. "Since we're stuck with each other. I ask one, you ask one. Anything you won't answer, you say so, and we both go on. No cost."

He considered. "The rope would not charge us for it."

"It's an old trade. The crews do it on long nights. You'd be surprised what comes out when you're allowed to say no."

"Very well." He settled his hand on his knee. "You first."

She'd had the question since the cairn.

"What's at Garh Neshar?"

"I decline."

"That fast?"

"It is not mine to say." His face was steady. "I will tell you that it matters to more than me. I will tell you that I would tell you if I could. Both are true, and you may watch my hands." He turned them palm up toward the glow. They were red from the fire and nothing else. "My turn."

She waited.

"How many people have you carried across?"

She had expected something about the Salt Fox. This was worse, because it was a count, and she kept a count, and her whole body knew the number.

Refusing would have cost her nothing. He had done it himself, not a minute before.

"Two hundred and six," she said. "Not counting salt."

He did not move.

"That's evidence, Captain. You know that."

"I carry no ink," said Rohan. "And the stones heard you, not me. Is the number correct?"

"Last I counted." She stared into the coals. "I wrote it down. Every one."

"You wrote it down."

"I keep ledgers. You'll laugh."

"I am not laughing."

He wasn't. That surprised her more than anything he had said. She had told a warden she kept books on her crimes, and he looked at her as if she had told him something about herself.

"My turn," she said. "Why do you hunt the crew?"

She thought he would refuse again. She thought she saw him weigh it. The fire popped, and a spark rose up and went out against the dark.

"A warden died on this pass two winters ago," said Rohan.

The words were set down plain, with no weight added.

His quarry was her crew. She heard it as plainly as a rope parting, and dread sank low in her stomach and stayed there.

"He was young. He was chasing a smuggler across the ice in a storm. The report said what the report says. I read it, and I signed it, and I put his name in the book." His hand was closed on his knee, and she saw the knuckles. "I hunted your crew one winter because the law said so. I have hunted it two more for him."

"One for the law," Meera said slowly. "Two for him."

"Yes."

She turned the sum over. Three winters of hunting, and a boy dead for only two of them. A man shaping a lie would have rounded it, made it tidy, given himself the grief from the start. Rohan had given her the gap and let it sit there, to his own discredit.

Something cold touched the back of her neck and was gone. It was the wind. There were many things in two winters. It had been a long one, and she had buried a neighbour in it, and Kiran had come in with an ear that would not heal and a story about a bad crossing. She put the thought down, because she did not have the strength to carry it and the redbark both.

"I'm sorry for him," she said. It was true, and she waited for nothing to happen, and nothing did.

"Thank you." He said it as a man says it when he is not used to being offered the thing. "My turn again, or yours?"

"Mine." She looked at his side. She did not decorate it. "Are your ribs hurt, Captain? Plainly. If one's through, we sit here a day and you lose your Fair. If they're only cracked, we climb at dusk and I bind them. I need the true size of it to choose."

His right hand began to turn over on his knee, palm up, the way it had for Garh Neshar. It stopped halfway.

She watched him do her sum. A refusal now would be an answer, with her price laid out in front of it. A lost day. A lost Fair. Declining would tell her everything he wanted kept.

"It's nothing," he said.

The waystone hummed.

It had been a low sound all day, the sound of wind in a hollow. Now it climbed, a note at a time, as if someone were drawing a bow slowly across it. The blue thread between the courses thickened into light and ran down the pillar to the snow, and the whole fire-ring went the colour of ice.

Rohan did not seem to hear. He reached for his glove on the stone beside him, a plain thing, a man getting ready to travel. He worked it onto his right hand, finger by finger, with the patience of someone whose body is already a long way from comfortable.

Under the cairn-light his fingertips went.

They went white from the nails inward, as hers had, a slow pale creeping up like milk drawn along a wick, and the wool of the glove closed over them before he saw. He tugged the cuff down and stood.

"It will be dark soon," he said. "We should go."

Meera did not answer. She sat by the dying fire with the red rope coiled in her lap. She had seen the white pass the first joint of every finger, and it was the gloved hand she could no longer check. So she counted his breaths instead, short and stopped halfway down.

One. Two. She got to six before he turned his back.

Chapter 6

Taking the Cold

"Are your ribs broken, Captain? Not hurt. Broken."

Meera asked it without turning round, the way she called out a distance. She was three paces up the pitch with the red slack looped between them, and she had stopped to wait for him for the fourth time since midnight.

Rohan had counted the stops. He had also counted the hours of the night they had left, and the days of the twenty, and he had come to a figure he did not like.

The slope above the waystone was scoured to blue ice in places and drifted in others. The blue line had died with the first grey in the east. His left side felt as if a hand were closing slowly on a wet cloth. He had not raised the arm above his shoulder since the slide, and he had gone to some trouble to make that look like choice.

"I saw your fingers last night," she said. "The white. I counted to six and let it go. A small one, I thought, and he's a proud man, and it's no business of mine." She turned then. Her face was raw with wind. "This is my business. If you slow on the Saddle, we lose the day, and Ranu hasn't got days. So I'm asking plainly."

The truth would cost him. She would halt them. She would build a shelter and sit him in it. She would take a day, perhaps two, and he had sixteen left and a regent counting them for him.

He weighed it as he weighed everything. A middling lie would bring frostnip and a night of shaking. He had been cold before. A lost day was a day of the grey cough in Ranu, and that was a debt he could not carry. His hands could pay for the first. Nothing he owned could pay for the second. It was a poor sum, and he knew it, and he did it anyway.

"They are fine," said Rohan.

It was the plainest sentence he had spoken since the cairn, and it was false in every word.

The lie landed. A bite went into his right hand, along the knuckles, as if he had plunged it into a stream in thaw. He looked down. The grey was spreading under the skin, from the second joint toward the wrist, bloodless and patchy. The glove had not hidden it, because the cold was under the glove.

He closed the hand. It did not want to close.

Meera watched him do it. She did not say a word. She pulled off her right glove with her teeth, as she had done for her demonstration, and held out her hand.

"Give me your hand."

"Guide—"

"The right one. Take the glove off."

He did not know what she meant to do. The rules of the rope were hers, and she had recited them, and this had not been one. A man who has just been caught does not argue about terms. He peeled the glove away and put his hand in hers.

Her palm was warm. That was all he understood, for the space of a breath. A rough, dry palm with a callus at the base of the thumb, closing over the back of his hand so that her fingers lay along the grey.

Then the cold left him.

It went out through his skin like a tide drawn off a flat shore. The ache in his knuckles thinned and ran to nothing. Colour came back into the hand in a rush of pins. He saw it go from him into her. It showed as a rime on her fingers, a pallor that crept past her wrist and whitened the nails one by one.

Her face did not change, but her breath did. It went short and flat.

"Middling," she said. "That was a middling lie, Captain."

"What have you done?"

"The loophole." Her teeth had begun to chatter, and she clamped them and spoke through them. "The one who's lied to can take it. Skin to skin. It passes over. The liar keeps their hands, and the other one pays." She let go of him. Her fingers shook so hard that she tucked them into her armpit, and the shaking went on in her shoulders. "I know it was a lie. I know how big. I don't know the truth of it. That's the price of taking it, you see. You can't spare someone and not know they lied."

He stood with his restored hand open in front of him. He had spent three winters hunting smugglers, and two had hanged from the deodar. None of them had ever done him a kindness in return.

"You did not have to," he said.

"No. I could've let you carry it. You'd have had frostnip to the wrist and a night of the shakes, and I'd have had a captain who couldn't hold an axe." She was blowing on her hands, which did nothing. "I'm not being good. I'm being practical."

"You are doing both."

"Don't," said Meera. "Listen. This is how it goes now. We go slow, and you tell me true, or I take it every time. I will take it every time, Rohan. So don't make me."

It was the first time she had used his name. He doubted she had noticed. She was too cold to notice anything.

"Now," she said. "The question again."

He understood that she meant him to answer it properly.

"Two ribs are cracked," he said. He said it to the snow first, and then he said it again to her. "The seventh and the eighth, on the left. The slide did it. I cannot take a full breath, and I cannot raise the left arm above the shoulder. I have been hiding both since the cairn. I have stopped on the pitch more than you have seen, because I stop when you are not looking."

Nothing happened to his hands. He watched them, and so did she. The wind moved in the loose cuff of his coat, and the fingers stayed the colour of fingers.

"There," said Meera. Her eyes shut, briefly. "That's a bill I don't mind not paying."

*

She bound him in the lee of a boulder where the wind could not get at his chest.

She had to do it with her hands shaking, and he offered to do it himself, which she declined with a look. From the bottom of the pack she pulled a coil of braided goat hair, grey and soft with use, and for a moment she only held it.

"Jassi's spare," she said. "He tethered the kids with it. He'd never go anywhere without a spare." She shook out a length. "Coat open. Tunic stays on. Lift your arms as far as they go."

He lifted the right. The left went to his shoulder and stopped. She said nothing of it. She slid the cord around his back, under the arm, and wound it round his ribs from below the cracked ones to above, crossing it flat across his spine so that there would be no knot to press on him.

"Breathe out," she said.

He did.

"Out more."

The cord drew in. The ends of the bone, which had ground on each breath since the gully, stopped grinding. A band of steadiness settled round him, snug enough to be felt and not so tight that it hurt. He took a short, shallow pull of air and found the top of it was no longer a knife.

"You have done this before," he said.

"Twice. Both men." She tucked the end under the last turn. "You'll breathe small whichever way. This way the ends don't grate on each other. Tell me if it pinches. Tell me *true*."

"It does not pinch."

"Good."

He did up the coat's buttons one-handed. She was already moving ahead on the slope, the red rope paying out between them, and she had slowed her pace by a third and made nothing of it. She had not looked at him the whole while she wound the cord. Her ears were red, which was not the wind.

He thought of that for a long time afterward.

*

They made the hollow by midmorning, a wind-cut bowl under the lip of the Saddle where the snow lay as hard as old bread. Meera cut blocks with the axe and laid a half-ring of them as she had at the waystone. Rohan hauled blocks with his right arm until she told him to sit down.

The day went in sleep and small chores. By dusk her hands had come back to a dull pink, but the shaking had not stopped. When the dark thickened and the blue line rose along the edge of the bowl, she was sitting with her knees drawn up and her whole body going like a sail in a squall.

"Frostnip and a night of shaking," she said, when he looked. "I know the rate. I'll live." Her teeth clicked on the last word.

He fed the fire. There were four dung cakes and a handful of juniper bark, and he set them as she had taught him, and they burned bright and honest. He pushed her closer to the coals. She held her palms to them and stared without expression.

"It won't help," she said. "Fire doesn't touch it. I'd tell you if it did."

He knew that. She had told him. He sat anyway, helpless as a man at a bedside, and watched the flames lick at the cold and the cold not give way.

Under his coat, rolled at his belt, was the grey pattu he had carried since the post. It was warden's issue, thick, woven close, and it was the only warm thing in the bowl that was not on fire. He had not touched it when the tents were lost, because he had been raised not to take warmth before the people in his charge had theirs.

He unrolled it and held it out.

"No," said Meera.

"It is wool, Guide. It does not say a great deal."

"You've cracked ribs. You need it." Her chin shook as she said it. "I'm the one who was fool enough to—"

"You took my cold, and you did not have to." He kept his voice level, as he did in council, and it came out less steady than he meant. "It is only a shawl. I am warm enough. Watch my hands, and you will see it is so."

She looked at the pattu. She looked at his hands, which stayed as they were. In the firelight she looked younger than twenty-nine and a good deal more tired. She had buried a man at the foot of this climb the day before, and she had not once asked for anything.

She took it. She dragged it round her shoulders with both hands and bowed her head into the fold, and for a while she only shook.

"It smells of wardens," she said at last, muffled.

"Camphor. It is meant for the moth."

"Terrible."

"I am told it is."

She made a sound that was not quite a laugh, and the shawl moved with it.

*

She slept near midnight, with the red rope slack across the snow between them. He sat up with the fire and did the sum.

It was a habit, and a poor one. He tallied what a thing cost, and who had paid it. He had done it all his life with fines and with men.

The day was gone. Fifteen of the twenty, then, and he had spent one on his own pride. That was the first line of the ledger, and it was the small one.

She had known the moment she held out her hand that she would learn he had lied to her. She had known she would pay for it. She had seen the lie in his face and weighed it as she weighed the odds on the gully.

She could have let him slow. It would have cost her nothing, if cost were measured in cold. She could have let him limp up the Saddle with frostnip and cracked bone, and put the blame where it belonged, and gone on with her sattu and her count. He had given her every reason. He was a warden. He was bound to arrest her at the thaw. He had seized her crew's goods twice, and he could not now remember the names of the families.

She had put her hand in the cold and held it there.

He turned his own hand over in the firelight and looked at it. The knuckles were whole. The fingertips were warm. They were warm because hers were not. He had priced his lie at a night of shaking, and she had paid the price, and the price had never been his to pay.

There was a thing he had never allowed himself to be, in all the years of the badge, and it was in debt. A warden gave and was owed. Rules kept the ledger straight. He did not know what rule covered this, and so he sat and watched the fire and let the figure stand where it was. He owed her, in a currency the Closing Law had no clerk for.

When the fire dropped, the shaking eased. She woke near the grey hour and lay with her eyes open, looking at the lip of the Saddle where the stars were going out.

"You didn't take it back," she said.

"The pattu? I am not cold."

She tested that, he saw. She waited, looking at his hands, and they stayed as they were. She seemed to relax by a degree.

"Rohan," said Meera.

He waited.

"Promise you won't lie to me again."

It came out small and plain, as if she had worn it smooth in her mouth. She was not asking as a guide, or as a smuggler, or as the woman who had bound his ribs. She asked like someone who had looked at the worst of a bill and was wondering whether it would come again.

He knew what a promise was on this rope. He had heard her say it among the rules, in the middle, where she kept the things she meant least

to explain. A promise made while bound was a promise to the mountain. If it broke, the breaker was struck as by a great lie, flesh dead in the hands and feet.

He did not know that he could keep it. There would come a night, and he knew it as he knew the Saddle was there, when the true answer would hang her, and silence would cost more than silence could pay. He would not stand in that night with a promise round his neck and call it a vow. He had priced a lie once already, and the bill had gone to her.

"No," he said.

Her face went still.

"I will not promise it." He kept his hands open on his knees, where she could see them. "A promise is a rope, and I would be tying it to you with one end already frayed. I do not know what the mountain will ask of me. I do not know what you will ask. I will not hand you a word I may not be able to hold."

"That's not an answer."

"It is the only true one I have." He held her eyes. "I have not lied to you since the pitch. I'll show you. Watch my hands."

She did. The fire had burned down to a rind of red, and in its light his fingers lay still and steady and warm. She studied them for a long time, with the pattu pulled up to her chin and her own hands hidden in its folds.

She said nothing. It cost her nothing. He had never heard silence sound so much like a question.

Chapter 7

Other Ropes

"Three hundred and eighteen," said Meera. "Three hundred and nineteen."

The snow squeaked under every boot, the high dry squeak that meant no thaw had touched it since autumn. The Long Saddle lay ahead like a sheet of beaten tin. Glare came up from it and in at the eyes, and by now the ache sat behind her face like a second skull.

"You are counting aloud," said Rohan behind her.

"It keeps the pace. Three hundred and twenty."

"And the number is?"

"Whatever the number is." She did not turn. "Three-twenty-one. Talk if you like. I won't answer till four hundred."

He did not talk. She listened to him instead, the careful sip of his breath inside the goat-hair binding, the long stride he shortened to match hers. At the three-hundred-and-sixtieth step the breathing changed. It went ragged, with a wet catch in it.

She stopped and looked back.

His eyes were streaming. He had them narrowed to cracks, and the lashes were clotted with ice. Tears ran down his face and froze at the jaw. He had not said a word.

"How long?"

"Since the hollow."

"You said nothing."

"I judged it a minor matter." He blinked, and winced. "It has become less minor."

"Snow-blind by noon, if you're lucky. By dark, you're led by the rope like a goat." She slung off her pack. "Writ case. Give it here."

That pulled him up straight. "I beg your pardon?"

"The leather one. On your belt." She held out her hand. "I've seen you touch it forty times. Don't tell me it's empty."

It was not empty. He undid the strap with his right hand and drew out a folded paper, thick and creamy. She saw red wax on the fold before he tucked it inside his coat against the binding. He passed her the case. It was good leather, boiled hard and dark with years of handling, and stamped with a goat.

"This is crown issue," Rohan said.

"It's a strip." She drew her knife. "Hold still."

She cut a band the width of two fingers, doubled it, and pierced two slits with the knife-point, each barely wider than a barley grain. She threaded a length of the red rope's spare wool through the ends and tied it behind his head with her left hand, because her right fingertips still tingled from yesterday. The leather smelled of ink and old oil. His hair was damp under her knuckles. She kept her eyes off his face while she worked.

"Better?"

He swung his head slowly across the white. "The world is a ribbon," he said. "It is a very good ribbon."

"You look like an owl in a bad temper."

"I have been called worse by wardens' wives." He touched the leather. "You have destroyed a writ case."

"I've improved it."

The corner of his mouth moved. It was nearly a smile, and then he put it away as though it might be seized.

She took up her pace again. Three hundred and sixty-two. Three hundred and sixty-three. She looked down the long scoured fall of the

Saddle to where it broke into the first folds of the south slope, and there, a very long way below, something moved that was not the wind.

She stopped counting.

"Captain."

He came up beside her with the slits of the leather turned the same way. Down on the white, small as seeds on a sheet, four figures went in two short lines. Between the lines there was a gap of black rope, and between the pairs another.

"Wardens?" he said.

"Not wardens. Look at the ropes. Two pairs means two bindings at the Shilak Cairn. Four people stood in that ring and spoke their true names to the stones." She shaded her eyes with her mitten and counted them, then counted again. "Nobody does that in a closed winter for love. Someone paid them enough to do it."

"You can tell who?"

"Packs low. Covered in ochre canvas. There's one crew on the lower salt road dyes its packs with onion skin so they can find them in the dark." Her mouth went dry. "That's Asha's."

"You know the name."

"Everyone on the pass knows it. Asha runs salt and a little else, and she runs it below Shilak, where the wardens are lazy. She never crosses the Saddle. She says the mountain eats the cheap." Meera lowered her hand. "Unless someone's paying her more than the mountain costs."

"For what?"

"I was about to ask you."

He said nothing. He stood looking at the four small figures with the slits of leather angled down the slope, and it was a long time before he spoke.

"Four," he said. "Two pairs, spaced a rope and a half apart, so that if one pair falls the other is not dragged. No tent poles. No long packs. They carry what a person carries who means to be fast and not to sleep. They keep their tracks tight, in single file, and they stop on a count. Every few hundred paces they watch the ridge behind them."

"Looking for us."

"Looking for something ahead. Then they move up in bounds." He glanced down the slope. "Whoever trained them knew soldiers. That is a soldier's advance, done by people who have been paid to be soldiers for a week."

"They're closing."

"By a third since dawn, by my reckoning. Your slowing for me has cost that."

"It has," she said, "and I'd do it again." She started walking, fast. "Eight hundred paces to the lip. Then the ridge. After that I'll show you what I can do about it."

*

He waited until four hundred. She had said she would not answer till then, and he seemed to be a man who kept the terms of a bargain even when nobody was holding him to it.

"I carry something," said Rohan.

She kept walking. "I'd gathered."

"I told you at the waystone that what lies at Garh Neshar matters to more than me. It is not only a place I am going. It is a thing I am carrying." The slits of the goggles stayed fixed on the snow. "The regent's people in Neshar would pay a lordship for it. Land and title and a hall with a bell on it. I believe now that someone has already offered, and that those four on the slope have been told where to find me."

She stopped so quickly the rope went slack.

"What is it?"

"I decline."

"A lordship," said Meera. "For what, in your pocket? A map? A ledger?"

"I decline." He stood in the glare with his hands open at his sides. "It is free to say that. I would rather give you the free thing than the false one."

She looked at his fingers. They stayed the colour of fingers. A fresh breeze combed the snow between them and drew a thin white smoke across their boots.

Anger came clean and sharp, and she was surprised to find how little of it belonged to him. A man had said he could be bought for a hall and a bell, and he was not selling. He had told her he was hunted and by whom, and what the hunters would pay, and had held back only the one thing she could do nothing with.

"Fine," she said. "Keep your lordship."

"I do not want one."

"I know." She set off again. "That's what's so annoying."

*

The ridge came up out of the Saddle like a spine, a long fin of black rock the wind had stripped to the bone. Meera led him onto it with the snow squeaking behind them, and at the first bare stretch she stopped.

"Here the tracks end," she said. "There's no snow on this rock. They'll lose us for a quarter mile unless they've a tracker. And they'll have a tracker."

"Then they do not lose us."

"They lose us for long enough. Listen." She dug her axe into the crust and leaned on it. "Past the ridge there's a shelf on the south face. A crew shelf. Bindu's mother cut it forty winters ago, and every guide who ever needed to sit out a storm unfound has used it. From the Saddle, it's invisible. From the slope below, it's a dark line in the cornice that looks like a shadow. A bound pair can lie there while an army passes."

Rohan's head came round. "A crew shelf."

"Aye."

"A hiding place for smugglers."

"For anybody who's hiding."

"Guide." He said it slowly. "I would ask you something. I would ask you very plainly not to show me anything I would be required to report."

She had been waiting for him to ask it. She had not expected it in that voice, quiet and unhurried, with nothing officious in it.

"The shelf is a crime scene," Rohan said. "The pegs, the cut, the cache, if there is one: each is evidence of a continuing offence under the Closing Law. If I see it, I know it. If I know it, I am sworn to carry it to the post. I would not wish to be obliged to do that to you." He lifted the leather slits to her face. "You have lost a man already on my account. I do not wish you to lose a crew."

The pegs he named were iron, hammered into the rock by Bindu's mother with a stone hammer. The cache was three days of food and two dry blankets. Every guide in the crew had slept on that shelf one night or another, and a good half of them would hang if the shelf were counted. It was her crew's ledge, and she was the Salt Fox. If he ever set the one beside the other, the shelf was the noose with her name on it.

Her hand stopped on the axe haft. Then she looked at his, open at his sides, the fingers pink and whole, and she pulled the axe out of the crust.

The wind rattled in the crust below. Four small figures were climbing the slope.

"I keep asking who knew my road," Rohan said, low, as if to the wind. "It was chosen for me, and only a handful ever saw it. Yet there they are."

"Ask it later. How many hours do you think I've got?"

"Three. Perhaps four."

"If I take the high route to lose them, it's six. I'd leave you out in the open, snow-blind by dark, and the first time they gained the ridge they'd have us in sight." She had pulled her right mitten off to work the axe free, and she kept her bare hand wrapped on the haft. "If I use the shelf, I save the time, and they don't see us go in. That's all it is. Time. I don't care a fig for the shelf."

The cold took her at once. It bit the pads of her fingers where they lay on the wood, and they went white from the tips inward, a small lie's worth, plain as chalk.

"That is not true," said Rohan.

He was not looking at her face. The leather slits were tipped down at her hand, and he had read it as plainly as a page.

She shoved the mitten back on. "Fine. I care," she said. "I'm doing it anyway. Shut your eyes if you want. I'll walk you like a goat. But I'm not leaving a man to die so a peg stays secret."

"Meera."

"Eyes closed, Captain, or eyes open. You pick."

He was quiet. She watched him think about it. Then he did a thing she would remember for a long time afterward: he lifted the strip of leather off his face, shut his eyes, and put it back, so that there was nothing in the slits to see.

"I choose the first," said Rohan. "I shall see nothing. You will tell me where to put my feet, and I shall put them there."

"And when you're asked?"

"I shall say that I was blindfolded by a snow-glare, and that this is true." The corner of his mouth moved again. "It is a fact I can make good on."

For a second she could not say anything at all.

"Hand on the rope," she said finally. "Walk where I walk."

*

She read the snow as she went, because there was nothing else to read.

She told him the ridge was cold-hardened on the windward side and rotten on the lee. She told him the cornice beyond it was old and sound, and the wind slab on the south face would hold a man's weight if he was careful and not hold a goat's. She said it all in small, flat sentences, and he repeated each one in his head, she could tell, because he put his feet where she told him and never once asked why.

Halfway down the ridge he stopped.

"They have reached the foot of the Saddle," he said, without opening his eyes.

"How do you know?"

"The sound. A pair lifts its feet on a count. I heard two counts, then two, and the gap between them is the length of a rope." He tilted his head slightly. "They are at a speed they cannot hold for long. They will halt at the ridge to read the ground."

"They'll halt at the first bare rock. They'll look for tracks and find none."

"Then they will send one pair across the ridge and keep the other back. That is how I would do it." He listened a moment. "That will cost them half an hour."

"Half an hour's good."

"It is better than good, if we use it."

"We're using it." She looked down the south face, at the long white fall of the slope and the dark seam in the cornice, so thin she would not have seen it if she had not known it by heart. "Shelf's there. You see?"

"I see nothing, as I swore."

"Good man." She took a breath. "There's a gully before it. A snow bridge, eight paces across. It's good. I crossed it six winters running."

"How good?"

"Nine in ten."

"And the tenth?"

"The tenth is the mountain's," said Meera. "It's cold. The snow's dry. The bridge has had a freezing night to set." She set her teeth. "I'll go first. I'll plant the axe on the far side and take your weight on the rope. You come across when I say, in my steps, not beside them. Don't look. Don't think. Walk."

"And if it gives?"

"It won't." She said it to him, and then to the snow, and a third time to herself, with her eyes on her mitten. The white tips would show under the wool for an hour yet, but they could not get worse. "I believe it won't."

*

The gully was a black slot in the white, twelve feet down at its lip and deeper beyond. Across it lay the snow bridge, a smooth blue-white arch no wider than a door, with the shelf's dark mouth at its far end.

Meera went over it like a woman walking on eggs. She did not hurry. She set each boot, tested, shifted her weight, and counted. One. Two. The snow gave a small dry sigh underfoot and held. At the far side she stepped onto rock, sank her axe to the head in the crust beside the shelf's lip, and wrapped a turn of the red rope around the shaft.

"Come," she called.

He came the way he had promised. He put his feet in her steps, eyes shut behind the leather, and his right hand ran along the rope as if it were a banister in a house he had known all his life. She watched his boots. Each time one went down she held her breath, and each time the snow held.

Four paces. Five.

"You're at the middle," she said. "Slow. Slow."

"I am aware of it."

"Don't be aware. Walk."

Six. The wind lifted a thin sheet of powder off the bridge and spread it across his coat. Seven. She could see the shelf's dark mouth over her shoulder, and the cache, and somewhere on the ridge behind them a pair of strangers coming up on a count.

On the eighth step the bridge breathed.

It was a sound she knew, the low, flat sigh of snow that has stopped being a floor. She saw his boot go down and the white around it dissolve, not in a crack but in a quiet, slow pouring, as if the bridge had turned to sugar. She saw him throw himself forward. His hand came off the rope and closed on air.

Then the whole span went, and Rohan went with it.

The rope hit its length with a bang she felt in her ribs. It snapped taut across the lip of the gully and tore at the axe's shaft, and the weight on the other end dragged her one stride toward the edge before she threw herself back. She came down on her knees on the rock with both fists

around the axe. The blade bit. The wool shrieked round the shaft and held.

It held, and every ounce of him hung off it.

"Don't you dare," Meera said.

She had not meant to speak. It came out of her through clenched teeth, to the rope, to the gully, to the long black drop and the man at the bottom of it. The rope sang under her hands, thin and high. Somewhere below, a boot scraped on ice, and a sliver of snow ran down the wall, and there was no other sound.

"Rohan," she said. "Answer me."

He did not answer.

Chapter 8

The Rope-Hut

"Rohan," Meera said again. "Count your fingers."

A scrape answered her, then a cough, then a voice from the bottom of the gully, flat with effort. "Ten. I have been through them twice."

Her knees nearly gave. She did not let them. The rope was still singing against the axe shaft, and every pound of him hung off her two fists.

"Can you see the wall?"

"I see a very blue wall."

"Is there ice you can kick?"

"There is ice I can kick."

"Then kick it when I say, and not before." She looked at the axe. One turn of wool around the shaft would hold a hanging man. It would not lift him. At fourteen, Bindu's mother, a woman with no patience, had taught her what to do about that.

She worked fast. She dug the axe in to the head and stamped the crust around it. She ran the rope back through a loop knotted from its own spare end, tied a sliding grip in the line, and threw her weight on the grip instead of the rope. The tail ran through the loop and doubled her pull. Bindu called it the lazy woman's lift. It was the only way one pair of arms could do the work of two.

"Right hand on the rope," she called. "Left stays down. I'll count, you climb."

"On what count?"

"One is my pull. Two is your boot. Don't think about three."

She hauled. The line came in a hand's width and stuck. "One!"

Below, a boot struck ice. "Two," said Rohan, through his teeth.

"One! Two! One!"

It went like that, a hand's width at a time. The binding of goat hair creaked around his ribs. Each breath he took came out as a sound he would have refused to make in front of the post. He did not stop. He climbed on her numbers, because she was the only voice in the world with a plan for him.

"Twenty-six," she said. "Twenty-seven. You're past halfway. Twenty-eight."

His hand came over the lip. She let go of the grip and seized his wrist with both of hers, and he came up over the edge on his belly, goggles knocked askew, snow in his hair and his face the colour of a candle.

He lay with his cheek in the crust. She knelt beside him, shaking in a way that had nothing to do with lie-cold.

"Ribs," she said.

"Present. Complaining." He did not move to prove it.

She put her palm flat on the binding over his left side anyway and felt him breathe under it, shallow but even, nothing grinding. Jassi's cord had held. She took her hand away.

"You're a fool," said Meera. "You're a bloody, sworn, rule-bound fool. I said slow."

"You said walk." He rolled onto his back and looked at the sky through the slits. "I was walking."

"You shut your eyes!"

"At your instruction."

The laugh got out of her before she could stop it. It was a poor, cracked thing, half sob. Rohan made a sound that might have been a cough and then wasn't, and held his bound ribs with one arm while he laughed too, badly, wheezing, his head going back against the snow. It hurt him. She could see that it hurt him. It went on anyway, and so did

hers, until she had to wipe her face on her sleeve and turn it into something else.

"Up," she said. "They'll be on the ridge."

*

They lay in the crew ledge until the light began to go.

The shelf was as she remembered it: a low cut in the cornice, dry as a cupboard, iron pegs in the back wall. Rohan sat against the rock with the leather slits turned to the floor and told her, with great correctness, that he was not looking at anything. She sat at the mouth and watched four ochre packs move along the bare ridge above, cast about like hounds that have lost a scent, and turn east along the Saddle's lip to look for tracks that were not there.

"That buys the night," she said.

"It buys a part of it."

"Part's enough."

Dusk came blue. The cairn-light woke along the south slope in thin threads, and she took the line down it with the red rope tight between them and the snow squeaking under her. Rohan walked in her steps with his hand on the wool and his jaw set. She did not call it out. She slowed by a third and said nothing.

The Rope-Hut came up out of the dark an hour later, a hump of dry-laid stone, roofed with slate and sod, with its door facing downhill out of the wind. Smoke stains blackened the lintel. A sprig of juniper had been nailed above it by someone dead.

She put her shoulder to the door. It gave on a room barely long enough for a man to lie in, and she stepped in and looked at what was hers.

One chulha, a clay hearth the height of her knee, its mouth black. One sleeping shelf, a plank slab of deodar worn to a dip by forty winters of crossers. And against the north wall, tied in a bundle with hide, the juniper pile.

She counted it with her finger. It took a while, because her finger was clumsy, and she did it again.

"Forty-one sticks," she said.

"Is that a good number?"

"It's a number. One night's fire is five, if we're mean. Eight nights, and one stick over." She dropped her pack against the wall. "The next pile is two days' walk past the door. We can't burn this one to the last stick and hope."

Rohan had come in behind her and stopped under the lintel. He took the leather off his face in the dark and stood holding it. His gaze went to the hearth, and the shelf, and the stacked stones of the walls, and the two of them, and at last to the sprig above the door.

"Guide," he said. "I should say this aloud."

"Go on."

"A lawful warden may not enter this house. A lawful warden may not sleep in it, nor eat in it, nor warm his hands at its fire." His voice was perfectly level. "What we are about to do is harbouring. It carries the rope for me as it carries it for you. I would be hanged beside you, and rightly."

She lit the first stick with her flint. It took on the third try, a blue lick of juniper resin, and the room filled with its sharp clean smoke, the smell of every night she had ever been warm on this road.

"Then hang yourself warm," said Meera.

For a moment he said nothing at all. Then he crossed the floor, folded himself down on the dirt before the hearth with his ribs held stiff, and put his hands out to it.

"It seems a sound policy," said Rohan.

*

While the fire caught, Meera did the redbark.

It was her habit on every night of every crossing. She opened the oilcloth roll, took back the six packets Rohan had carried in his coat, turned the twelve small bundles over one by one, and pressed each between thumb and finger to feel for damp. Damp meant clumping, and clump-

ing meant the grey cough would win. She had done it on the pass with her mother's old patience, and now she did it in front of a warden.

He watched her hands. Eventually he said, "May I?"

She weighed it. "One. If it comes to powder, I want it back."

He took a packet in his right hand. A seam had worked loose in the avalanche, and a pinch of dust had come out of the wax. He rubbed it between his fingers and bent to the fire to see it.

His face changed. It was slight. She would have missed it a month ago.

"This is crown-grade," Rohan said.

"It's redbark."

"It is ground fine. Finer than any hill apothecary has the sieve for." He rolled the grains on his thumb. "The crown storehouses sift through a silk sieve with a ring in the weave, and the mark of that ring is pressed into the wax of the wrapper." He tilted the packet. In the firelight, along the fold, she saw it: a faint round print, like the ghost of a coin. "This came out of a crown storehouse. I have seen this mark on every medicine chest the queen has sent north."

"Which is not the same as stolen."

"No. It is not." He looked at her. He didn't accuse. He asked. "Where did you have it?"

Her hands were bare and the fire was near. She kept them where he could see them. "A middleman in the lowlands, who sells through the lower-lane runners. I've never met him. I send silver down the road and a crate comes up." She held out her palm for the packet. "I saw a stamp scraped off the crates. I didn't ask whose. He never told me, and I never wanted to know."

Brown and warm in the light, her fingers stayed still. He studied them, and she let him. That was the worst of it. The truth did not cost her a thing, and it was not clean. Then he gave the packet back.

"I believe you," he said. It was a plain statement, and not his to make. The cold would do the believing. His belief was a courtesy.

"It means a crown man is selling medicine out the back door," she said.

"It means that at least." He did not say the rest. She saw him decide not to, and the decision sat heavy in the room while the juniper snapped.

Meera wrapped the packet again and put it in its row. Then she took the count from inside her coat, the waxed book that never left her ribs, and found the middleman's page. Ten winters of crates, in her own small hand. Beside his entry she drew a round mark, the size of a coin, and wrote nothing under it.

Rohan watched her do it. He did not ask what it meant, and she did not say.

*

He cooked.

Her hand was already on the sattu bag, with the pot beside it and the water melted, when he said, "I gave back half my winnings at the waystone, Guide. Let me cook, and call it the rest of the wager."

"You didn't win. You cheated. You hummed."

"I did not hum. I breathed in tune."

"Fine." She sat down. "Make it, then."

He made it badly. He poured the flour in before the water had warmed, so that it floated in grey islands. He stirred it with his knife, which was the wrong end of the wrong tool. He tasted it and gave a small clerk's frown, and added salt, and then added a great deal more, from which she deduced that the warden's mess served its sattu without any. When it was done it was a paste the colour of wet slate and nearly as hard, and he held out the bowl to her with the same grave face he used for oaths.

She ate every mouthful. It was dreadful. It was hot.

"Well?" he asked.

"It's the worst thing I've eaten since I was fifteen."

"That is true?"

"Look at my hands."

He looked. He was smiling, with only one side of his mouth, the side he never offered, and then he took his own bowl and ate it as if it were a duty.

The shelf was the next trouble. It was one slab, three feet wide, with a hollow in it, and he stood looking at it with the half-formal air of a man at a council.

"You will take the shelf," he said.

"You've cracked ribs."

"I shall be lying on a floor which is dry and sound. You have been shaking for two days. You will take it."

"You'll take it. I'm the guide."

"You are the guide. That makes you the one thing on this mountain I cannot replace." He said it quite evenly. "I am a warden. There are forty more at the post. The mountain has one of you."

She opened her mouth and found she had nothing in it. She tried again.

"The rope's eight spans. Floor or shelf, you don't go farther than that."

"Then I shall be on the floor within the length." He had already spread the pattu on the dirt beside the chulha, and now he lifted it and held it out to her, folded. "Camphor and all. The shelf will be cold."

"It's your pattu."

"It has done more for you than it ever did for me."

She took it, and she took the shelf. She lay in the hollow the crossers had worn, with a warden's shawl over her and her red rope running across the floor to his wrist, and she did not know where to look. Rohan lay down by the fire with his coat for a pillow. The ribs bound with Jassi's cord made him lie very straight, like a stone figure on a tomb.

Then she listened. She had not meant to.

His breath was slow at first, and careful at the top, and then, when he thought she slept, it dropped. It went long and low and even. The juniper ticked and the wind shifted in the slates. He turned in his sleep, toward the fire, and the rope drew taut across the floor and tugged at his

bound wrist. His breath caught on the left side, a small hitch, and stopped.

She was off the shelf before she had decided to be. She crouched, took up the slack of the red rope in both hands and eased it back across the dirt until it lay loose again. His wrist settled. The breath came out of him long and easy.

Longer than the rope needed, she stayed there. Then she went back up to the shelf, lay on her back, and counted the cracks in the slate. At sixty she gave up and counted his breaths.

*

Near midnight the fire sank. She rose to feed it, a single stick from the forty-one, and stepped to the door to listen to the cold.

The hut door stuck. She eased it open a hand's width.

Down the mountain, far below the cairn-light and the black fold of the south slope, a road ran into Neshar. She had come up it a dozen times, with her pack and her goats. It was a pale thread under the stars, and on the thread there was a row of fire.

Torches, climbing. She counted them, because she could not stop. Nine, then fourteen, then more behind. They went up the road in a line too slow for a march and too tight for a caravan, and between them, thin and carried on the wind, came a horn: two notes, falling, the same pair the regent's hunters blew when they ran a man to ground.

They were not Asha's. Asha's packs did not carry fire.

She stood with her hand on the cold wood of the door. Behind her Rohan slept on, slow and unaware, with the thing in his coat that the regent would pay a lordship for, and that she still could not name.

Nobody on the Neshar side should have known there was a man to hunt. Nobody should have known which pass.

She turned and looked at him. One shake of his shoulder and he would be awake, and angry, and planning. It was what he would want. It was also the first whole night's sleep he had had since the avalanche, on

ribs that would not mend without it, and the torches were half a night's climb from the third bend at the best of their pace.

Weighing one against the other, she chose. Dawn, then. She would let him have the dark, and at dawn she would tell him, and he would be right to be furious about the hours. She would answer for them.

She shut the door on the torches, laid the stick on the coals, and did not sleep.

Chapter 9

Clean-Cut

She told him about the torches before he had his boots on.

"Fourteen that I counted," said Meera. "More behind. They were still climbing when I lost them."

She crouched at the chulha with her back to him, feeding it one stick. Grey light leaked through the gap she had left in the door. Rohan sat on the dirt with the leather strip tied over his eyes and his ribs aching like a bad tooth, and he went through what she had said once, the way he went through a report.

"Regent's hunters."

"A two-note horn, falling. I know it."

"How?"

"From being on the wrong end of it." She did not turn round. "Free to say. Not free to say more."

He let that stand. It was an answer of a kind, and he put it where he put such things.

"Then we have a choice," he said. "Go down on the line this morning, or wait."

"We."

"You are the guide. I am the man asking what the guide would advise."

That turned her head. He could not see her face through the leather, but he heard the pause. He had spent three winters giving orders on this

mountain, and one winter of that being wrong about it. He found it was not hard to say. It was only unfamiliar, like a left-handed knife.

"The line comes out on the Neshar road at the third bend," she said. "Half a day down. Fourteen torches are climbing that road. We'd walk into them at noon."

"And if we wait?"

"They can't cross the Saddle in a column. Nobody can. They'll make camp under the lip and send out pairs, as Asha's done, and pairs take days to bind and cross." She poked the fire. "So we wait. We keep the fire low by day and watch the road from the door. We go down when they've gone up past us, or split."

"You do not like waiting."

"I like it better than being found."

He weighed it as a warden would, and found that it held. Going down meant fourteen men with a lordship in view. Staying meant a hut with one door, smoke from one chimney, and four ochre packs somewhere above them on the Saddle's lip. Both were bad. One was slower.

"We wait," said Rohan. "Your judgement, Guide."

"Don't thank me for it."

"I was not going to."

"Good." She sat back on her heels. "You were about to look pleased with yourself."

*

By dusk the road below had gone quiet and the ridge above had shown nothing. The hunters' fires burned in a long red string beneath the lip, as small as sparks from a forge. Nobody had come to the hut. Rohan had slept most of the day in the dark, and his eyes had stopped streaming.

Meera knelt at the woodpile and counted the bundle with her finger. Her lips moved.

"Thirty-six," she said. "Five a night is seven nights, and one stick over. We can't spend more than that."

"Then we will not."

"We'll be spending something. Sit down. I've got a rule."

He sat. She dropped onto her heels across the chulha from him, so that the fire stood between them like a third party at a hearing, and held up one finger.

"A question each, every night. Any question. You can answer it or you can refuse." She tapped the juniper bundle. "A refusal costs a stick. It goes on the fire as it is, over the five. You feel it in the wood, not in the hands."

"The mountain does not require this."

"The mountain says silence is free. I'm saying it isn't, in here." Her mouth went crooked. "You keep your secret and I keep mine. But there's seven nights of wood, and whoever won't talk burns the rest of us colder."

He saw the design at once, and admired it more than he liked. A silence on the rope could be a lie in a better coat. Her rule made it a thing with a price that both of them could count. It was a tariff on evasion, and she had set it at the exact weight of what they could afford.

"It is a sound rule," said Rohan.

"Is that a yes?"

"It is an acceptance. I wish to say that I dislike how well it works."

"Good. I'll go first."

She sat quite still, the firelight in the lines beside her mouth. He thought she was going to ask what he carried. His refusal was ready and already priced: one stick, and a look from her that he did not want to see twice.

"Who died?" said Meera.

It was not what he had braced for. He opened his mouth for the refusal and shut it.

"You told me you hunted my crew two winters more for a dead man's sake," she said. "I'd like the man. Not the reason. The man."

The fire ticked. The wind moved in the slates.

"His name was Dilan," said Rohan. "He was twenty-three. He was the youngest warden at the Shilak post, and the worst at knots, and he

could not carry a tune in a bucket. He sang anyway, every watch, a hymn he thought was a love song." He looked at his hands. "He died on this pass two winters ago, in a storm, chasing a Kothi smuggler."

He had not said it aloud to anyone since the report. It came out in good order, in the voice of a man reading a report, and that was the only way he could have said it.

Meera did not move. Her hands lay open on her knees. Her eyes were on the fire, and they stayed there.

"He's why," she said at last.

"He is why. I would have hunted your crew for the law alone, and I did, for a winter. After Dilan I hunted it for him." He stopped. "I should not have said that last."

"You said it. I'd rather have it." Her voice had gone low and level. "I'm sorry, Captain."

He looked at her fingers, as brown and warm as the fire made them. She spoke no lie, and for a moment he could not think why he had checked.

"It is my turn," he said.

He had a question ready, and he looked at it plainly. What are you to the Salt Fox? It sat in his mouth like a coin. He could ask it. She would refuse it, and burn a stick, and say nothing, and he would have the shape of her silence to turn over in the dark. It would be evidence, and he knew by now what evidence did to him.

"Who taught you the line?" said Rohan.

Her head came up. He watched her take it in, and take in what he had left out.

"My mother," she said. "I was fifteen. She took me over bound, my first winter crossing, and made me walk it twice with my eyes shut." A small breath. "She died ten winters back. Fever, in a closed winter, with the medicine on the wrong side of a notice on a gatepost. I was nineteen."

"Guide."

"That's the answer. It's all of it." Her hands stayed warm. "Don't say sorry. You've said it once tonight, and I made you."

"I was not going to say it."

"What were you going to say?"

"That it is a very good line," said Rohan. "The one she taught you."

She laughed, one short breath through her nose, and looked away. Her eyes were bright. Then she picked up a stick, turned it over, and set it on the coals, where it caught blue.

"Five," she said. "That's the night's. Go to sleep, Captain."

*

She slept, or did the next best thing, curled in the hollow of the shelf under his pattu with the red rope slack across the floor between them. He listened to her breathing change, shorten, deepen. Then he lay quite still for a long time with the dark pressing on his eyelids.

At last he put his right hand into his coat.

It lay where it always lay, against the lining over his sound ribs. A forearm's length of grey hand-spun wool, rolled and tied with a scrap of its own cord. He drew it out and held it in the last orange light of the coals.

One end was whipped with black thread, tight and neat. Dilan had done that himself. It was the only knot Dilan had ever tied well, and he had tied it on everything. The other end was where Rohan's thumb always went.

He rolled it over, and found the cut.

In the loose fibres he tied an overhand and pulled it tight, then picked it out again with his thumbnail. He did it slowly, so that the wool made no sound. Tie, pick. Tie, pick. The fibres lay together, every one, severed at the same line, as flat as bread under a good knife.

A mountain did not do that. A mountain frayed. Rock sawed a rope, ice chewed it, and the wool came apart in a beard of broken ends. He had seen a dozen ropes that had parted on the pass, and all of them ended in a ragged mess. This one ended like a cut loaf.

Somebody had held a knife.

He had told himself so on the day he found it, in the cold room at the post with the body on the board and the report in front of him. That evening he had stood in the warden hall, before eleven men and a bare table, with this rope in his right hand, and sworn on it to find the one who had stood at its far end. He had meant every word. He had said the oath, put the rope in his coat, and never taken it out in company since.

And now he was lying in a smuggler's hut with the nearest thing to a smuggler he had ever met three paces from his boots, who had made him sattu-bread jokes, and who had pulled him out of a gully on a lazy woman's lift. He could not have said what he wanted. He turned the cut over and over.

The shelf creaked.

He did not move. The rope lay in his open hand, with the neat black thread on one end and the flat white ruin on the other, and he was perfectly aware of it.

She had half-woken. He could tell by the quality of the silence from the shelf, which had changed from the silence of sleep to the silence of someone deciding. Her eyes were on his hand. He felt it as he might have felt a lamp.

He closed his fingers. He drew the rope back into his coat, slowly, and laid his palm over the place it lay.

She did not ask.

He waited for it. It would have been a fair question, a free one if she wished. He could have answered it or refused it, and the price of either would have been small. She had the right to put to him anything she liked. She looked at him a moment longer, and then she turned her face to the wall, drew the pattu over her shoulder, and settled.

She had chosen silence. He understood that it was a choice. No rule of the mountain gave it to him, and no tariff of hers. It cost her nothing the cold would count, and it was the kindest thing anyone had done for him in a year.

He lay with his hand over his coat, and what settled in his chest was not gratitude. It was something sharper, and he took a long minute to name it.

I will have to use it, he thought.

Not tonight. But there was a ledger in him that never closed. It had already written the evening in a clerk's hand: *Her mother crossed. A line taught at fifteen, over a closed pass, in winter. Her mother died of fever in a closed winter, ten winters ago. Motive. Knowledge of the hunters' horn. A reluctance when the dead man was named.* He had set each truth down as she gave it, in its column, as he had done with every truth since the waystone. He had done it as he breathed.

She had given him her mother, as plainly as she would give a man a cup of water. And he had been counting it.

Then he turned his face to the dark and was, for the length of one long breath, as angry with himself as he had ever been with a smuggler.

It was not fair, he thought. The law was not unfair. It was merely exact, and he had made himself exact in its service until there was nothing in him that could hear *my mother died* and not hear *a motive.* A year ago he would have called this his virtue. He would have said it in a hall.

The coals sank. Somewhere above the hut the wind moved over the lip of the Saddle and found the stacked stones of the nearest cairn, and he heard it hum, low and level, the sound of a true word.

Frayed, he thought, he could have forgiven the mountain. He had been trying to do it for two winters. But the rope was cut clean. Somebody had held the knife, and the somebody was still out in the snow, and he lay awake under the juniper smoke with his hand on the place where the rope lay, not asking himself whose hand it had been.

Chapter 10

Parley

"Shilak!"

The voice came down the rock like a dropped bucket. Meera had the axe in her fist before she knew she was awake.

"Guide of Shilak! I'm coming no closer than I like, so keep your hands where they are and we'll both stay pleasant!"

She stood in the hut door, heart going, the red rope running slack behind her across the floor to Rohan's wrist. Grey morning. Cloud lay on the Saddle like a lid. Fifteen paces up the slope, a black rib of rock stood out of the snow, and on its crest a woman sat with her boots dangling, as at the edge of a well.

Four ochre packs lay in the snow behind her. Asha had come up in the night and camped over the hut's head, and none of the watching had caught it.

The wind had been blowing across the slope when the shout began. Now it swung and ran downhill, straight at the hut door, and it carried every word.

"Stay down," Meera said, without turning.

"That is Asha's voice?" Rohan had pushed up on one elbow on the dirt. His face looked wrong in the half dark, too bright across the cheekbones. "I should hear what she offers."

"You should stay on the floor with your ribs. If you stand in this door, you're a target the size of a barn." She looked at him over her shoulder. "I'm the guide, Captain."

A pause. Then, to her surprise, he lay back. "Eight spans," he said. "Do not go past them."

"I know my own rope."

She stepped out and paid the line off until it drew, then walked its length, up and across the slope, so that the hut sat below her and the rock rib stood above. Wind pushed at her coat. At the top of the rib the woman grinned and swung one boot.

Asha was twenty-eight, wide in the shoulder, with a gap in her front teeth you could post a coin through. She wore a felt hat with a salt-stained brim and a rope at her waist that ran back along the rock to a thin young man hunched in the lee, a spyglass on a cord at his neck. A second pair squatted by the packs, a long way off, doing something to a stove.

"There she is," said Asha. "Meera of Shilak. I've priced you for three winters and never once seen you. You're shorter than your reputation."

"You're louder."

"It's a loud trade." She tapped her own rope. "This is Lalit. My eyes. And I like the high ground. That's a good axe, by the way. Eleven silver, new."

"It's not for sale."

"Everything's for sale. That's what makes it a market."

Meera looked at the gap between them. One span of steep snow, smooth and glassy, lay between the end of her rope and the foot of the rib. She could see every ripple in it. She could not cross it. Asha's rope tied her to Lalit and nothing else. She could have strolled down to the hut door. She sat where she sat on purpose.

"Eight spans, isn't it?" said Asha pleasantly. "Red wool, spun fine. I'm sitting nine. So you can stop measuring, Guide. You'll get to the end of that rope and no further, and I'll be here, enjoying the view."

Meera kept her face still. Asha knew how far a bound guide could come, to the span. She had done her sums before she ever climbed the rock.

"I'll be quick, because it's cold and I like my toes," Asha went on. "Whatever's under that warden's coat, I want it. His coat, and whatever's sewn in it. I don't ask what. I'm a trader. I don't ask what's in the bale."

Sewn in. Meera thought of the hand that had flattened over his chest in the firelight, and the grey wool that went back under it.

And she thought, plainly: *Asha knows what I am.* The Salt Fox stood on this slope with a warden's rope on her wrist. Eight spans down, Rohan lay with his ear to the door. One shouted word from that rock and he would have the name he had hunted. Her mouth had gone dry.

"Who's paying?"

"The regent." Asha said the word as if tasting it. "A lordship's purse, in Neshar silver, counted out before witnesses. And a crown pardon, with the queen's name on it, for every soul in my book."

"The regent can't pardon. Nobody can but the queen."

"He says he'll have her hand to hand by midwinter." Asha shrugged. "I don't ask about that either."

"Why would I sell you a man I walked up a mountain with?"

"Because he's a warden, and you're what you are, and the rope won't last past the thaw." Her voice dropped into the reasonable register of a woman reading figures off a slate. "And because I can add names. The regent's clerk wants a list for the pardon. Every Shilak name you give me goes on it. Your crew. Your brother. Whoever's sitting in the salt house this minute wondering whether the wardens come back."

It was exactly the right place to push. Meera felt it go in under the ribs and stay.

"How'd you find us?" she said, to give her mouth something to do.

"Oh, we didn't find you." Lalit's voice cracked in the wind, pleased with itself, a boy's voice that had not learned to be quiet. "We were told where to look. The gully approach, three wardens and two goat-folk, and

they'd go in on the second day. We watched the whole slope slide from the ridge. Only one warden came out of it, and he came out roped to—"

"Lalit," said Asha, not loudly.

He stopped. The wind took the end of it.

Meera did not move. She set the words in a row. *The gully approach. Three wardens and two goat-folk.*

Two wardens had gone into that gully, and two guides. She had counted them on the slope herself. Rohan had named two in the Kothi yard, before the whole village. She had never heard anyone say three. A watcher on the ridge would have counted two. A gossip in Kothi would have said two.

So the number had not come from eyes on the slope. It had come off a page, from a plan someone wrote out before any of them set foot on the snow.

"Tell your boy to mind his tongue," Meera said evenly. "He'll lose it."

"He loses it daily. It grows back." But Asha's eyes had narrowed a hair. She had seen something cross Meera's face and was trying to price it.

"I'll make you an offer of my own," said Meera. "The salt road is yours at the Kothi toll. Free of the levy, for a winter. My crew's word on it, and a guide at your disposal when it's snowed in."

Asha laughed. It rang off the rock, big and honest and unembarrassed.

"Free of the levy! You're offering me a toll you don't own. Your crew's word is worth, what, a decent goat? A goat with all its teeth." She wiped her eye. "No. I'll tell you what you are. You're two hundred in silver for the skin, and a hundred more if you come in quiet. I'm fond of you, in a distant way. By my mother's last good tooth, I'll bring you down alive, whatever you decide."

"That's your oath?"

"It's my best. I keep it in a drawer." Asha stood, balancing on the rock with the ease of long practice. "I've the whole of today, and tomorrow till the light goes. After that I come down with four, and the

hunters under the lip are a good deal less polite than I am. Think about your brother. Think about the names."

She turned her back, which was a kind of insult, and Lalit scrambled to follow her.

Meera stood with the wind in her face until they were gone. Then she looked down at her hand and made herself open it. The fingers were red from the cold, and shaking.

Asha's threat wasn't what did it. The other thing did: a pardon for Kiran, waiting at the end of one word.

She walked back down the rope to the hut, and every name on the list walked down with her.

*

He was awake when she came in. He had propped himself against the wall under the shelf with his right hand flat on the dirt, and the light from the door showed her how bright his eyes were.

"She wants my coat," Rohan said.

"You heard."

"Not the words. The tune of it." A cough took him, dry and short, and he held his ribs through it with his teeth set. "What does she offer?"

She looked at his fingertips on the dirt. Pink, and warm with fever, with no trace of white in them. And the wind had turned downslope right after Asha's first hail; she had felt it herself. Anything that carried to the door would have carried inside. He had caught the tune and not the words, and it was no lie.

"A lordship's purse for the coat, and a pardon for her crew." She sat down across from him, since there was nowhere else. "She gives us today, and tomorrow till the light goes. After that she comes down with four."

"And how she found us," said Rohan. "You went quiet at the end. I heard that, too."

"Her boy said they were told where to look. The gully approach, and three ward—" She stopped. The word sat in her mouth. Three was a number off a page, and the page would have been his post's. If she gave

him the number she gave him the shape of the hole. She could not yet rule him out. If the leak came from his own door, it was leverage, and she might need it to buy Kiran's name out of that book. "And a deadline," she said. "That's all of it. The coat is worth a lordship to her. That's the price on you."

He studied her. She watched him see the stop. He had asked precise questions all his life, and she saw him weigh this one and set it down.

"Silence is free," said Rohan.

"It is."

"Sewn in," he said, after a while.

"Her word."

"It is a fair word." He closed his eyes briefly. "I wish to say that I do not know how she learned it."

His hands lay open on his knees, steady. Out on the rise above the hut the cairn hummed through the roof stones, low and level. It told her no one under that roof had lied, and nothing about whether his post had.

"What is it, Captain?" she said. "The regent's after the queen's hand. What's that?"

He did not answer. She waited, and he went on not answering.

She let it ride through the afternoon. She melted snow. She made a thin soup out of barley and a dried apricot she rationed with a knife. From the door she watched the road, where the hunters' fires pricked the dusk under the lip. She counted them, marking the tally on the doorpost with her thumbnail, and each time it came out the same. Then she took the count from her coat and wrote, in her small square hand: *Three wardens, two goat-folk. Said by Asha's boy. We were two and two.* She looked at it a while, then closed the book. Twice she glanced at the man by the wall and found him with his head against the stone and his lips slightly apart, breathing as though the air were something he had to bargain for.

At dusk she took the night's five from the bundle, thirty-one down to twenty-six, and laid the first on the coals.

"My question," she said.

"You have one."

"There's a woman on the rock who'll pay a lordship for it. I'd like to know what for. What's in your coat?"

He looked at her. The fire made his face all hollows.

"Guide, I cannot."

"That's a refusal."

"It is." He sounded tired and entirely sure. "Burn the stick."

She did, because she'd made the rule and she'd hold to it herself. She took one more from the bundle, twenty-six down to twenty-five, and put it beside the five. It caught blue.

"I'll guess, then," she said. "You can stay quiet. It's free."

"You are very pleased with that rule."

"It's a good rule. First guess: coin. A pay chest sewn in the lining."

"Wardens do not bribe, Guide."

"Wardens don't do a lot of things. Second guess: names. A list of the regent's men, handed to you by an informer." She leaned in. "Third: a pardon. A real one, with a seal on it, made out blank."

"That is a charming idea."

"That's not an answer."

"It is not." He coughed again, harder, and the rattle at the bottom of it made her hands go still. "You are close to something and well away from something. I will not say which."

She turned a stick over in her fingers. She had meant to stop there. But the hunters' fires had nagged at her all afternoon.

"You haven't asked yours tonight. I want a smaller question." She waited for his nod. "Does the regent want you dead, or only the coat?"

The fire ticked. She had thought it a kindness, a thing he could answer with half a breath. *Only the coat.* If it were true, it cost him nothing, and it would have let her sleep.

He said nothing. He looked at her, and the nothing went on, and she heard the wind go over the roof stones twice.

"That's easy to answer," she said, "if it's only the coat."

"I know."

"Then say it."

"I cannot." His voice was very gentle. "Burn the stick, Guide."

She did it herself. Twenty-four. Her hands were quite steady as she laid it down, and that was the worst of it. The man across the fire could not tell her the one thing a man in his place would tell her if he could.

"Meera," said Rohan.

He had never said it on purpose. She heard that. The stick she had been lifting slipped from her fingers and rolled against the hearthstone, and she picked it up again with both hands, as if it were heavier than it was.

"Asha is not the only danger," he said. "I must be careful, and I am not being careful with you. If I say the whole of it, I put a weight on you that may cost your whole crew. You would be carrying it."

"I'm already carrying it. It's on a rock above my head."

"Yes." He looked at his hands. They were trembling very slightly. She did not think he knew. "Then you should have part. I did not want to give it."

The wind slid over the roof.

"It is the queen's will," said Rohan.

She watched his hands. Warm, pink, no white at the tips. The red rope lay slack and warm at her wrist, and stayed that way.

"The queen's will," she said. "Her wish? Or—"

"I will not be drawn further."

She turned it over and could not make it lie flat. A dying queen's testament, naming her heir. A paper the regent would pay a lordship to burn. It fit too neatly, the way a key fits a lock it was filed for. And a will could be sewn in a coat. It could not be, she thought, the whole reason a warden captain climbed a closed pass in the thirtieth winter of the reign with the goats dead behind him.

But it was a door. He had held it open the width of a hand. A man who had refused her twice and burned two sticks for it had still reached across the fire.

"Thank you," she said. It came out small.

"You are not to thank me." He drew a short breath that stopped halfway. "The hunters are the greater trouble. I should tell you how they will come, because I know the road. I walked it as a boy with my father." His voice had sped up, slurred at the edges. "They will hold the third bend. But the herdsmen's cut above the bend, behind the stone fold, they will want that as well, because it is the only way round. Two men there, I think. If we take the line down and cut left at the shrine, before the—"

He stopped.

She looked up from the fire.

He sat very straight, mouth a little open, as if the next word had not arrived. His eyes had gone to some distance. A sheen stood on his forehead, though the hut was cold, and the breath that went in and out of him made a small wet sound, like a boot in a thawing marsh.

"Rohan?"

"Before the," he said. "The shrine." His right hand lifted off his knee, searching for something, and fell.

She was across the floor before he tipped. The rope snapped taut between their wrists and she took his weight on her chest, one arm behind his shoulders, the other flat on the dirt to stop them both going over. His head dropped against her collarbone. His hair was damp. He was heavy and slack, and the breath dragged in and out of him with that dreadful rattle.

And he was burning.

She put the back of her bare hand against his neck and snatched it away, then put it back. Heat came off him in a slow rush, like the side of a bread oven. It had been hiding under the snow and the shivering and the camphor and the quiet good manners of a man who would not say he was ill. It had been there all day. She had sat across from it and counted sticks.

"Captain," said Meera. "Stay. Say my name. Say anything."

His head moved against her. His lips shaped something she couldn't catch.

Outside, above the hut, a woman had given her a day and a night. Below, the hunters' fires waited on the road, one spark for every scratch on her doorpost. Four hundred paces of ridge and a pocket of herdsmen's trail lay between her and anywhere.

She held a burning man in her arms, and the coat over his heart was warm against her wrist.

Chapter 11

The Lapis Goat

The coat came off him in three pulls, and he never knew it.

Meera dragged the left sleeve over the bound ribs as gently as she could manage, which was not very. Rohan made a sound in his throat and rolled his head against the wall. The heat of him came through his shirt like a stove through a door. She laid the coat on the shelf, unwrapped Jassi's goat-hair cord from his chest, and looked at what lay under it.

Bruise, yellow-green and black, wide as her two hands. And over it, all down the left side, the skin glistened.

"Right," she said. "Counting."

She said it aloud because the hut was too quiet. The breath dragged in and out of him with that wet sound. She fetched the pot, packed it with snow, and set it on the chulha. Then she took the juniper sprig from the nail above the door, the one the crew hung for luck, and stripped it into the water. The needles hissed. The smell came up sharp and clean, like a cold room with the window open.

Four sticks to bring it to a boil. She fed the fire and did not look at the bundle.

She tore a strip from the hem of her own shirt, soaked it in the steaming water, wrung it until her palms stung, and laid it across his ribs. He flinched, then sighed. She did it again. Steep, wring, lay. Steep, wring, lay.

The cloth cooled in a minute against the fire in him, so she kept three going and rotated them like a woman minding bread.

It was not enough. She knew that while her hands were still moving.

Juniper opened a chest. It did not break a fever. For that she had one thing, and it was not hers.

She pulled her pack across the dirt and unrolled the oilcloth at the bottom. Twelve packets lay in three rows of four, palm-sized, wrapped in waxed paper and tied with thread. She had counted them at the salt house and on the Saddle and every night since. She touched the first with one finger and stopped.

Nimmi measured redbark by the pinch: a pinch a dose, morning and night, three days to a course, child or grown man alike. Forty-one sick in the note. She had done that sum on the pass a hundred times, and it had never once come out right.

"Half," she said.

She slit the corner of the first packet with her knife. The powder was the colour of dried blood and smelled of wet bark and iron. She tipped half a pinch from the knife tip into a cup of the hot juniper water and stirred it with a twig until it clouded. Then she raised his head onto her arm.

"Drink. Captain. Drink it."

He swallowed because she pinched his jaw and made him. Most of it ran down his chin. She wiped it and tried again, and the second cup went down better. It was less than a man his size should have. She did not tell herself otherwise.

She folded the packet's corner over and tied it with its own thread. Next she took the waxed notebook out of her coat, found the page, and wrote with the stub of lead.

Redbark, half a pinch. One captain, lung fever. Ranu is one dose poorer.

The line was in the same flat hand as *two hundred and six people* and *eighteen silver*. Nothing in it showed what it cost to put down.

She shut the book.

*

By the time the pot had gone black on the bottom, the shirt strips were steaming on his ribs and the sweat had come out on him in earnest. That was either good or very bad. She sat back on her heels and watched his chest move, one breath, one more, and counted them.

His coat was steaming too, where it lay on the shelf by the fire, soaked with a day of fever. She picked it up to turn it, and her fingers closed on something that was not wool.

Hard. Small. Under the collar, in the seam.

She went still.

Then she turned the coat inside out on her knee and ran her thumb along the lining. A stitched pocket, no wider than her palm, in the seam at the nape, where no hand would go in a search. The thread was a warden's grey. The stitches were close and even. Someone had done this carefully, and not at the post.

Sewn in, Asha had said.

Her knife was out before she decided anything. Six stitches came away, each as neat as a seamstress's, and two fingers went into the pocket. They found a cord first, then the heft at the end of it.

She drew it out into the firelight.

It was a stone no longer than her thumb joint. Lapis, deep as water under ice, flecked with gold dust like a frozen sky. On its face, cut so finely she had to tilt it to see, stood a mountain goat. Horns swept back. Forefoot lifted. One eye, a single pinprick, looking out.

Every child in Hemkot knew that goat from the coins. It had never been on a coin like this.

The queen's seal.

Someone had threaded the cord through a hole in the stone's shoulder and tied it off with a double hitch: two turns round the standing part, a tuck, and a locking half-turn. Every warden tied that knot. It held the notice on the Kothi gatepost, the lanterns on the post wall, and

the noose peg on the deodar. She had seen it ten thousand times and never once held one in her hand.

Her mouth had gone dry.

"Meera."

She jerked. He had said it soft, the way a man says a name to keep hold of it. But his eyes were closed and his head rolled on the wall, and the next word was for somebody else.

"No," said Rohan, quite reasonably. "No, not the grain. The bell. He will have the bell rung for it."

She sat very still, the stone cold in her fist. He had named her in his fever, and she did not know what to do with that, so she did nothing.

"Twenty days." The words came in a rush and a drag, as if he were wading. "Twenty days from the post. Fifteen, now. Sixteen. I have not—it must be pressed before the assembly, before they—" A cough broke him in two. He rode it out with his eyes still shut. "Pritam. He will say she is dying. He will have the Snow Fair say it. They will look at the regent and see a man who feeds them, and—"

Pritam. The regent, in that voice. She'd heard the name said with contempt all her life, but never with the ache of a man who'd carried it a long way.

"Dilan," said Rohan. His hand lifted a little off the dirt. "Mind the thread. Dilan, the thread." And then, very low, "No."

She put the seal down on her knee, picked up a wet strip, and laid it on his ribs. She kept her hand there until he quieted.

Then she sat and put it together, line by line, as she would a ledger.

A regent who wanted Neshar. A queen too sick to ride to a midwinter fair. A fair where the whole assembly gathered below Garh Neshar to hear a man say the queen was dying, and to see him invested before they thought about it. And a warden captain who climbed a closed pass in the dead of winter, against his own law, with a stone in his collar that said otherwise.

Queen's will. He had said it, and his hands had stayed warm. Not a testament. The queen's hand, in the shape of a goat. A seal pressed in front of the assembly would undo whatever Pritam had built.

And that was why Asha wanted the coat. Never the man. Never the redbark. Only this: a stone the length of a thumb joint, and the clerk who would pay a lordship for it, and a pardon, and the end of Pritam's trouble.

She turned it over on her palm. The goat watched her out of one gold eye.

*

She held it a long time.

The fire sank and she did not feed it. Outside, the wind worked at the slates. Rohan's breath rasped on.

Two hundred in silver for the skin, and a hundred more for quiet. That was her own price. The other price was the list, and it was longer. Bindu and her songs. Roop and Chand somewhere on the road. Every name in the salt house, written into a clerk's ledger as pardoned. No more nailed notices. No more pegs. Not one more of her people hanged on the deodar.

And Kiran, with a space beside his name in the regent's book.

And her. She made herself say it, since there was no one awake to hear. The third peg on the deodar was empty, and the name the wardens meant to hammer under it was the Salt Fox. The Salt Fox was Meera of Shilak. Asha's pardon would lift the rope off her own neck first.

There would be silver in it too. Enough for the road to Ranu to stay open, for more redbark than twelve packets, for a lowland physician to climb to the walnut slope and tell Nimmi her count was wrong. The queen's seal was not just a stone. It was the one thing in Hemkot that could buy what she'd have sold her right hand for since she was nineteen.

It was in her hand now. He was lying at her feet with a fever she could let run.

She did not have to cut his throat. That was the clean part of it. She only had to keep the redbark in the oilcloth, and let the juniper go cold, and in the morning walk up the slope with the stone and tell Asha to name her price.

She looked at the man on the dirt.

He hanged two. She knew it as plainly as the heft of the stone. Two lowland men in three winters, and her loads twice, and he had told her himself, without cushioning it, that he hunted the Salt Fox crew for Dilan's sake and meant to bring it in. He did not know whose hands were on his ribs. The Salt Fox was standing over him with his life in her pack.

She could not make that stand for nothing. That was the trouble with a rope that took lies out of your mouth. It put a man's words into your count whether you wanted them or not.

And what would Pritam do with a winter? She knew what he did with grain. He sold it at famine prices to villages like Ranu. A regent invested at the Snow Fair, with no seal to stop him, would own every valley behind that pass. Nimmi's count would be the least of it.

That was a reason, and a good one. But she made herself look at it, because she knew her own mind and did not trust a good reason that arrived so conveniently. It was not why her hands would not close on the stone.

Her hands would not close because of last night. He had lain awake with Dilan's rope end in his fist, thumb working at the cut end, tying and picking the same small knot over and over. She had seen it, and turned her face to the wall, and asked him nothing. Earlier that night he could have asked her about the Salt Fox, and he had asked who taught her the line instead.

He had known what her silence was. She'd felt him know it. And he had not asked for thanks.

"Right," said Meera, to nobody.

*

She did it by the dying fire, slowly, because slow was the only way she would get it right.

The cord had slipped half out when she unpicked it, and she had to find the way it ran. She threaded it back through the hole in the stone, slid it to the shoulder, drew it snug, and put the lapis goat-side down in its pocket, deep in the seam. Her needle was in her coat. Six stitches of the grey thread went in, small and close, to match the six she'd cut. A knot, and she bit the thread.

The cord still hung loose out of the pocket's mouth, a hand's length of it. It needed tying off.

Her fingers made the knot before she'd had a thought. A flat reef with a half hitch, the crew's knot, the one Bindu had taught her at five.

She looked at it.

It was a Kothi Shilak knot, and it sat in the seam of a warden's coat like a signature. If he woke and put his hand to his collar, he would know it in a breath. A man who could read a pass by its pegs could read a knot.

Her thumbnail picked it out.

Then she thought back. The old tie had been plain in the firelight, with the stone lying across her knee. Two turns round the standing part. A tuck. The half-turn that locked it, drawn down tight against the hole. She laid the cord over her fingers and did it as she would copy a line from a ledger. Two turns. The tuck. The locking half-turn. Her fingers wanted to go the other way, the way they had gone for twenty years, and she made them go against it.

It looked right. It looked exactly right. A small, hard tug set it.

She looked up.

His eyes were open.

They were slits, bright and sunk, glazed with fever, and they were on her hands. How long, she could not tell. One thumb still pressed the knot flat, and the coat lay across her knees with the open collar in the light.

He looked at the knot. Then he looked at her face.

A dozen things were there for the saying. *You were burning. I used half a pinch. I found it.* She said none of them. The silence sat between them across the chulha and the cold pot, the third party at the hearing.

His lips moved. No sound came. His gaze went back to the cord, and rested there. Then his eyelids sank slowly, like a man putting down something heavy, and his head rolled gently against the wall.

His breath evened out. Not much, but it evened.

Her hand ached by the time she moved it. She folded the coat over his legs, lifted the strip from his ribs, wet it, and laid it down again.

The notebook came out. The fire gave enough to see by. She found the page where she'd written *Ranu is one dose poorer* and held the stub of lead over the line beneath.

She thought about two hundred in silver. She thought about a space beside Kiran's name, and a peg with her own.

She wrote:

One captain. Price: none.

The stones in the wall hummed their low note and held it. She looked up from the page. Rohan's right hand had crept off the dirt in his sleep, and it lay flat over the seam at his collar, fingers spread, as if to keep something warm.

Chapter 12

Grandmother's Knot

"Lift your hips," Meera said.

"I am able to walk."

"You were able to walk to the wall and back, and the wall won. Lift."

Rohan lay on the hut floor in his blankets with his jaw set. The fever had broken some time before dawn. It had left him pale, hollow at the temples, and polite in the way of a man who has been very ill and wants it understood that he has not been *changed*. The second half-pinch of redbark had gone into him at first light. She had written that down too.

The trouble was the stick count. Twenty-four dry sticks of juniper, and a fever that had eaten four. She needed the day fire built from something else. Outside, ten paces down the slope, a wind-felled juniper lay with its roots in the air and its limbs half buried in snow. Deadfall. It would be wet and smoky and it would sulk, but it would burn, and it would leave the dry sticks for the nights.

Ten paces. Her rope ran eight arm-spans.

She had measured it twice with her arms flung wide, once from the door and once from the sill, and it came out the same both times. From the sill, with the rope paid out to its end, she could just reach the tree's root-ball. The limbs lay a pace beyond that. A pace was a price she could pay, if she kept it short.

So the man would have to go to the door.

"I'll drag you," she said.

"I would rather not be dragged."

"Then crawl."

He looked at her. She looked at him. After a moment he shut his eyes and lifted his hips.

She got the grey pattu under him, and the hut blanket over that, and gathered the corners at his shoulders into one fist. She leaned back and pulled. The whole bundle moved six inches, and Rohan, rolled in it like a dumpling, said something short.

"I didn't hear that."

"I said," said Rohan, with great dignity, "that the floor is uneven."

"It's packed dirt. It's the flattest thing in the hut."

"It has found every rib I own."

She pulled again. The rope between their wrists tangled in his arm, and she had to stop and untwist it, and by then she was laughing in a way she did not like. He heard it. His mouth went thin.

"Guide."

"Sorry. Sorry." She wiped her eye with the back of her glove. "It's the voice. You've a voice for a tribunal and you're being hauled along like a goat on a feast day."

"I have commanded forty men," said Rohan to the roof beam. "I have written to the queen. I am being moved like a sack, by a woman who comments."

"Sacks don't argue."

"This one has begun. I wish it noted that I offered to crawl."

"You didn't. I did."

"Then I wish it noted that I thought of it."

That time the bundle slid a full arm's length, and she got another, and another, and the dirt hissed under the wool. At the door the sill had a lip of old snow. He stuck against it like a cork. She set her boot against the post and gave one great pull that tipped him over the lip and out into the cold, where he landed on his back and said a word she had not known he knew.

It was a good word. It had two syllables and a great deal of feeling in it.

"Captain," said Meera, "I'm shocked."

"You are the one who is shocked." He lay and breathed. A little colour had come up under the pallor, from the effort or the shame. "I believe I will sit now."

She propped him against the doorpost with the pattu round his shoulders. His hair was stuck flat. He looked like a man fished out of a river, holding on to what remained of his manners.

"Stay," she said.

"I am not a dog."

"You're an anchor. Same thing, for the next hour."

*

The morning came up hard and bright, with no cloud on the Saddle. From the doorway the whole slope lay open, a long fall of snow to the black line of the Neshar road, and on the right a rock rib where Asha's camp had sat.

Asha's camp was moving.

Meera stood with the axe in her hand and watched. Four ochre packs were going onto four backs. The second pair doused their stove with snow. Lalit came last, thin as a heron, his spyglass swinging on its cord. At the lip of the rock he turned and looked up at the hut.

She lifted the axe. It was not a wave.

He turned away. They went down in single file, two ropes and four packs, and the lip of the Saddle took them one by one.

"Gone?" said Rohan behind her.

"Down. Not far. She has until the light goes still owing to me, and she's leaving it." She frowned at the empty rock. "Repositioning, or the hunters have called her in. I'll know when I know."

She paid the red rope out to its end and walked.

At eight spans the line drew tight, trembling behind her like a plucked string. The root-ball stood at her elbow. The first limb hung a pace past it. She took that pace.

The leak began with the step: a thin draining of warmth from her ears, then her cheeks, as if someone had opened a door in her. She hooked the axe haft round the limb and hauled. A branch as thick as her arm snapped off at the knuckle. She stepped back inside the line and the warmth rushed home, stinging.

Three trips, three paces past the line, three small thefts of heat. On the fourth she reached for the topmost limb, and something that was not a branch swung against her glove.

A bundle.

It hung in the crook of the tree at head height, wrapped in oilcloth and tied off with a cord, the same ochre as the packs. It had not been there yesterday. Anyone passing could have hung it. Anyone, she thought, who knew exactly where she'd have to come for wood.

"What is it?" Rohan called.

"A present." She untied nothing yet. She stood and looked at the knot.

It was no ordinary knot. She had tied ten thousand and seen more, and she knew a hitch from a bend at a glance, as she knew a face. This started as a loop, drew its tail through the loop's own throat, and came back round to do the same twice more, so that three small loops sat nested in one another. The final tail did not finish. It slid under the first two, like a snake tucking its head beneath its own coils, and left the whole thing tight enough to take a dead lift.

Her thumb went to the tuck and traced it. Once. Twice.

She knew that shape, and not from rope. She had seen it in stone every winter of her life, on the inner face of the Shilak Cairn, where the old carvers had cut two hands bound by a single cord. Where the cord crossed itself between the wrists, it made this figure. She had run her thumb over it as a child, and nobody had told her it was a pattern a per-

son could tie. Once more she had seen it, worn smooth, on the east face of the waystone below the Saddle.

Somebody had tied it onto a bundle of food and left it in a tree.

She cut the oilcloth, not the cord, and worked the knot loose with her fingertips, slowly, to learn how it went. Inside lay a skin bag of sattu, a handful of dried apricots, a twist of salt, and a strip of smoked goat as long as her forearm. A trader's courtesy, or a price tag. She could not tell which.

She carried it back with the last of the wood. The fire took the branches and gave off a sullen white smoke that smelled of resin and wet pennies. She sat down in the doorway beside him with the bundle on her knees. He looked at the apricots, and then at her.

"You will not eat that."

"I'll eat it when I'm hungry enough to count the risk. It isn't poison. A woman who priced me honestly doesn't poison. It's the other thing she's doing."

"Which is?"

"I don't know yet."

She took the waxed notebook out of her coat and found a clean leaf. The lead stub had gone blunt. She laid the cord over her left hand, loop by loop, and drew it as she saw it. Beside it, small, she wrote *Asha's bundle, deadfall, at the rope's end*, and under that, because the thing would not leave her alone: *Same as cairn.*

Rohan was watching the lead move. He read things, as a habit. She could feel him doing it without turning her head.

"May I ask a question?" he said. "Not on the night's account. It has been in my mouth since yesterday."

"It's daytime. Ask. I'll decide whether to answer."

"The post keeps a file on the guides of Shilak. A factor's receipt was seized at Taravan last spring. It shows a crossing paid at twice the Kothi rate." He looked straight ahead. "The same week, a widow crossed with a sick child, by the gatekeeper's tally, and no payment is set against her anywhere. I have read that file eleven times. The sums do not agree, un-

less the rich pay for the poor." He paused. "You charge the rich double, I believe."

She did not stop drawing. She had carried two hundred and six people, and he had found the place where the ledger leaked.

There was no reason to lie, and a lie would have cost her a finger-end. She found she did not want to.

"Yes."

"Why?"

"So the poor cross free."

The chimney drew the white smoke up and away. Down the slope the wind pushed snow across the road in a long, low sheet. Rohan was silent, and not as he went silent over the seal. He sat the way a man does when he has lifted the lid on a pot and found a different dish.

"All of them?"

"All who ask, and can't pay. A widow with a sick child. A shepherd whose flock's on the far side. Taravan factors pay what they're charged and complain about the weather. It balances, if you're careful."

"You are careful."

"I count."

"That is not in the file," said Rohan, slowly. "The gap is there. The reason never was." He rubbed his thumb along his knuckle. "I had a picture of you, Guide. A clear one. I supposed it accurate."

"What was it?"

"A woman who makes money out of a closed road."

"I do make money out of a closed road," said Meera. "I just don't keep it all."

He turned his head and looked at her then, a straight, grave, unsmiling look, and she could not hold it, so she bent over the notebook and shaded the third loop darker than it needed.

*

She ate a strip of Asha's goat, in the end, because her stomach had made up its mind. She watched him watch her do it and did not offer him any.

By noon the fire had settled to a low, dirty orange, and in the doorway the sun lay a hand's breadth across the floor and warmed their boots.

She had answered. It was her turn. The day had no stick rule for turns, but she kept the rule by habit.

"My question," she said.

"You are owed one."

"Not the seal." That was the one she'd bought with silence. "Something plain. Something the file would have. Have you hanged anyone, Captain?"

He did not flinch. She had half hoped he would.

"Two," said Rohan.

"I knew that."

"I know you did. You wished to hear it in my voice." He looked down at his open hands, lying on his knees in the sun. "The first was a lowland runner with a debt to a factor. Thirty-one, I think. He had carried powder for the regent's men over the Saddle two winters running, and I did not weigh whether the regent's men were the worse for him or he for them. He cursed me till the peg, and I thought it fair."

She waited.

"The second was a boy."

The word went in softly and stayed.

"Ketan," said Rohan. "Seventeen. A lowland boy from the Taravan road. His mother had married into Neshar, and she had a cough and no salt for the broth. He was taking her forty pounds of it over the pass. The post sent a patrol. I was the officer. He was alone on a closed pass in the first snow, with no writ, and the law is plain on that." His voice never rose. "He did not curse me. He asked if I would carry the salt to her. I said I could not. A warden who delivers a smuggler's load has harboured it."

Meera watched his hands. The knuckles were pink, the nails clean. They stayed the colour of hands. Not a thread of white anywhere, not a tremor. Only his thumb pressed once, hard, into his own palm, and lay still.

He had said it plainly and every word was true.

"Did you do anything?" she said.

"I paid his mother's fine, when the post fined her for the salt that never reached her." He looked at her. "It was too late for the boy and not for his mother. I do not offer it in defence."

"Good."

"I did not think you would find it so."

"I don't," said Meera.

She waited for the anger. It had been with her for ten winters and she had a place ready for it, with a door and a bolt. It did not come as she'd braced for. She saw a boy of seventeen with forty pounds of salt on his back, and a man in a warden's coat who had said *I cannot* and meant it, and gone on meaning it until the peg.

Forgiveness was not on offer. She wanted that clear to herself. Forgiveness was a thing you gave, and she had nothing to give a man who stood on the right side of a rope and let a boy go through. It was a debt, and it stood on the page of his account, and she did not close the page.

She lifted the lead stub and wrote, below the knot, in the same flat hand as the rest:

Ketan. 17. Salt to his mother. Hanged. The captain's count.

She did not write *two*. She wrote the name. It was the first time she had put a warden's act into the book in his own words.

The sun moved a finger's width across the floor.

"The double price," said Rohan, after a while, "is in no record."

He was not talking to her exactly. He had his head against the post and his gaze on the road. He turned his thumb against his knuckle, over and over, and did not seem to know it.

She was the Salt Fox, and the file had hunted her for three winters without once learning why she was worth keeping.

"No," Meera said. "Nobody writes down what we do for free."

She got up to see to the fire. Behind her the rope ran slack between them across the sill, and neither of them touched it.

From far down the slope, a horn sounded. Two notes, the second falling.

The rope drew taut on her wrist. She had not moved.

"That is the hunters' call," said Rohan quietly. He was already looking at the knot drawing in her notebook. "And it came from where Asha's crew went down."

Chapter 13

Hunters' Fires

Rohan got to his feet on the second try and did not look at her while he did it.

The doorpost took most of his weight. The pattu slid off one shoulder, and his ribs closed round the breath like a fist round a coin. But he stood. The hut floor stayed where it belonged, and the rope between his wrist and hers hung in a slack curve and did not pull.

"Walk," said Meera.

"Where?"

"To the fold in the rock and back. Twenty paces. I'll count."

He walked. The snow outside was crusted and took his boots with a squeak. He kept his left arm pinned against his side and set each foot as if it might be asked to testify. Behind him she counted aloud in the flat voice she used for goats and packets, and he hated, with great precision, every number.

Yesterday she had hauled him across the floor like a sack. He had commanded forty men. He had stood before the queen's chancellor and read out a post's accounts without a stumble. And he had lain in a blanket while this woman laughed so hard she had to stop and untwist the rope.

"Twenty," said Meera. "Turn."

He turned. It cost him. "I apologise for the delay."

"No."

"I beg your pardon?"

"You've said sorry six times since the door. For the delay, for the weight, for the floor. I'm not charging for any of it." She came up beside him, close enough that the rope tightened and eased. "You can say it again if you like, but I've work for your hands and I'd rather they didn't waste breath."

"What work?"

"Rope."

*

She set him on the sill with the red rope across his knees and made him learn it.

It was his own trade turned inside out. A warden used rope to take things: a prisoner's wrists, a load off a mule, a body off a ledge. She used it to keep two people alive. She taught him to pay it out hand over hand when she stepped off the line, so the pull never came as a jerk on a bound wrist. Next came taking in slack against a slide, sitting back with his heel dug in, and reading the tug of her weight by its rhythm. Three short pulls meant halt. One long one meant come.

"You'll do all of it with your right," she said. "The left stays in your coat."

"The left is perfectly—"

"The left lifts nothing above the shoulder. You told me so yourself on the pitch, when you thought you were lying."

He had not thought he was lying. He had simply not said. He closed his mouth and gave her his right hand.

The first bowline came out wrong. The second came out as something that would have slipped under a wet goat. "I am sorry," he said, "I have not tied that one-handed since—"

"Seven."

"You are counting apologies."

"I count everything. A bowline round a post, Captain. The rabbit comes up out of the hole."

The third held. The fourth held. By the ninth he had stopped talking. His fingers knew the work even where his pride did not, and she sat on her heels and watched them as she might watch a horse she was thinking of buying. When he drew the loop tight on the post, she tugged it hard enough to rock him, and it did not move.

"Good," said Meera.

That was all. No grin, no more. But the heat that had been sitting in his face since the doorway eased off, and he found himself looking at his own hand with something close to interest.

Under the collar of his coat, the seam at his nape lay flat and warm against his neck. He knew by touch the knot at the end of the cord. Two turns, a tuck, a locking half-turn. A warden's knot, tied by hands that had spent twenty years tying another. He had said nothing about it. Neither had she. It sat between them like a line in a ledger that neither would sign.

"Again," she said, and he tied it again.

*

The afternoon went to walking. Twenty paces became sixty, then a hundred, to the shoulder of the rock rib where the slope fell away and the whole Neshar side lay open under a white sky. He needed the rest by then. He leaned on the stone with his breath sawing and did what he did best, which was read ground.

The Saddle's lip. The black thread of the Neshar road, switchbacking down. The third bend, half a day off, where a stone fold sat in the lee of a spur and a herdsmen's cut climbed behind it, steep and narrow, to a shrine no one had tended in his lifetime.

"They're lighting early," Meera said.

Smoke. A thread of it at the third bend, then another higher up. By dusk the threads had become fires. He counted them from the rock, as he had once counted torches along a ridge at night, because counting was a way of not feeling. Three at the bend. Two by the stone fold. Four

more above it, strung out on the slope, and one small orange point right at the shrine.

Eleven. All of them climbing.

He frowned. It was wrong, and for a moment he could not say how.

Then he could. The road lay a mile to their left, broad and packed, an easy march for any column that wanted to reach the Saddle. A hunting party with fourteen torches and a horn would take it. They would take it because it was easier, and because they had no reason to be anywhere else.

The fires were not on the road. They were on the cut.

His mouth had gone dry.

The cut was a fallback. It was no part of the pass or of any map the post held. Varun had drawn it at Rohan's direction, at a table in lamplight two nights before the crossing, in case the gully failed. Rohan had held the ruler and spoken the way aloud: from the winter line at the third bend up behind the fold, past the shrine, and round the spur to the Saddle's lip, where a pair on foot could come up unseen by anyone on the road. Varun had drawn it, in his neat hand, on the only copy.

Varun was under the gully. He had been under it for seven days. Rohan had stood on the slide in the dark and dug until his nails split.

So someone had been told. Someone had read the line off a sheet in the post room, or off a wall, or out of a man's head, and carried it down the mountain and sold it. And the cleanest answer, the one that sat there plain as a peg, was—

No.

He did not follow it. He put his hand flat on the stone and made himself look at the eleven fires as if they were eleven fires, and not a sum with only one possible answer. A dead man could not sell a road. Meera? He had named the cut to her himself, on the night of the parley. He counted her, and he struck her out in the same breath: she had been tied to him every hour since, and a woman could not sell what she could not walk away to sell. A living clerk might have copied a sheet. A guard might have talked. It was a long list of other things.

Beside him Meera said nothing. She had put on the snow goggles she had cut from his writ case, and she was watching him through the slit.

"What?" she said.

"Not yet."

His hands stayed warm. It was not a lie, exactly. It was a refusal to say what he thought, which cost nothing, and she knew it as well as he did.

"That's your road," she said quietly.

"It is not a road."

"It's the one you named. The stone fold and the shrine. You said it the night you fell."

"Yes."

"Then I'd say you've a bigger list of people who know it than you thought."

He looked at the shrine's small fire. She was on the list, and he had struck her off, and the list was still too long. "I would say the same," he said.

*

Dusk came down early and blue. In the hut the chulha ticked as it warmed, and Meera knelt at the shelf by the wall with the juniper bundle between her knees. The sticks were pale and dry and about the length of a forearm. She laid them on the shelf in a row and touched each one, moving her lips.

"Nineteen," she said. "Five for the night. That leaves fourteen."

"And eleven days to the Fair," said Rohan. "By my count."

"Mine too." She tied the bundle back. "Fourteen's under three nights. It's less if either of us has to ask something we don't want answering."

"We cannot stay here."

"No. We can't." She sat back. "Two days. The hunters are on your cut. By the day after tomorrow they're on the Saddle's lip, and we're standing in the one place they'll check. We go within two days, whatever the sky says."

"The sky is clear."

"It's clear now."

He did not argue. There was nothing to argue. He had a ruined lung, a left arm good for nothing, and a guide who had measured every risk since the gully and given him the odds out loud. One in four, one in three. He had learned to trust the figures because she had never once rounded them in her own favour.

She fed five sticks to the fire. The room warmed and filled with the clean bitter smell of juniper. He ate sattu from a wooden cup, and she ate it too, and neither of them touched the rest of Asha's bundle.

"My question," he said.

"Go on."

"The Salt Fox." He watched her face and kept his voice level. "You have crossed Shilak for ten winters. You know the crews. Do you know who leads it?"

It was the same question he had asked on the winter line, the night they were bound. He knew that, and so did she.

She did not answer. She sat with the cup in her lap, perfectly still, and the firelight lay along her cheek. Then she reached past him to the shelf, took a sixth stick, and laid it on the fire.

It caught with a crack.

"That's one," said Meera.

Thirteen. He did the sum without wanting to. A refusal cost one stick, and a stick was warmth, and warmth was the hours between them and the Saddle's lip. She would rather burn it than say a word.

There were two reasons a person did that. One was that the answer was no, and she did not care to be questioned. The other he did not follow, because he had refused one such thought already today and had no room for another. Instead he looked at the stick burning down, and at her bare hands round the cup, pink and steady in the heat. She had paid, and not for herself alone.

"I will not ask it again tonight," he said.

"You can ask whatever you like. It's on the account."

"I know." He set down the cup. "I would rather you were warm."

She glanced at him. Her thumb stopped on the rim of the cup and stayed there. She said, "My question, then."

"Yes."

"Why 'Guide'?"

He had expected it, some day. He had not expected it to feel like a hand on the back of the neck.

"You've called me that since the salt house," she said. "In the yard, in the gully, now. I've been called worse and I've been called better. A warden's got a dozen words for a woman on this road. Smuggler. Runner. Whatever's on the notice. You don't use any of them. I want to know why."

He was quiet a while. The truth was a plain thing. The difficulty lay in how much of it was his.

"Every other word for your trade is a word I write on a warrant," Rohan said. "Smuggler. Runner. The crew's name, the name the post gave it. They are names I have put on men before I hanged them. I do not mean to say them to you."

She did not move.

"It is not courtesy," he said. "I want that understood. I will do what the writ says at the thaw, and I will not pretend otherwise. But there is a name for what I may have to do to you, and a name for what you are on this mountain. 'Guide' is the second. You took a stranger with ribs like kindling across the Saddle, and you did not leave him. I will not call you by the other word while you are doing that."

The fire ticked.

He looked down at his own hands on his knees, and they stayed the colour of hands, and he understood that he had put them there to be looked at.

"It is true," he said, unnecessarily.

"I know," said Meera. "I watched."

*

The stove burned down to a red eye. Outside the wind had dropped to nothing, and the quiet had the ringing edge of deep cold.

He had not meant to move. It was the rope that did it. It lay slack between them across the packed dirt, the red wool dark in the dim light, and somewhere in the last hour his right hand had gone down and found it, as a man's hand will find a rail. It lay on the cord a hand's width from her wrist, where the knot sat, the one she had tied and he had tied back.

He knew where it was. He did not take it away.

She had seen it. Her breathing changed, a small, even catch, and she looked at the hand and then at the fire. Her own wrist lay on her knee, bare below the cuff of the glove. She did not draw it back.

Neither of them spoke. There was nothing to say that would have been free.

The cold at the door pressed in. The wool of the rope was dry and a little rough under his thumb, and the heat of her wrist reached him across that hand's width, faint, if he held still and noticed it, which he did. He thought: *this is the first thing she has allowed me.* He did not think anything after that.

Then she said, very low, "Listen."

He had heard it a moment before she spoke and had told himself it was the wind. But there was no wind. The sound came up from the dark slope below the hut, thin and carrying, the way sound carries in cold: a man's voice, young and hoarse with shouting.

"Left of the fold! Keep the cut on your right hand! There's a drop at the shrine, mind the drop!"

Meera had gone rigid. The hand beside the rope turned, very slowly, into a fist.

"Lalit," she said.

Rohan listened. Below the voice came the sound of boots on crust and the clink of iron, a whole line of men feeling their way upward in the dark. Then the calling again, patient and steady, picking the path as a man does who has walked it before.

Keep the cut on your right hand.

Asha's crew was not tracking the hunters. It was guiding them. And the road it was guiding them up was the one drawn on a single sheet of paper, in a neat hand, by a table in lamplight.

He did not move his hand from the rope. He found, to his lasting surprise, that she had not moved hers either.

Chapter 14

Died on the Pass

Lalit's voice stopped, and the silence after it was worse.

Meera stood in the doorway with her fist still shut and listened to eleven fires climb the cut. Below the hut the cairn-light lay faint on the slope, a blue thread laid over the dark. Far down, a rope of orange points crept along the herdsmen's way. They were not hunting. They were being led.

"She said the light," she said. "She gave me the day and the next until the light went, and she hasn't waited a day past it."

"She is not bound to you," said Rohan behind her. "Her word cost her nothing."

"I know what her word cost." She turned back into the hut. "Lalit's calling the road like a man who's walked it. Somebody gave her your fallback, and she sold it on. That's all I've got, and I'll thank you not to ask me what I think of it."

"I did not intend to."

"Good. Come to the fire. I need your eyes and your opinion, in that order."

She knelt at the chulha, tore a clean leaf from the back of the count, and drew by the red light. The hut at the rock rib. The Saddle's lip. The cut, with its fires. The road, broad and obvious and, by morning, full.

"They come up the cut tonight and tomorrow," she said. "By the day after, they hold the lip and the road both. We can't go by the road. We can't go by the cut. That leaves the Teeth."

"The Teeth."

She drew a row of small jagged marks along the south-east shoulder, where the Saddle broke away into stone. "A spine of rock, steep as a roof. It drops two thousand feet to the Neshar side and comes out below the third bend, past the hunters' backs. Crews call it the Goat's Teeth because a goat could do it and nothing else could. Jassi named it. He hated it more than any place on earth."

The last word caught. She laid her palm flat on her coat, over the small dented bell buttoned there beside Kiran's note, and went on.

"It's three ledges, two ropes' worth of down-climbing, and a chimney with ice in it. A pair who knew it could do it in a day and a half. A pair with one good arm will want two."

"A day lost."

"A day lost, or the hunters. I'll take the day."

He studied the drawing for a long time. He did not argue. He asked about the ledges, how wide and how long, and where she would stand to belay him. She told him. He asked what she would do if he came off.

"Sit down hard and swear," said Meera. "You've been practising the sitting."

His mouth moved, barely. It was a smaller thing than a smile.

Something had bothered her since noon, and she got up and went to the door to look. The stars had been thick and cold an hour ago. Now they were going out in the west, not in clouds but in a slow greasy smear, as if someone had breathed on a window. Over the Long Saddle the sky had gone the colour of old tallow.

"What?" said Rohan.

"The sky's turning." She counted the missing stars under her breath. Eleven. Twelve. "I've seen that smear before a storm. It might hold off a day. It might be on us by morning."

"Then we go before it."

"We go before it, and we pray the Teeth are dry."

"I do not pray."

"No," said Meera. "I don't suppose the post allows it."

She shut the door and set the bar, then sat across the chulha from him with the plan between them. Tomorrow they would be two people on a rope, and the night belonged to them still.

*

She banked the coals rather than feed them. Then she reached for the branch of wet juniper deadfall she had dragged in at dusk to dry on the stones. It was meant for tomorrow's kettle, and it was the only wood in the hut that wasn't counted.

"Another round," she said.

"We have both asked tonight. I the matter of the name, you the matter of 'Guide'."

"This buys one for each of us." She laid the damp branch across the coals. It hissed, then sulked, then gave out a thin sour smoke and almost no heat. "That's the price. A night colder, and no kettle at first light. I'm tired of rules that cost me sleep, so I'll pay for the one I want." She leaned her back against the shelf. "Why keep the law, Captain?"

He did not answer at once. He had the pattu round his shoulders and the red rope across his knee, and his right hand had found the knot in it again.

"You have an answer to that," he said. "Everyone does."

"I've got mine. Mine's ten winters old and has a grave in it. I want yours."

"Then you shall have it, though you will not like it." He looked at the fire. "My grandfather died on the pass."

She said nothing.

"It was sixty winters ago, the winter before the Closing Law. He was a warden of the Shilak post, before the post had a hall. I never knew him. My father told it as a short story, the way men tell what hurts. There was a storm, and he went out at night to check the cairns for a lost party, and

a whiteout took him. They found him at the thaw. The law was written the next spring." He turned the rope a quarter turn. "My father said it was for him. So that no one else would go out on that mountain in a winter storm to bring in a fool who had no business there. I believe it was an accident. I think it very likely that it was a stupid one. He was a good man doing a thing he need not have done."

"So no one dies that way," she said.

"No one on my watch. Not a warden. Not a fool. Not—" He stopped, and she saw him decide to finish. "Not a boy like Dilan, chasing a runner onto the ice in the dark, because a runner was on the ice at all."

"The runner was on the ice because a sick village was on the other side."

"I know that."

"Do you?"

"I know it now," said Rohan. "I did not know it as I know it this week. I said the law keeps the strong from the passes. It does. Pritam would have the Shilak open to his grain wagons by midwinter if it did not. I said it keeps my wardens off the mountain. It does, a little. I have buried seven. I know the tally of both."

"My mother died of the grey cough in a closed winter," Meera said. "Ten winters ago. The medicine was in a lowland shop three days off, and the law said no one crossed, and no one did. That's my tally. One."

"One is enough."

"For me. It's not enough for you, though, is it? You'd weigh her against seven wardens and the grain wagons." She heard her own voice go flat, which meant it was close to shaking. "You'd do the sum, and she'd come out light."

"I would not do the sum with her in it."

"You'd have to."

"Yes," said Rohan. He looked up and met her eyes, and he did not look away. "That is what I am telling you. I would have to. And I have done it, and signed it, and hanged a boy by it. I do not say the sum is

kind. I say it is the only sum I have, and that I begin to think the sum is wrong, and I do not know yet what to put in its place."

The banked fire settled. The wind had come up outside, and the roof beam creaked under it.

She had come to the question with a place ready to put his answer. A cruel man would have fit it. A stupid one would have fit it. It did not fit a man who had stood on a mountain with a dead man's rope in his coat and said *begin to think*.

The law's hand and the law's victim sat in one ledger, and she had no column for a man like this.

"Your turn," she said, and her voice came out rough. "Ask."

He thought about it. She watched him pick one question up and put it down, and pick up another.

"If the law were gone," said Rohan. "Tomorrow. Struck off the roll. No peg, no notice, no warden on the Saddle. What would you do?"

She had thought about that more than once in ten winters and never said the answer. She said it now.

"Sleep."

He blinked.

"That's it?"

"That's the whole thing." She laughed, short and surprised, and it hurt in her chest. "I'd carry the medicine over in daylight, on the road, with a mule. I'd get home before dark. I wouldn't count anyone's fingers. I wouldn't hide a packet in a wool bale or go to bed with a boot on in case the salt house door got kicked. I'd put my head down and sleep through a night." She rubbed her eyes with the heel of her glove. "Ten winters. I can't remember it."

"Sleep," said Rohan, as if testing a word in another language.

"Don't."

"I am not laughing."

"You are. Your mouth is."

"It is a very small laugh." He ducked his head, and for the first time she saw the line of his throat move without a cough behind it. It was not an official face. She did not think anyone had seen it in a long while.

She put it in the count in her head, where the other things went.

*

She let the quiet sit for a while. Then she asked the thing she had carried since the yard.

"There's a widow in Kothi Shilak," she said. "Puja. Her husband had a lean-to behind the house, and the patrol found salt in it the autumn he died. They fined her eighteen silver, and she hadn't eighteen coppers. The night before we crossed, she had it, and she wouldn't say from where." She kept her eyes on the fire. "She told me in the yard before dawn that a cousin brought it. She has no cousin with eighteen silver. And I watched you leave her step."

He did not move.

"And there was Ketan's mother. You said it yourself. And I'd lay money there are others." She waited. "Do you pay the fines of the poor families, Captain?"

That made two questions from her in one round, and she knew it. The bought round was spent. He owed her nothing, and a refusal would not have been charged.

Rohan looked at the rope across his knee, as a man looks at a thing he has been asked to carry in front of a crowd.

He did not answer.

She knew what he would do; she had learned it over nine days. He leaned and took a stick from the shelf. It was one of the pale, dry ones, and he held it a moment, then laid it on the coals without a word. It caught and burned.

"That's twelve," said Meera.

"Yes."

His hands lay in the light, easy and warm, steady, the nails pink as hers. There was no lie in them, because he had not told one. He had

spent a stick of juniper he need not have spent rather than say a thing aloud.

She had hated him for three winters on the strength of a notice nailed to a gatepost and two pale pegs on a tree. She had no wish to stop. It would have been easier. But the hatred had a hole in it now, the exact size of a man who paid fines in the dark, and every honest thing she had learned this week fit into it.

"You don't have to say," she said quietly. "I'm not asking you to."

"I know."

"I know too, then."

He did look at her at that. She had not meant it as an answer, and he took it as one, and his shoulders eased as if a rope had been paid out an inch.

"Thank you," said Rohan, "for not saying it for me."

*

The fire had burned low and the room had shrunk around it. At some point she had moved. Or he had. She was sitting on her heels at the edge of the hearth stones and he was beside her, and the rope between their wrists had gone slack and curled on the dirt like a sleeping thing. She could see the pulse in his neck. She could smell camphor from the pattu and juniper smoke and, underneath, the clean tired smell of a man who had been ill and was not now.

His hands had caught her eye in the gully, and again on the sill, when he took the bowline for the ninth time. An hour ago he had laid one on the cord a hand's width from hers and had not taken it away, and she had told herself it was nothing.

Now he was looking at her mouth.

He did not lean. He sat still as he had sat for the Saddle's wind, giving her the whole of the choice. There was a breath's width between them, and he was not going to cross it.

She lifted her hand and laid it along his jaw. The stubble rasped against her glove. His eyes closed, briefly, as if he had braced for a blow and found only a touch.

"Guide," he said, very low.

She was close enough to feel it. She could have done it. Her heart was going in her throat like a goat on a ledge, and there was a hunger in it she had not given room to in years, because it was a luxury and she did not keep luxuries.

Say something true, she thought. *It'll be free.*

The truest thing she owned was not the hunger. She was the Salt Fox. She had known it since the third empty peg on the hanging tree in Kothi Shilak. And an hour ago, with his hands warm in the firelight, he had said, *I will do what the writ says at the thaw.* He had not yet joined that name to her face. He read files eleven times over; he would.

She took her hand away.

"No," said Meera.

He opened his eyes. He did not look hurt. He looked, if anything, as if he had expected it and wanted to be told the reason.

"I'm not saying it's hate," she said, and made herself hold his gaze, because anything less would be a small lie in its own right. "It was, a week ago. It isn't now. I'd like you to know that, since you like things written down." She drew a breath. "But you said the writ comes due at the thaw. You said it with your own mouth and I watched your hands stay warm. So at the thaw you deliver me. I'll walk beside you down this mountain, and I'll hold your rope, and I'll tell you the truth when I can afford it. But I don't kiss my noose."

The fire cracked.

Rohan's eyes went still on the word *me*. It lasted half a breath. Then they moved on, to the fire, and his face gave her nothing at all.

She had said it plain, and on purpose. Tomorrow he would be hanging on her rope above two thousand feet of air. He could choose his next step knowing that she knew what he carried.

"That is a better reason than the last one," he said at last.

"I didn't give you a last one."

"You gave me a week of them. They were all about what I am." He lowered his head. "This is about what I will do. It is a fair reason, and I cannot answer it, because it is true."

"You could promise," she said. It slipped out. "You could say you won't."

"I could. And the mountain would hold me to it." His voice was steady, and gentle, and it was the gentleness that made her throat tight. "I will not promise what I do not know I can keep, Meera. Not to you. Not when it would cost you my hands."

It was her name, plain, with no *Guide* in front. He did not seem to notice. She noticed for both of them.

"Sleep," she said, a little hoarsely. "We go before light."

"Yes."

"I'll take the shelf. You take the floor."

"That is the second time you have given me the floor."

"It's a good floor. It's very flat."

"It has found every rib I own," said Rohan, and she nearly laughed, and had to turn her back to lie down.

*

She woke in the dark with the rope tugging at her wrist, one long pull, *come*, and he was at the door with the bar already lifted.

He did not speak. He only stood aside.

The wind had gone. That was the first wrong thing. After a night of rising wind, the Saddle lay in a silence so complete that the snow seemed to be holding its breath. The cairn-light on the slope had thinned to a single blue thread.

The second wrong thing was the west.

It stood over the Long Saddle like a wall, black at the base and bruise-yellow along the crest, and it did not look like cloud. It looked like a cliff that had decided to walk. The top of it caught a colourless light from somewhere, and below that the whole range had vanished, stripped out,

as if a hand had wiped a slate. A single low sound came out of it, the groan of a very large thing shifting its weight.

Far down the slope, thin and small, a two-note horn answered it. Falling, falling.

"Twelve sticks," Meera said, because her mouth needed something to count. "Two days down the Teeth, with your arm, if the ledges hold."

"And the wall?"

"Hours." She took the pack from beside the door and slung it on, and the bell shifted against her ribs and rang once, soft and dented. "Maybe less. Rope up, Captain. We're going down into it."

Chapter 15

The Goat's Teeth

Iron rang on stone somewhere below the second ledge. Three clean strikes, a pause, three more.

Rohan went flat against the rock and raised his right fist. Above him, Meera stopped paying out the rope at once. They had come onto the Goat's Teeth at first light, and for two hours she had fed him down the spine as if he were a bucket in a well. He had stopped noticing her hands on the line. It was the best thing a man could say about a belay.

"Picks," she said, low, coming down the last pitch to the ledge. "Two pairs, by the sound. They're in the chimney."

"They were told the Teeth."

"Or they guessed. Every crew on the salt road knows what a goat can climb." She kept her eyes west, where the black wall stood on the edge of the sky, no nearer than at dawn and no farther. "Four hours before that breaks. Three, if it's in a hurry. I'd like to be off this rock before it decides."

"Then I had better be quick."

"You'd better be tidy. There's a plate of ice under your left heel."

He shifted his weight before he had finished hearing it.

The ledge was two strides long and a yard wide, with a rock horn at the south end and the chimney's mouth at the north. A man coming up the chimney had to come over the lip alone. Rohan put the horn at his back and pinned his left arm against his side. A warden took the weapon

first, the wrist second and the life never, unless the writ named it. He had taught that to forty men. He had not taught it with two cracked ribs.

The first hand came over the lip. Then a hood, and a broad face under it. The man saw Rohan and did not look surprised.

"Captain," he said, almost pleasantly. "There's a lordship on your head."

"So I am told. Come up slowly."

The man did not. A hand-axe came up on a wrist loop in a short, hard arc. Rohan took the haft across his right forearm, turned in under the swing and rolled the wrist outward until the fingers had to open. The axe dropped into his palm. He threw it over the edge and heard nothing land. The man's other fist caught him on the cheekbone. Rohan let it. Dodging would have cost him a rib.

The second hunter came over the lip with a short sword already drawn. The tarred climbing line between the two men, three arm-spans of it, snagged on the first man's boot, and the sword came in crooked across his partner's back.

"Left!" Meera shouted from above. "He's low, Captain, *left*!"

He was already going. He trapped the sword arm against the horn, laid the heel of his right hand on the wrist and bore down over the stone edge. The bone gave with a small, dry sound. The sword rang on the ledge. The man screamed once and bit it off.

Rohan stepped on the line between them and held it there.

"Yield," he said. His breath sawed. "Both of you. Now."

They yielded. The first man sat down with his empty hand in his lap, and the second folded round his wrist and rocked. Neither looked like a man who had been promised a lordship. They looked cold, and young under their beards.

"The ice was real," Rohan said, up the rope. He did not know why he said it.

"I know," said Meera. "I read it."

That was all, and it was enough. For a moment he had stood on a yard of stone with a sword at his back, and a woman he did not trust

with his name had told him where to put his feet. He had put them there without arguing.

*

He searched the men for knives and orders. The second carried a flint and a clasp-knife and nothing else. The first, the broad one, wore a leather purse at his belt, and in it were three silver pieces, a pinch of salt in a rag, and a twist of waxed paper no longer than a thumb, tied off with thread.

He knew it before he had it open. Powder, rust-red, and a smell like old tea and bitter bark. Redbark.

He turned the twist to the light. Along the fold, pressed into the wax, was a faint round mark, a ring within a ring. It was the print of a silk sieve in the guild stores in Taravan, where crown medicine was sifted and weighed. He had seen that same ring on a wrapper in Meera's oilcloth roll. He had told himself then that it meant nothing, that crown-grade bark could be had by anyone with enough silver.

A regent's hunter did not buy medicine for a sore chest. This was a crown packet, and it was not in a crown store.

He closed his fist on it. Meera was looking down the chimney, not at him. He put the twist inside his coat, against the shirt, and said nothing, because he did not yet know what the saying would cost.

"Captain." Her voice had changed. "Come and look at this, and tell me I'm wrong."

Below the throat of the chimney the second pair had stopped. Two hoods, forty feet down, their picks driven into the ice. One of them had a hand up to his eyes, looking at the ledge.

"They've seen the others," said Rohan.

"They've seen the others went quiet." She pointed across the chimney with her axe. "Look up there."

A tongue of snow hung off the shoulder on the far side, grey-white and smooth as a plastered wall. Along its top lip ran a thin black crack. "That's slab. The wind built it in the last storm and it's been sitting on a

skin of nothing ever since. Hear that?" She struck it with the haft from the end of the ledge, and it answered with a flat, hollow note, like a drum with no skin.

He understood. "You can bring it down."

"I can cut it. I can't tell you how far it runs." She counted it out as she would count goats. "Five in six it dumps itself in the throat and stops. One in six it takes the chimney and the ledge and us. And it's what's between us and a fight I'd rather not have."

He thought of the other slide, and of Jassi. Meera was thinking of it too. She laid her palm on her coat, over the small dented bell, and the hand was not quite steady.

"You were the one who read the gully," Rohan said. "I would be a fool to argue the slope."

"You are a fool. A tidy one." But the corner of her mouth moved. "Take my rope, and keep it short. If I shout, sit down hard."

"And swear."

"I'll do the swearing."

She went out along the north end of the ledge, as far as eight arm-spans would let her, and he paid the line out with his heel dug into the stone. She did not look back. She set the adze of her axe in the crack, leaned on it, and the crack ran. Then she stepped back, once, and kicked.

The slab slid off the shoulder with a long sigh. It was not the roar he remembered. It slid, bowed and broke, and poured into the chimney's throat in a grey rush, packing as it fell. Spindrift blew across the ledge and stung his face. Below, a voice cried out, and a pick rang, and then there was only the settling hiss, and a wall of tight white snow where the chimney had been.

No blue light had stirred. It was snow, and her knowledge of it, and the stone it hung on. He had not thought to be glad of that.

She came back along the ledge with her face grey. "They'll dig," she said. "It'll take them till dark. I didn't want them under it." She took a breath. "I didn't."

"I saw," said Rohan.

"There's a price in it." She nodded at the white plug. "That chimney was our road down. I've shut it along with theirs. We climb back to the hut and sit out the storm, and look for another line when it clears."

"Then we climb," said Rohan.

The two hunters on the ledge had watched all of it without a word. He knelt and splinted the broken wrist with the man's own scabbard and a strip of his cloak, because it was what a warden did. Then he stood, and they looked up at him.

"The storm will be here within the hour," he said. "Your friends will dig through by evening. Get into the lee of that rock, put on both cloaks between you, and keep each other awake." He had no better counsel. It was not enough, and he knew it, and they knew it.

"Captain," said the broad one, as Meera drew the rope tight. "You'll not make the Neshar side."

"Nor you," said Rohan. "Not this week."

*

The wall reached them on the climb back.

First came the wind, a clean cold shove that nearly took Rohan off the second pitch. Then the light went. It went the way a lamp does when a hand is laid over it, and the Saddle above them turned the colour of tin and then of nothing. Snow came sideways, fine as flour. He could not see the rock he gripped. He could not see his own hand.

He could see the rope. A short curve of red wool went up into the white, and at its end was a woman's wrist.

"Cairn-light!" Meera shouted. He barely heard her. "Watch for the blue, Captain! It'll come!"

It came. Faint at first, a thread laid over the nothing, and then thicker, a line of cold sapphire running up the spine of the Teeth and across the Saddle's shoulder. He had never seen it so near. He set each boot where the blue touched the rock. Every breath caught on the seventh and eighth ribs like a hook in a sleeve, and his left shoulder burned from the socket down. The thread did not waver, and the mountain, which had

been trying to kill them all morning, closed its hand at last round the path and let them walk it.

How long it took he could not have said. Hours, perhaps. When the door of the Rope-Hut came out of the whiteness it was dark already, and the bare nail above it was furred with ice.

*

Meera barred the door with both hands and leaned her back on it.

"Light," Rohan said. He was down on one knee by the chulha, unable to rise. "I will do it. You have the flint."

"I've the flint." She held it up between finger and thumb, and it dropped. She looked at it on the dirt. She tried to pick it up, and her fingers would not close.

He saw her hands then. She had stripped her gloves for the axe work, for the slab and the knots in the chimney, and she had not put them back on in the wind. The skin was swollen and a hard, shining red, split across both knuckles. A strip of the haft's varnish was ground into the palm. She held them in front of her like things belonging to another woman.

"Give me your hands," said Rohan.

"It's ordinary cold. Not the other kind." Her voice was thin. "I'd know."

"I know. That is why I am asking."

She did not move. He took off the pattu, opened his coat, and then the shirt beneath it, on the right side where the ribs were sound. The air struck his skin like a slap. He held out his own hands, palms up, and waited. It was the first thing in ten days he had asked of her without a writ behind it.

She put her hands in his.

They were as cold as the stones of the cairn. He drew them in against his bare side and held them there, her palms flat on his ribs below the arm, and he did not flinch, though it was a near thing.

He braced anyway. It was an old, absurd habit, the way a man braces for a cold plate. If there had been lie-cold in her hands, he would have taken it through the skin and known at once that she had lied to him, and how greatly, and nothing else. He had held them anyway. He found he could bear that. There was only the ordinary cold, slow and honest, draining out of her into him.

"That hurts," said Meera.

"It will for a while."

"I wasn't complaining."

"You are doing it very well."

She made a sound that might have been a laugh. The blood was coming back into her fingers, and he felt it as a faint pulse against his side and then a tremor. She hissed through her teeth and did not pull away. Her forehead came down, briefly, against his shoulder, the width of a breath, and lifted again.

"This isn't—" she said.

"No," said Rohan. "I do not think it is."

She did not say what it was. She sat with her palms flat against him till the red had turned to pink, and the pink to the colour of hands. Then she took the flint from the dirt, struck it, and lit the chulha with a single stick of the juniper. The fire caught and held. The warmth reached her face.

She looked at her fingers in the glow, and flexed them. "Fire warms this kind," she said. "And so does a hand."

"Both work," said Rohan.

"Don't make a speech."

"I had not planned one."

*

She counted the sticks by firelight. She laid them in a row on the dirt against the wall beside the door, the one stretch of floor the roof drip never reached, because wet juniper smoked and she would not burn smoke. She touched each one with a finger that finally obeyed her.

"Eleven," said Meera. "One to light. Eleven left, and a night of storm."

He did not answer. He was thinking of the twist inside his coat, and of the ring pressed into its wax. He had held it back on the ledge for no better reason than that he did not know how to hold it. Now there was a fire, and her warm hands, and he had no excuse left. He took it out and laid it on the hearth stone between them.

"I took this from the broad man's purse," he said. "Before the slide."

She looked at it. For a time she did not touch it. Then she bent close, picked it up, and turned the fold to the fire with her thumb along the wax.

"Redbark," she said. She held very still. "It's the guild's silk. That's the sieve ring, there, same as—"

She stopped. She looked up at him, and then, quickly, away, to the oilcloth roll beside her pack.

"The redbark in my pack and that purse came from the same—"

The door burst inward.

The bar did not break so much as leave, its old frost-split giving at last. The whole slab of oak went over on its hinges with a groan like a deodar splitting in a hard frost, and the night came in on top of it, white and howling. The chulha flared and went flat. Ash and sparks flew across the floor. Rohan saw the row of sticks by the wall lift and scatter, rolling and skidding, and the wind took them as a hand takes a fistful of straws and swept them across the sill, out into the dark.

"The wood!" Meera was already moving.

He was moving too. The rope snapped taut between them. She had dived for the door, and he was a pace behind, and the first stick had gone past the sill and was sliding downhill toward the felled juniper, a pale line against the black. Behind it went another, and another, and the snow rose to meet them.

Eleven sticks. And past eight arm-spans of rope, the mountain would not let either of them go to fetch them.

Chapter 16

What the Storm Kept

For one stupid breath, Meera thought the rope tied her to the door.

Then the second stick slid past the sill, and her head cleared. The rope did not tie her to a doorway. It tied her to Rohan.

"Together!" she shouted into the roar. "Same pace, rope short! Stay on my left!"

They went out into it shoulder to shoulder. Snow came flat across the slope and filled her mouth. The cairn-light was out there, though, a blue thread under the white, and by its glow she saw the pale sticks skidding downhill toward the wind-felled juniper. She went down on her knees and swept her arm through the drift. One. Two. Rohan crouched beside her, working one-handed, his left arm clamped to his side. He pulled a stick from the snow and held it up, grinning like a boy.

"Four," she yelled. "Five!"

The sixth was wedged in the juniper's root plate. The seventh lay half buried under her own knee. After that there was nothing. She felt along the deadfall's trunk until the wind drove her off, and then she saw the rest go. Four pale lines slid over the lip of the slope into the dark, and the dark took them.

"Seven," said Rohan in her ear. His breath rattled, but it was only the ribs. "Meera. Seven is what there is."

"I can count."

"Then count inside."

They went in. It took both of them to haul the oak slab back onto its hinges. She wedged the split bar against it, lashed the halves with Jassi's goat-hair cord, and jammed her pack against the foot. The wind still found the gaps. It whistled through the seam like a kettle.

She sat down on the hearth stones and found she was shaking, and not from cold.

*

She laid the sticks across her knees where the snow couldn't get at them. Seven pale lengths of juniper, each as long as her forearm.

"Five for the night," she said. "That's what a storm night costs when the fire's honest and the door's bad. Two left for morning. After that, the deadfall. Wet wood, and no way to keep it lit."

"And tomorrow?"

"If it blows out by dawn, we find another line down. If it doesn't, we sit." She turned a stick over. "I can do all that arithmetic. There's one more sum, and it's the one that matters."

Rohan had set himself against the wall across from her with the pattu round his shoulders. The fire put red along his cheek and none in his eyes.

"Say it."

"Fire doesn't warm lie-cold." Her voice went level, the way it did at a cornice. "Not a small one. Not a joke that isn't quite a joke. We have seven sticks, Captain. If either of us lies tonight, it's a night of shaking and no way to put it out. So no lies. Nothing but the true thing, whatever it costs, and we spend what we have to."

"That is a harder rule than the firewood."

"It's the same rule. We just never said so."

He looked at the fire. He looked at her hands, lying open and ordinary in her lap. "You have wanted to say something," he said slowly, "since the hearth stone."

"Since the yard."

"Then say it. I will not hold the stick for you."

She had rehearsed it for ten days. In the rehearsals it came out as a speech, with the crew's reasons ranked in order and a dying brother at the end for weight. None of that came now. What came was the deodar outside the Kothi gate, and its pegs, one for every hanging, two of them pale from last winter. There was a third hole, the empty one. She had counted it every morning for three winters.

The truth would not cost her a finger. Truth was warm. That was the trap in it. A refusal would burn a sixth stick, and a sixth was tomorrow's. She could not buy her way out of this with wood.

"I am the Salt Fox," said Meera.

The fire ticked. She watched her own fingers, because that was where a lie would show, and they stayed pink and warm and bent a little at the split knuckle. The wind howled at the door and nothing in the hut answered it.

"It isn't a crew," she said. "Not the way your post files it. It's me. I run it. I've run it ten winters. The packets in my pack are mine and the debt's mine, and every salt-house cellar you've seized was one of my doors." She did not stop. "That's the true thing. You can do what you want with it."

Rohan did not move. Silence was free, and he spent it. It ran on until the fire cracked in it. She looked at his hands resting on his knees, because she could not look at his face. They told her nothing. They stayed still.

"I suspected," he said at last.

"You didn't know."

"I did not. I will be exact, now that exactness is free. You said *you deliver me* in this room, and I have been trying very carefully not to hear it since. I suspected and I chose not to know. That is not the same as ignorance, but it is not far from it."

"Why?"

"Because if I knew, I would have to write it."

She breathed out slowly. It was not what she had braced for. She had braced for the warden, the iron voice. She had not braced for a man who had spent a week declining to open a letter.

"Now you," she said.

"Yes." He sat forward, wincing. "My writ orders me to deliver the Salt Fox to the warden-judge at Taravan at the thaw. Whoever it is. Alive, if the mountain permits."

His fingers stayed pink in the firelight. Nothing in them changed.

"Then that's both of us," said Meera. Her mouth was dry. "The two things that make us enemies, said aloud, and neither of us froze."

"No." He turned his hands over on his knees, palms up, and let her look. "Still warm."

"Say what you are, then. All of it."

"I am the man who must hand you to the rope. You are the woman I must hand over. And I am sitting here warm."

*

The twist of redbark lay where she had dropped it, by the hearthstone, one corner scorched by flying ash. She picked it up. Her hands were steady now, which she resented.

"Tell me where you got this."

"The broad hunter's purse. With three silver and a pinch of salt."

She set a packet from her own roll beside it, wax fold turned up, so the two sieve rings lay together in the red light. "Same ring. Same guild wrapper. And my crates came to me with the crown stamp scraped off the lids." She heard how it sounded. "I buy from a lowland middleman I have never met. His carter leaves me a brass button at each drop. The next courier carries its twin, or no crate moves. I thought it was a good arrangement. I never once asked why it was so good."

Rohan's face changed. "A brass button. Small, domed, plain."

"Why?"

"Varun has a new one on his coat. Brass, among pewter. A pedlar sold it to him, he said, after he lost one on the stair." He looked at the fire. "I remember because he laughed at how long the pedlar took to find brass."

The storm hit the door and went on.

She dug past the packets and brought out the waxed notebook. The count. She found the page by feel and held it to the fire. "Asha's tracker, Lalit, called your party to me across the ridge. I wrote it down because numbers are what I do. *Three wardens, two goat-folk.*"

Rohan read it over the edge of the page. His mouth went thin. "I struck the third name before we rode. I named two in the yard. The only paper that ever said three was Varun's sheet."

She did not stop to argue the rest. The gully he had picked over her odds. One clean ring of iron before the first crack. Varun dropping back for a strap. She said them like a count, fast, and Rohan nodded at each, because he had been there, and now he had the sum.

"And the Teeth," he said. "The pairs came up the one chimney that lets out behind the stone fold, on the herdsmen's cut. That is my fall-back. I held the ruler. Varun drew it, in his own hand, on a single sheet. Only the two of us ever saw it." He touched his collar. "And what they would pay a lordship for. The queen's seal. You have held it. The cord was tied my way when I woke, but snugged harder than I snug it, and I have wondered who taught you the hitch. I told Varun I carried it. I told the queen. No one else alive."

She laid the hunter's twist beside her own packet on the hearth stone, the two sieve rings together.

Neither of them spoke. The fire ticked. The wind leaned on the door and let go. Silence was free, and they let it run.

*

"Ten winters I've paid that button," said Meera. She hadn't meant to speak. "Every season, silver for the drop. Honest silver, most of it from the rich merchants who pay double, so the poor cross free. It all went to the middleman. To Varun. And Varun belongs to the regent."

"Meera."

"My lifeline was your enemy's purse." The words came out in her own flat counting voice. "The medicine keeping Ranu alive, and Kiran, was bought with money that went into Pritam's coat. I've been paying for the coup you're riding to stop. Every winter. For the price of a village's cough."

"You did not know."

"Jassi didn't know either. And he's dead." She pressed the heel of her hand against one eye. "That's the sum, Captain. Don't tell me it's different."

"It is not different. Hear mine."

She nodded.

"I have known Varun ten years. I stood at his wedding. He was the first man at my shoulder when Dilan died, and the last to leave the hall after I swore my oath over that rope." He turned back the front of his coat, and the clean-cut end of Dilan's rope showed in the lining, grey and neat. "I gave him my route. I gave him the seal. I told him the one fact that would hang me. I trusted the man who killed Jassi, and tonight I would have called him dead and grieved."

"You didn't know either."

"I am not asking pardon." He opened his fist on his knee. "We fed the same hand. Your silver. My faith."

She laughed once, a cracked sound. It did not feel like a joke. It felt like a latch letting go.

"Four crates in the salt-house top room," she said. "All four lids scraped clean. I thought a clerk had been careless. Somebody scraped them so no warden would read a crown stamp. Somebody who knew which wardens read stamps."

"He chose the gully," said Rohan. "I thanked him for it." He nodded at the red rope on the dirt between them. "And the mountain has been telling me since the cairn that you were honest. I kept filing it under something else."

Sparks lifted from the fire. The wind eased for a moment and rose again.

She had two choices, then. She could go on sitting on her side of the hearth with the whole truth lying between them. Or she could stop.

*

She did not remember deciding it.

She was on her knees on the hearth stones, and he was a hand's breadth away, and neither of them was pretending the distance was an accident. She had refused him before. She had said *I don't kiss my noose*, and she'd meant it. Then he hadn't known who he'd be kissing, and she had, and that was a lie of its own, even in silence.

It was worse now. He knew her, name and crime and crew. She knew exactly what he carried for her and when he must use it. There was no second reading left to hope for.

"Tell me why I shouldn't," she said.

"You have the reasons," said Rohan. "I have given you every one. At the thaw I must take you to Taravan. You would be kissing the man who carries your rope." His voice dropped. "I would be kissing the Salt Fox, and I would be a warden who knew it."

"That's all of it?"

"That is all of it, and it is enough to stop me. I will not move. You will tell me which."

She put her hand against his jaw and did not take it away.

He kissed like a man reading a document he had waited a long time to sign. Slow, and careful, and entirely there, with his right hand coming up to cradle the back of her head as if it might break. She tasted smoke and the thin bitterness of redbark on his breath. Her fingers dug into the pattu at his collar, and her split knuckles stung against the wool, and she let them. The rope lay warm across both their wrists, and it pulled gently, as if the mountain were leaning in to listen.

When they parted, neither of them went far. Her forehead rested against his. His breathing caught at the ribs, steady and not quite even.

"That," said Meera, "was free."

"I know," he said. "I watched your hands."

She laughed against his mouth. Then the laughter stopped, because he had gone quiet, and his eyes had left hers for the rope.

"Meera. Listen."

"I'm listening."

"I will not let you fall on this mountain." He put both hands on his knees where she could see them. "Not the Teeth, nor the Saddle, nor any ledge between here and Ranu. If the ground goes, I will be under you."

The rope hummed.

It came first through her wrist, a low, level note, rising out of the red wool as if the whole length of it had been struck. The stones in the wall kept silent. The sound ran up her arm and into her teeth, and it did not climb or crack. It stayed even and held, like a hand laid flat on a table.

Rohan's fingers were warm. They had stayed warm all the way through it.

"You shouldn't have," she said. Her voice shook. "A promise made while bound is a statement of intent. If you break it—"

"I know the rule."

"Then you know what you've done."

"I have made a promise I mean to keep," said Rohan. "I would not have made it otherwise."

She sat back on her heels and looked at him by the light of the dying fire. She read mountains for a living, counting what a slope cost and what it gave back. She read him that way now, and the answer came without any help from her.

A broken promise struck like a great lie, and a great lie took flesh. Until the thaw, his hands, his body, were tied to her footing.

And the thaw was the day he had to hand her to the rope.

She did not say so. There was nothing left that was free to say. She put her hand over his, and under the wind and the humming wool, she counted: five sticks for the night, two for morning, and a man who had just promised her the one thing he was ordered to take away.

Chapter 17

Below the Snowline

Rohan had her pack on his right shoulder and one boot laced before she opened her eyes.

The storm had gone out in the dark. He had felt it go, the way a man feels a fever break, and had lain on the sleeping shelf listening to the quiet until grey light came through the door seam. Now the hut smelled of cold ash and wet wool, and Meera lay with the red rope across her chest, one hand curled by her face.

She woke all at once, as she always did. Her eyes went to the pack, then to him.

"Put it down."

"It is forty pounds, and you carried it through the Teeth. My right arm is sound." He kept his voice reasonable. "Let me take the door as well. Let me kick the drift clear and test the sill before you put a foot on it."

"Captain."

"A cornice can sit against a door. I would rather learn that with my boot."

"Rohan." She sat up. It was the first time she had used the name when she meant to be heard, and he stopped with the strap in his fist. "Put it down. Your promise doesn't make you my guide."

"I did not say it did."

"You're doing it with a pack on your shoulder." She pulled her boots toward her. "I heard you last night. The rope heard you. You'll be under me if I fall. That's a promise about falling. It isn't about where I put my feet."

He set the pack on the shelf. It cost him something, and he was surprised by how much. For ten days he had reached for the downhill place on the rope and for the first step through every door, and each time she had stopped him, with a look and nothing more. It was not vanity. It was the oldest rule of his trade, and it was what *safe* meant to him.

"If you fall because I let you lead—" he began.

"Then I fell on my own line, and you caught me. That's the whole bargain." She laced up with fingers that obeyed her again. "Two sticks for the morning. I'm spending one on the sattu and keeping one. Eat."

They ate. Then Meera drew the door and stepped through first, and he let her. Outside, the world had been scoured. Every slope lay clean and blue-white, and the Saddle's lip stood against a sky so hard it looked glazed. She stood on the sill with her eyes narrowed to slits behind the strip of boiled leather she had cut from his writ case for goggles.

"The chimney's plugged," she said. "So we take the winter line itself. Down the south slope to the Neshar road, third bend. Half a day, if I read the snow right, and I will."

"And the hunters?"

"Digging. They'll come out onto the Teeth, find nobody, and cast east. I'd cast east." She tested the rope between them with a flick of her wrist. "Behind me, Captain. Uphill of me, always. Where you can sit down on the line."

Behind. Uphill. He saw why she wanted it. A man below her could only fall with her. A man above her could be an anchor. His reach for the downhill side had been an annoyance to her yesterday. With his promise humming in the wool, it was a danger.

He walked behind.

For an hour it was easy, and he hated it. She picked her way down the long slope in short, flat steps, stopping to probe with the axe haft. He

wanted to call out every hollow she was already stepping around. He bit it back and watched the back of her neck, the stray black hair freezing against her collar.

Where the slope rolled over into a shallow bowl, a clean, smooth stretch opened to the right, an easy shortcut, and his body began to take it. One stride off her line, and he had a good view of the way. The rope went slack in his favour.

Three short pulls.

He stopped with his weight forward. Meera did not turn her head.

"Look at your left boot," she said.

He looked. The snow under it was hard and pale, and it seemed sound. She came back up the rope, knelt, and tapped the surface once with her axe. A square of crust the size of a door sank away with a soft, sighing sound, and under it was a black hollow where wind had undercut the slope. The hollow went down further than the haft was long.

"You'd have gone through to the hip," said Meera. "And I'd have gone after you, because that's how a rope works." She said it without heat. "That's not a lesson. It's a cost. You're paying part of it now by standing still when you want to be ahead."

"I am paying," said Rohan. His voice was not quite steady. "I had not understood the price was this."

"What did you think it was?"

"That I would be the one at risk. In your place." He stepped back onto her line, in her footprints, exactly. "I see now that keeping it means doing what you tell me. I had not thought of it as obedience."

"It's not obedience." She stood and brushed snow off her knees. "It's being on the same rope. I'd do the same for you if you were the one who knew the ground."

"Would you?"

"Ask me again when you do."

She went on. He followed, and it was not as hard the second time.

*

They stopped at noon in the lee of a boulder, where the sun had melted a hand's breadth of rock bare. Meera sat with her back to it and chewed sattu without tasting it. He could tell by how she held her jaw. When she spoke, she kept her eyes off him.

"I want to ask you something I already know the answer to."

"Ask."

"You hold the writ." She pulled up a knee. "It names the Salt Fox. If you put me down in your report as dead on the mountain, or never found, or not me, can you do that? Or tear the name off the paper?"

It was the most dangerous question she had asked him, and she had asked it softly, with her bare hands on her knee where he could see them. He did not take long to answer, because the answer was not in doubt. He took long because he did not want it to be true.

"No," said Rohan.

Her fingers did not whiten. She had known he would say it.

"A warden cannot pardon," he said. "Not a captain, not the judge at Taravan, not the Salt Guild. I can arrest you and hold you. I can delay, and I can argue. I cannot unwrite a name once the crown has it. Only the queen can, with her own hand."

"Then you could tell the judge I was never the Salt Fox."

"I could. It would be a lie, and I would have to say it to a man who has never taken my word on less." He spoke slowly. "And it would not hold. Your crew know you. The paper would only say that I was a liar."

"So it's the queen."

"It is the queen. I would carry you to her myself, if she were nearer." He heard what he had said, and did not take it back. "I cannot make the law bend for you, Meera. I can only walk you to the one person who can."

She was quiet. The wind moved a skin of snow across the rock.

"That's the worst true thing you've said," she said at last. "And you said it while I could see your hands."

"Yes."

"I think I liked it better when you were just the man with the noose." She huffed out a breath that was nearly a laugh. "At least then I knew where to stand."

"You still do." He held his hands out, palms up, and they were warm. "Here. Where I can see you."

She looked at the hands for a long moment. Then she turned her face toward the valley, and he knew the conversation was finished and that it had moved something.

*

It was the stone fold that undid him.

They had come down to where the Saddle's snow broke up into scree and stunted thorn. A herders' track crossed below them, and beside it a low wall of piled stone stood like an animal fold. Rohan knew it. He had walked this trail at twelve years old with his father's hand on his collar. Two nights before the crossing he had stood over the post table with the ruler held flat on a sheet of the post's good paper, and watched Varun's neat hand draw this very wall along its edge. *Captain-ji, you've forgotten the shrine,* Varun had said, and added it.

Rohan had not forgotten the shrine. Varun had only wanted it on the sheet.

He walked past the fold, and the thing came up through his chest without warning, so fast he could not shut it. Ten years. Varun had held his horse at the Taravan gate when Rohan was newly captain and sick with nerves. Varun had stood at Dilan's grave in the wardens' row with a skin of wine and said the wrong funny thing, and made the whole hall laugh when nobody could breathe. Varun had *sat with him*. He had sat in the dark of the post room on the night Rohan first read Dilan's report, saying nothing, and Rohan had thought: *this is what a friend is.*

And the pick had struck stone, and Jassi, forty winters old, was dead.

Rohan stopped. His fist went into the nearest slab of the fold before he knew he'd closed it. It split his knuckles. He hit it again, and the rope jerked at Meera's wrist.

"Rohan." She did not shout.

"He asked me about my sister." His voice was strange. "At the table, before we left. Whether Ila was safe in Neshar through the winter. He had a face like an honest man worried for her. He was already counting what I'd sell for."

"I know."

"You do not. You never trusted him." He pulled the hand back, bloody to the second joint, and found he did not care. "I stood at his *wedding*. I would have put my own neck in his hands. And I hope he is under that snow. I hope he is still under it, and that he woke, and knew."

It sat between them in the cold, ugly and entire. He waited for her to say something merciful.

She came back up the line and took his bleeding hand in both of hers, and turned it to the light. "That's a true thing," she said. "Don't take it back."

"I should not feel it."

"Why not? It's free." She pressed snow into the split knuckles, hard, and he hissed. "Jassi named every goat he ever owned. Auntie was the one who kicked. I'd like Varun to know that, before he's done." Her eyes were dry and fierce. "Be angry, Captain. I'll hold the rope."

He breathed. His chest heaved, and his ribs ached like a stitched wound. Under the anger there was grief for the friend he had had, and he let that show too, since there was no one to see it but her.

When he was done, she let go of his hand and walked on. He fell in behind her, exactly in her steps.

*

The birches began at the third bend, thin white trunks standing in snow to their knees. Below them the trees changed. The bark grew rough and dark and the branches thickened into broad, heavy arms, bare now, and the slope turned to long terraces of walnut, stepping down toward a hollow in the hills.

He smelled it first. A green, bitter steam, thick as tea, hung in the cold air from a hundred chimneys at once.

"Walnut leaf," said Meera. Her voice had gone odd. "They boil it for the lungs. Every house, every day." Her stride lengthened, and the rope drew him after her. "That's Ranu."

Then he heard the coughing.

It came through timber walls. It was not one cough, but many, a low rasp behind every door and shutter, wet and dry, near and far, a child's high bark answered by an old man's deep one. The sound never stopped. It simply moved from house to house, like a bell passed hand to hand.

The track dropped out of the trees onto the open shoulder above the village. Timber roofs showed black with damp, and pale threads of smoke rose between them. And on the slope beside the track, in frozen ground, lay the mounds.

He stopped. He had not meant to.

They lay in rows along the contour of the hill, each one a hump of earth the colour of rust where the spades had cut through the crust. Stones were piled on some. A bit of rag was knotted to a stick on another. The newest had no marker at all, only a scatter of dark clods across the snow.

Rohan had buried seven wardens. He knew how to count a grave. He started at the top corner and walked the first row slowly, and Meera did not stop him. Eight. Nine. A long mound, and a long one, and then one that was no longer than his own forearm and a half. Her breath caught. The next was the same length, and the one after, and he understood what the little ones were, and kept counting, because stopping would have been a way of looking away.

She was counting too. He heard it under her breath, the way she counted goats. Her hand had gone to her coat, over the bell.

The second row. The third. The ground was so hard here that the diggers had left stones at the edge of every cut, heaped up in small cairns of their own. Some mounds had fresh pine boughs laid across. Some had a toy: a carved goat, a spindle, a crooked wooden horse.

"Twenty-six," he said, and his voice came out thin and strange. "Twenty-seven."

He finished the row. He turned and came back along the lowest terrace, and the last of them were barely a hand's width apart, as if the diggers had given up the idea of space.

Thirty-one.

There was a shovel in the ground at the end of the row. A woman stood behind it, thick in the shoulder, wrapped in a shapeless brown pattu with its hem stiff with frozen earth. She was fifty perhaps, with iron-grey hair scraped back under a cloth and a mouth set hard as a ledge. She had been digging. Her breath hung in front of her in short, hard clouds, and beside her feet the raw earth was opened to a depth of barely a forearm. It was the right length for a child.

She looked at Meera's rope, the wool still red under its crust of ice. She looked at the grey pattu on Rohan's shoulder and at the warden's knot at his collar.

"Nimmi," said Meera. Her hand had gone to the pack, flat over the oilcloth roll. "Kiran, is he—I have it, twelve packets, near enough, it's here—"

"I know who you are." Nimmi's voice was flat as a plank. She ignored the pack, and Meera. Her eyes stayed on Rohan. "Breathing. That keeps." She drove the shovel in again and left it standing. "Blockade dead. Thirty-one this winter, and it's not yet midwinter. I've buried most of them myself. You're the captain who signs it?"

He could have said that the post signed it. He could have said the warden-judge, or the queen, or the Closing Law itself, written sixty winters ago, long before he was born. He could have said that he had only held the line. Every one of those was true. The rope on his wrist lay quiet. Nothing in his hands would have moved.

The smell of boiled leaf sat in his throat. The coughing went on behind him, and thirty-one counted graves lay at his back, belonging to people whose names he did not know. He said the one thing that was entirely his.

"Yes."

His hands stayed bare at his sides. He did not hide them.

Chapter 18

Twelve Packets

"Didi," said Kiran. "You brought a warden?"

He lay on a pallet by Nimmi's hearth with a quilt up to his chin, and he was the colour of old ash. His lips were split and dry. A wool cap was pulled down over both ears, hiding the frostbitten one, and under it his face had lost its flesh. One fist was closed under the quilt, gripping something, and it did not let go.

His eyes had gone to Rohan's face first. Meera saw it. Something in Kiran flinched, a small hard tightening, as if he had been struck. Then his gaze dropped to the grey pattu on Rohan's shoulder, and the joke came up over the top of it.

"Don't talk," said Meera.

"Ten days gone, and you bring me a warden. I'd have settled for apricots." The laugh turned into a cough that bent him double. She was on her knees with her arm under his shoulders before it finished. His ribs moved under her hand like a bird's.

Any smuggler flinched at that coat. She put it down to that.

"Don't," she said again, and heard that she was begging.

"He's tied to you." Kiran's eyes had found the red rope. His voice broke, then steadied. "Of course he is. Of course you did it the hard way." He turned his face into her sleeve. "Didi. I kept them going. Nimmi will tell you."

"I know. Hush."

Behind her, Rohan stood in the doorway, close enough that the rope hung slack. He said nothing. It was the one silence she had ever been glad of.

*

Nimmi did the counting at her own table, with a kettle going and her sleeves pushed back.

"Forty-one sick. Nine under ten. When your brother wrote his note it was forty-one, and twenty-five have been buried since, and twenty-five more took to their beds. The number doesn't move. The people do." She ticked each case off on a thumb, like a woman reading out damages. "Fever, all of them. Cough, wet in most, dry in the old. Hira the weaver has the blue lip. Bholu's mother lost her voice on the third day, which is bad, and her daughter has the rash, which is worse. Kamla's two have been sleeping since morning, and I don't like sleep. The Dev boy won't eat. The Dev boy's father won't stop eating. Your brother is the only one who jokes, and it's wearing him thin."

"Nimmi."

"Open the pack."

Meera unrolled the oilcloth on the table. Three rows of four, palm-sized bundles of waxed paper tied with thread. She had counted them at every halt since Kothi Shilak. She had opened only one, for the captain's lungs. Now she saw the wax on the end bundles, and grey paste in the oilcloth beneath.

"The Teeth," she said. "I had the pack against the rock all that day."

Nimmi turned the ruined bundles over with a fingertip. Two had split along the fold. The third had taken the damp and set like clay. She scraped what she could into a saucer, weighed it in her palm, and shook her head.

"Not enough to dose a cat." She pushed them aside. "Nine sound. A course is a pinch in hot walnut tea, morning and night, three days. A packet is two courses. Eight whole ones, sixteen. The one you opened is short two half-pinches, so call it a course." She eyed the twist Rohan had

set on the table, thumb-long, the silk-sieve ring pressed in its wax. He had taken it from a hunter's purse. "And this. Crown-grade, from the men who wanted you dead. Another course. Eighteen."

"Could you thin it? Two pinches to a cup, a smaller—"

"Thin it and it turns nobody. I tried it three winters ago. I buried the proof." Nimmi folded her arms. "Eighteen courses, forty-one sick. You can do the sum. I did it on the way here, every night, and it came out the same."

Eighteen. The number lodged in Meera's chest like a stone she had swallowed whole. She had carried twelve packets over the Long Saddle with the regent's hunters behind her and Jassi dead in the gully. She had counted them until the count was a prayer. She had never once thought of the other number.

"Then we choose," said Nimmi, "and you write it down. You're the one with the book."

*

They did it in the back room, where the loom stood under a sheet. Nimmi sat on the weaver's bench. Meera took an upturned crate, with the count open on her knee and the pen she kept for names.

At the door she had told Rohan to wait in the front room.

"Eight arm-spans," said Rohan. "I am aware of the length. I will be at the edge of it."

"At the edge of it with your back turned."

He gave her the long, level look he gave a map he did not like, and she held it. "Meera, the choosing—"

"Is mine." It came out harder than she meant. "Nimmi's and mine. It isn't a warden's business."

"I have no wish to make it my business." His fingertips stayed brown on the doorframe. "I will turn my back."

He turned. But the back room was windowless and the lamp had burned to a stub, and when Nimmi cursed and fumbled with the flint, an arm came through the doorway holding out a fresh wick, already lit.

Rohan had not turned around. His hand was simply there, steady, holding the light at her shoulder.

"I said—"

"I heard you. I am not looking." He faced the front room, and the lamp stayed where it was. "You cannot write by a stub. If I put it down, you must get up and light another, and then you will be away from the rope."

She did not answer. She dipped the pen.

"Hira," said Nimmi. "Blue lip. Sixty if he's a day. A course won't turn him."

"Then he doesn't get one."

It was the first name, and she wrote it without a pause, in the left column. She made her hand form every letter. *Hira, weaver, no course.* The lamp did not shake.

"Kamla's two. Both sleeping. Girl of five, boy of three."

"Since dawn?"

"Since dawn."

"Gone too deep," said Meera. "Both. No."

"Meera—"

"I know. I'll write it. It's the same rule." She wrote *Kamla's boy, Kamla's girl*, and the pen scratched. The rule was plain: the course had to catch someone still on the near side of the worst, a fever that could be turned, a mouth that could still swallow the tea.

They went down the list. Bholu's mother, yes. Her daughter with the rash, yes, because Nimmi said the rash meant days left and not hours. Old Lalli, who'd had the cough three winters running and would likely outlast them all, no. The Dev boy, yes. His father, no, and Nimmi laughed once, short, and didn't look up from the paper.

Sixteen. Seventeen. When the pen reached Sunni, Meera's hand stopped.

She had seen Sunni already. The girl was seven, with plaits as thin as pencils and a fever that painted her cheeks. She had been watching Meera's coat. When Meera crouched to put a cup in her hands, she had

asked, in a voice like dry reeds, whether the bell in her pocket was for a goat.

"For an old one," Meera had said. "She's called Badami. She's retired."

"Can I ring it?"

Meera had taken out the small, dented bell and put it in the girl's hand. Sunni had shaken it once and laughed, and the laugh had turned into the cough. She'd laid the bell on her chest and kept her fist over it.

"Sunni," said Nimmi now. "Still talking. Still eating, a little. Her breath's wet but clear at the bottom."

"So she's stronger than the others."

"Stronger than Bholu's mother. Which means she can wait for the third water." Nimmi rubbed her eyes. "I can brew six cups at a time on this hearth. That's three waves. Sunni could take till dusk."

"You're sure."

"No." Nimmi dropped her hands. "I'm sure of nothing. That's what this is."

Meera read the page. Eighteen with a course, Sunni the last of them. Twenty-three without. She wrote it. *Sunni, seven. Third water, dusk.* The ink sat there, black and wet and exact.

Behind her the lamp had not moved. At the corner of her eye she saw the hem of his coat, and the hand at the end of the light, bare and still, split across the knuckles from the stone fold. He did not touch her shoulder. He did not tell her she had chosen well.

She set the pen down and found she was glad he was there.

*

The water began as Rohan's idea, and ended as a thing he did with his whole body, as if there was nothing in him but arms.

There were four wells in Ranu. The nearest to Nimmi's house was a hundred paces down a frozen path. At noon he took two buckets from the porch before anyone had asked, got to the end of the porch, and felt the rope go tight.

"Eight arm-spans," said Meera. "I'm coming."

"The tea—"

"Will wait a quarter hour." She pulled on her gloves. "It won't like it."

They went down together, a warden of the queen in a pattu with a goat on the collar and a smuggler with a kettle-burned sleeve, and the whole village watched from doorways and shutters. They saw the red rope between the wrists. They saw him slow at every step to keep inside its length. He filled the buckets. She took one so he need not carry both on his ribs, and they climbed back.

A hundred paces down, a hundred up. She counted it, because she counted everything. Every trip was a quarter hour, and every quarter hour came off the time between houses. The tea went late to the Dev house. It went late to Bholu's mother. Nimmi said nothing, but her eyes went to the sun.

Rohan followed her to Hira's and stood at the edge of the room with the bucket while she crouched by the weaver's pallet. He followed her to the Dev house and filled the kettle, and when the Dev boy's father, still eating and weeping into his bread, took hold of his sleeve and said *please, please*, he stood and let the man hold it. He did not tell him the law. He did not tell him he was sorry.

"You don't have to haul every bucket," she said at the fifth door. "Get a boy to do it. You'd be a quarter hour quicker, and I'd stop walking to the well."

"Which boy?"

She opened her mouth, and turned, and looked down the lane. In every doorway stood a woman with a cloth over her arm, or a grandfather holding a basin. Every pair of hands in Ranu was already full. The boy who had hauled for Nimmi till yesterday lay on a pallet in the third house, burning.

"Everyone who can walk is nursing," said Rohan, quietly. "I asked at the second door. Nobody has hands to spare." He lifted the bucket.

"Without the rope you would be quicker. With it, you are not. I can do nothing about the rope. I can carry what it allows."

She had counted the trip. She had not counted why it had to be them.

At the sixth house a woman stood in the doorway with her arms crossed and her face shut. Her gaze went to the goat on Rohan's collar, and she spat on the boards at his feet. It was a careful spit, not at him but beside him. Meera opened her mouth.

"It is a fair price," said Rohan. He picked up the bucket again. "Please tell her I am carrying water, and that I would carry it if she spat on me."

The woman's mouth twisted. She stood aside.

By late afternoon the second water had gone out, and Meera's boots were soaked to the ankle. She stood in the lane between the Dev house and the next, with her cold hands pressed to her mouth.

"One hundred and forty steps from the well to this door," said Rohan, behind her. "I counted. You always count."

"Don't make me laugh."

"I was not trying to." He set down the buckets. "I was giving you something to count that was not the other thing."

She laughed anyway, or something near it, a hard cracked sound. When she turned, his face was grey with the ache of his ribs and his hands were raw, and he was looking at her as if she were an ordinary person to whom ordinary things might be said.

"Third water," she said. "It's nearly dusk."

*

Sunni took the tea in both hands, and Meera held the cup beneath her chin so the steam rose into her face.

The girl was hotter than at noon. Her breath came short, and her plaits had come loose. But she smiled, thin and wobbling, when she saw the bell was still in her fist.

"Is Badami in the barn?"

"In the barn. Eating the roof, probably."

"Mama says goats can't eat roofs."

"That's because she hasn't met Badami." Meera tipped the cup. The girl swallowed, and coughed, and swallowed. The pinch of redbark had turned the tea bitter and brown, and she wrinkled her nose. "It's horrible, isn't it?"

"It's *so* horrible," said Sunni.

"Then it's working. Drink the rest."

She drank the rest. She slept, with the bell under her chin and her mother's hand in her hair, and Meera stayed for the length of a hundred slow breaths. She counted them. Then Rohan's shadow shifted at the door, and she got up and went out into the dark.

*

Kiran's cough was lower now, the tea in him. He was awake, on his side, watching the fire with half-lidded eyes.

"You're writing it down," he said.

"What?"

"The count. Your book's out." He tried to grin. "Who did you pick?"

"Eighteen."

"And you hate it."

"I hate it." She put the notebook away. It was an effort, and her hand shook, and she saw him see it. "Turn over. You're lying on your lung."

She went to ease the pillow from under his head. Something was beneath it, a small hard weight wrapped in wool. When she lifted the corner it slid out onto the quilt.

A badge. Brass gone brown, a stamped disc the width of her palm, with a green bloom in the lettering. She knew it at once, having seen a hundred like it on a hundred coats: a goat's head, the queen's mark. A warden's badge, with a tiny dent in its rim.

She sat very still.

"Kiran."

His hand came out of the quilt and closed over it, faster than a sick man's should. He held it against his chest. The same fist, she saw. It had been gripping this all day.

"It's nothing."

"It's a warden's badge. Under your pillow."

"It's mine."

"It isn't yours." She kept her voice low. In the doorway the edge of Rohan's shoulder showed at the margin of the light, turned away, watching the lane. Eight arm-spans. He could see the room if he turned his head. "Whose is it?"

"Didi."

"Whose?"

"I'll tell you." His eyes were very bright, and the fever was in them, but under it was something that was not fever. It was fear, plain and old, and she remembered how it had flickered across his face when he first saw the coat in the doorway. "I swear. Not now. Ask me when I can breathe."

"Kiran, if a warden—"

"Not *now*." His voice broke, and the cough took him. When it was done he was crying a little, the way the sick do, without sound. "Please. I'm so tired."

Her eyes stayed on the badge in his white fist. Then they went to the back of the man she was tied to, who had hunted a smuggler for a dead boy's sake for two winters.

Silence was free. It was the one gift the mountain gave you, and she had never wanted it less.

She tucked the quilt over Kiran's hand and the brass in it, and moved so that her body stood between the bed and the door.

"Sleep," she said.

"You're not going to tell him."

"I'm going to sit here." She sat. "That's all I'm doing."

*

The fourth water went round at full dark, and then there was nothing left to do but wait.

Rohan slept sitting against the wall, the lamp turned low and his hands open on his knees. Meera watched them for a time out of habit. They were warm. They were only tired.

At the grey edge of dawn, Sunni's mother began to make a noise.

Meera was on her feet before she knew it. The girl lay as she had been, one hand curled over the bell, her plaits damp and her face turned to the wall. There was no cough. The room had become much quieter.

"She was asleep," said her mother. "I put my hand on her chest and it was going, and I closed my eyes. I only closed my eyes."

Nimmi put two fingers under the little jaw and held them, and held them, and took them away. She said nothing.

Meera knelt where she had knelt the evening before. The cup was still on the floor, the dregs gone cold and brown. She had given the redbark at dusk. Too late by a day, or six hours, or the quarter hours spent walking to the well. It did not matter which. Sunni was seven.

The pen was in her hand. She did not remember taking it out. She opened the count to the last name on the right and drew a line through it, plain and horizontal, straight as a rule. Then she wrote the date beside it and the hour, in the same hand that had written every other name.

Grey light came through the shutter. A palm came down, not onto her shoulder but onto the floor beside her, flat on the boards, an arm's length off and no nearer. He had only put it where she could see it.

She did not look up.

"I wrote her down eighteenth," she said. "It was my sum."

"Yes," said Rohan. "And it was my water. Eleven trips to the well. I counted them, as you would." He did not move his hand. "I am not saying it to lessen yours. I am saying it is not yours alone."

She shut her eyes. Nothing in his voice asked her to feel better.

He stayed where he was, on one knee in the cold, a hand's breadth from the small curled shape and the bell, and let her do the work.

Chapter 19

Nimmi's Count

They buried Sunni at first light, and Meera dug the last foot herself.

The ground fought her. Nimmi kept one cut open ahead of the dying, a forearm deep, because she held that hope wasted medicine and a grave dug late wasted worse. It was not deep enough for this. So Meera knelt in the raw trench with the adze and chipped the frozen clay out in pieces the size of her fist. Rohan stood on the uphill edge, holding the rope slack so it would not drag at her wrist. He did not offer to take the tool. He had learned.

Sunni's mother brought her wrapped in a blue shawl, walking slowly, as if the weight were more than it was. At the edge of the cut she held out her other hand. In it lay the small dented bell.

"She'd have wanted you to have it back. It's not mine."

"It's hers." Meera climbed out and closed the woman's fingers over the brass. "It was Jassi's. Put it in with her."

The mother laughed, one broken sound, and bent to lay the bell on the shawl over the small chest. Then the earth went in. Nobody sang. In Ranu there was no breath to spare for it. When the last clod fell, the women at the row's edge went back to their sick without a word.

Meera stayed, the adze hanging from her fist.

"Thirty-two," said Rohan, quietly.

"Don't count them for me."

"I was only saying it so that it is said."

She turned on him then, because there was no one else, and because she had carried the thing since the stone fold.

"Say it to me. The law. All of it, the way you'd say it to the judge at Taravan." Her voice came out low and level. "Say why a girl of seven has to be in that hole."

He did not step back. She gave him credit for that. "You know the answer I will give."

"I want to hear it with her there."

He looked at the mound. He used the formal voice, every sentence whole, and she understood it was respect and not hiding.

"Without the Closing Law, the Saddle would run all season with the regent's grain wagons and the Salt Guild's long trains. Neshar would buy its bread at whatever price they named." His hands hung open. "The law is cruel. It is also the one wall Pritam cannot buy."

"And the law kills children." She said it flat. The heat had gone out of her somewhere around the hundredth breath beside Sunni's pallet. "Your wall has a shape, Rohan. It's a row on a hillside. Nimmi has buried thirty-two this winter, and every one of them is on the near side of the wall you're keeping for their sake."

"I know."

"Then keep it, but don't tell me it's *for* them."

"It is for the ones who would be buried by the wagons." Each word cost him. "I cannot show you those graves. They have not been dug. I am asked to weigh dead I can see against dead I cannot."

"That's convenient."

"It is the most inconvenient thing I know." His voice cracked, only slightly. "I would give a great deal for it to be convenient."

She looked at the row. "I don't weigh the ones I can't see. I count the ones in front of me, every name, because nobody else will. Your unseen dead are a guess, Rohan, a good one, and you've hanged boys on it." Her voice shook and she let it. "If the wagons come, you'll have graves to

show for it, and I would stand at them with you. I would hold the adze. But I won't dig these on the strength of a guess."

"No," he said. "I do not think you should."

That was all. He did not argue. Her hands were bare on the adze, and so were his, and neither pair had whitened. He had told the truth, and so had she, and the mountain was content with both. That was the part she could not forgive. It would have been easier to hate a liar.

*

The patrol came up from the lower road at mid-morning, and Meera's first warning was a boy running.

He skidded to a stop in the lane, cap in his hand. "Riders. Twelve. Grey coats, with a bell on the shoulder. They're asking for the guide."

"Which guide?"

"Any guide. They said *anyone off the Saddle*."

Rohan looked at the sky as if it might give him the hour. "They have found something at the Teeth. Two men in the lee of a rock, with a splinted wrist."

"Nimmi's goat shed. Now." Meera took a grip on the rope.

They ran, as far as his ribs let him, the grey pattu still on his shoulders because there had been no time to take it anywhere. The shed was a lean-to of timber and plaster behind Nimmi's house, with goats below and a hay loft above, under the roof.

She worked it out on the way, and it was short. The house would be the patrol's first door. A stranger in the yard would be asked a name, and nobody in Ranu could vouch for her and live. With a man who could not run, the loft was the only cover there was.

Rohan went up the ladder one-handed, breathing through his teeth. Halfway up, Meera saw the problem. The grey wool showed bright against the dark boards, plain as a flag from the lane. She came up two rungs behind, caught the pattu at the collar and dragged it off his back.

"Meera—"

"Quiet." She shoved it deep into the hay and pulled straw over it. "That's what they're looking for. Not you. That."

The loft was low enough that she hit her head on the first purlin, and hay-dust rose in a cloud that made them both cough into their sleeves. Under the eaves, where the roof came down to the floor, there was room beside him for exactly one person, and only if she lay on her side.

"Move your arm."

"I am moving it."

"Your *good* arm."

He lifted the right, and she went in under it, spine to his chest, which kept her weight off his ribs. The hay crackled. His coat smelled of camphor and woodsmoke, and below them a goat shifted and sighed. The rope lay between them, red against the straw.

Boots on frozen ground. A bit-chain. A man's voice, bored, carrying across the yard.

Meera put her eye to a knot-hole in the gable plaster.

Twelve riders had pulled up before Nimmi's house. They wore grey wool with a small brass bell stitched on each shoulder, and they were clean in the way of men sent to look at something they will not touch. The captain was heavy, with a red moustache. One soldier had a sack on his saddle bow, another a bucket.

Nimmi stood on her step with her sleeves rolled and a ladle in her hand.

"Healer. You keep the sick book here?"

"I keep a count."

"Good. We want the houses." He swung down. "Every house with a sick person in it. The regent has a care for Ranu, mistress."

"Has he."

"By his order every sick house is to be marked, for the cleansing after the Fair."

The bucket went down on the frozen mud. It held ash, grey and fine, mixed to a paste. The soldier dipped a glove in it, walked to the nearest

door and pressed his palm to the lintel, hard. He left a handprint the width of a plate.

Rohan went still behind her.

"They're going house to house," she whispered. "What's cleansing?"

"I do not know." His breath moved the hair at her nape. "I have never heard the word used so."

Below, Nimmi came down off her step. "Mark my door and every house in Ranu knows who to blame. What does it mean? Cleansing."

"It means what it says."

"Say it again with more words."

"The sick houses are marked, and no one goes in or out after the sixth day without a pass." The captain wiped his hands. "You'll be told more when the general rides up."

"The general."

"After the Snow Fair." He said it easily, like the name of a season. "He's coming up himself, once the regent's invested. He'll want it done properly. So the marks are for him, healer, not for you. Where's your guide?"

"What guide?"

"The pair that came down off the Saddle. One has the wardens' grey on his back. We hear a captain of the Shilak post is lost."

"Lost," said Nimmi, "is a word for it. We've had no one. We've had the grey cough. If your general wants to see it done properly, he's welcome to carry a bucket."

She lied flat to the regent's man, and it cost her nothing. She was bound to no one. Meera pressed her forehead to the cool plaster and thought of the grey wool under the hay, an arm's length from her knee.

The soldier with the bucket moved along the lane. Hand, lintel, grey print. At the third house a woman stood in her doorway with a child on her hip. The soldier looked at her and at the child, made the mark above her head, and she did not move.

"Meera." It was hardly a breath.

She turned her head against his arm. His face was very near, grey in the light through the slats, his eyes on her and not on the lane.

"I am going to say something I should not," he whispered. "It is true. I need you to hear it before I decide to take it back."

"Say it."

"I do not know if I can keep the law after this." The words came one at a time, as if he laid them on a table. "I said I would, in the Rope-Hut. I said it at the grave. I have believed it for twelve years, and I stood at that hole this morning and believed it still, and I cannot *find* it. The reasons are where I left them. I can see them. I cannot feel that they are enough." He swallowed. "If I had to sign the blockade a fourth winter, I think I could not hold the pen."

Her fingers lay on the rope. His hand was by hers on the straw, bare, the split knuckles dark. Warm. She did not need to touch it.

"You're telling me this with a dozen of the regent's men in the lane."

"You are the only person I can tell."

"And if I told the judge?"

"Then you would be telling him the truth." The corner of his mouth moved, though it was not a smile. "You have been careful of mine. I am going to be careful of yours. It is a bad habit, I find. It grows."

Below, the captain's voice rose. "We'll want the loft searched. They hide in hay."

Her whole body went to ice, and not the lie kind. Rohan's good arm closed round her without a word. She put her face in the straw and listened to a boot on the first rung of the ladder.

A ladle rang against the shed post, loud as a bell.

"Go up, then," said Nimmi. "My goats have had the grey cough since first snow, and I've been sluicing them with the water I wash the dead in. That hay is black with it. You'll carry it to the general on your sleeves."

The boot stopped.

"Leave it, Pasang," said the captain. "Half-dead goats and a loft full of mould. I'm not climbing up for a warden who got himself lost." A pause. "Mark the shed, though."

The boot went away. A palm hit the shed door, flat, a sound she felt through the boards.

They lay there until the bit-chains faded down the lane. The breath she finally took tasted of dust and camphor.

*

Nimmi let them down an hour later.

Meera dug the pattu out of the hay and shook it. Her knees shook from the cramped quarter hour and nothing else, and she held the ladder rail until they stopped. Rohan came down one rung at a time, lips pressed white, coat full of straw. In the nearest stall a goat regarded them with a yellow eye and went on chewing.

She had walked down the mountain with one thing clear. He held the noose. He had held it three winters.

She took out the count and thumbed back to the page where she had written him in the Rope-Hut, in her small hard hand. *Warden. The noose.* She uncapped the pen. She meant to add a line.

Nothing came that was true. *Liar* was not true. *Hangs boys* was, and it was not all of it. The nib hung over the page until the ink dried on it. Twelve years of an honest man's certainty had cracked in front of her, and he had not hidden the crack. He had pointed to it.

She shut the book. She did not want him to be the villain. She wanted to want it again.

"Your hair," said Rohan, with great gravity, "has become a haystack."

"So has your coat."

"We are well matched."

It was a bone-dry joke, the first in days, and it took her by surprise. She laughed. It came out as a cough, then something wetter, and she turned her face to the shed wall until it passed. He waited a hand's breadth off, a wall to lean on if she chose. She did not choose, and he let that be.

Outside, the lane was bright with winter sun. Nimmi stood on her step looking at her own front door.

The print was on the lintel, grey on dark wood, four fingers spread, above the room where Kiran lay coughing. Down the lane, house after house wore the same pale hand held up against the timber as if in surrender.

"Cleansing," said Nimmi. She did not turn. "I have been a healer thirty years. I know a word for a cleansed wound and a word for a cleansed well. I don't know one for a village."

Meera went and stood by her and set her own hand beside the print, not touching. The ash was still damp. Hers was smaller by half.

Beyond the last house, a drover in a felt cap was unloading a packhorse at the lane's foot. He stacked split pitch-pine against the last wall, log on log, neat as a man paid by the cord. When he was done he mounted and rode down the road without looking up. The wood was pale and wet with resin.

"Nobody here burns pitch-pine," said Nimmi, as if to the door. "It blacks the pots."

Meera looked from the stack to the row of grey hands, and back.

"How long?" she said. "Until the Fair?"

"Eight days, if the road holds." Nimmi counted it off on her thumb, as she did everything. "And the general after."

Meera counted what she could not take back. Garh Neshar was a day on the road for a sound man and a day and a half for Rohan. The Fair would not wait for a village to be ready. The doors shut on the sixth day. The courses begun yesterday would run out in three days, long before. After that came the twenty-three who had never had a course at all, nursed by one woman behind a boarded door, with no boy to haul water and no one to spell her.

She wrote it standing, on her knee, in the sun. *Sixth day. Twenty-three, no course. Nimmi alone. I go.* Then she read it aloud, so that it was said.

"I'm going," she said. "When the doors shut I walk away from that house and leave her with them. The rope won't let me stay, and it won't

let you go without me." She did not look at him. She looked at the print. "So I go."

Rohan drew a slow breath at her shoulder.

"Then we go," he said. "Until then I carry every bucket."

The rope hummed against her wrist, a low note and level, and it did not climb. She felt it through the bone. He had not said *I would*, or *I might*. He had said *I carry*, and the mountain had taken it as a word given. Every bucket until the doors shut was a debt now, written in the cold.

"You shouldn't have said that on the rope," she said.

"I know." He was already lifting the two pails from Nimmi's porch. "It is true, though."

The line drew tight, and she went after him down the path, past the doors. At the lane's foot the pine stood stacked against the last wall, and the grey hands ran toward it, house by house. She began to count the doors between.

Chapter 20

Across the Rope

Nimmi gave them the storehouse because it was the only room in Ranu without a sick person in it.

It stood against the back wall of her house, a plank room full of sacks of dried walnut leaf, so that the whole dark smelled of bitter tea. Someone had swept a space clear. Someone had left a clay brazier, a heap of blankets and a lamp.

Meera sat on a sack with the count open on her knee and wrote Sunni's name.

She had struck it that morning in the choosing list, straight as a rule. That was the dead column of a different sheet. This was the count itself, the waxed book, where she wrote the ones she carried and the ones she lost on the way. *Sunni, seven, Ranu. Third water, dusk. Died before light.* Under it, in the same hand: *Eighteen courses. Forty-one sick.*

She did not write what she thought about the quarter hours. The page would not hold it.

The rope lay slack between her wrist and Rohan's. He sat on the floor with his back to the wall, a careful distance off, his left arm held against his ribs. He had not asked what she was writing. He had studied her pen for a long time, the way he studied weather.

"May I see it?"

She almost said no. The count was hers, and nobody had read it through. Bindu had never asked. Kiran had joked about it for ten years

and never once looked. Rohan had seen one page, in the hut, and she had chosen that page.

She held out the book.

He took it in his right hand and read as he read everything, to the end of the line. His eyes stopped on the last entry. He turned back a page, and another, and found the long run of names: two hundred and six people, each with a date and a price and a village. Some of the prices were crossed out. Beside those, in smaller writing, she had put *free*.

"You charge the rich double," he said.

"The file at your post never says that."

"No. I have read it eleven times." He turned another page. "I was wrong about that. I want it said, and I want it said now, while we are not in a hurry."

"You were wrong about a lot of things."

"I am working through them." He closed the book and gave it back, gently, as you hand over a thing that might wake. "Thank you. That was not a small thing to let me do."

She put the book on her knee and her hand on the book. Through the wall, Kiran coughed, low and wet, and fell quiet.

*

"A question," said Rohan. "Yours, if you want it. Mine if you do not."

It was the old trade, the one they had made in the hut with sticks of juniper for every refusal. There was no juniper here and no one counting. It had never needed to be counted.

"Yours," she said. "Go on."

"Then I will answer one before you ask." He set his right hand on his knee, palm up, in the lamplight. "I signed the Shilak blockade order. Three winters running, in the autumn, before first snow. The post commander writes it and the captain signs it, and I signed it with a clean pen and slept that night." He did not look away. "Sunni is in my hand too."

The rope stayed quiet. Outside, the wind among the stacked leaf-sacks made a small dry noise.

His palm was warm. The fingers were relaxed, the split knuckles pink and ordinary. She had been waiting, without knowing it, for the whitening that would tell her it was only words.

She said, "Say how many."

"I do not know how many. I only know the winters." He drew breath carefully, around the rib. "Nimmi says thirty-two now, with Sunni, dead this winter before midwinter. I could say that is not mine alone, and it is true. The regent's grain, the Guild, a queen who has signed pardons for thirty winters and never repealed one line of the law. I could say it, and each word would be true, and I would be using them to stand behind. So I am not going to say it."

She had wanted this. For three winters, and especially since the gully, she had wanted to hear him say it. She had imagined a voice full of shame. This was not shame. It was an account, set down plainly by a man who knew the sum.

It did not feel like winning. It did not make Sunni lighter.

"That's not absolution," she said. "I don't have any. I'd like you to know that before you think you've bought some."

"I did not come to buy."

"I know. That's what's so—" She stopped. Her own hands, in her lap, were warm too. She had said nothing but true things all evening. "I know you didn't."

"Then what is this?" he said quietly. "If it is not that."

"It's the count." She opened the book.

*

There was a line she had never written a name beside. Near the back, ruled off by itself, it read: *Shilak closed. Three winters. By order.* Under it she had set down, winter by winter, the numbers Nimmi had told her over the years, because someone should. The right-hand margin had stayed empty.

She dipped the pen.

R., captain, Shilak post. Signed. She wrote the name in the same letters as everyone else. It looked small on the page.

Then she turned back through the book to the page from the Rope-Hut. Her own small hard hand looked up at her: *Warden. The noose.* Under it, in Nimmi's goat shed, the nib had hung and dried and left nothing. She had not been able to add a line.

She could now. Beneath the old words she wrote, *Said so himself. Carried water, eleven trips.*

She turned the book so he could see.

He read the page twice. His eyes rested on the first line a long moment, and then, to her surprise, the corner of his mouth moved.

"That is also correct," he said.

"I don't strike true things."

"No." When he looked up, his face had the stunned openness of a man who has braced for a blow and been handed a cup. "It is the first time anyone has written me down as a thing that happened, and not a thing that was done to them. And you left the first line standing."

"Don't get fond. It's a ledger." Her voice was not steady. "Everyone in it is someone I couldn't leave off."

He didn't answer. He got up slowly, a hand against the wall, crossed the length of the rope and sat on the sack's edge in front of her. He took her bare right hand in his and turned it over. The knuckles were swollen and split from the Teeth.

"May I?"

"What for?"

"There is goat fat on Nimmi's shelf. I saw it. Your hands are not mending and you have not said so." He waited. "You do not have to say it now. I would like to do it."

She had said once, in the hut, in passing, that the cold got into her knuckles and she never could be bothered. She had forgotten saying it. He had not. She nodded.

He fetched the pot. He warmed the fat between his palms first, so it would not shock the cracks, and worked it into her knuckles one at a

time with his thumb. It took a long while. Neither of them spoke. At the end her hand lay in his as if it belonged there. When his thumb stopped, her fingers curled around it before she had decided anything, and held on.

*

"I'm twenty-nine," she said.

His thumb stayed where it was, inside her grip. "Yes. I have read your file." A pause. "Thirty-five. You have it, I think."

"I do." She looked at the hand around hers. "I'm saying it because I want us both to have said it. I'm not cold, and I'm not afraid. I'm not looking for something to hold on to because a girl died this morning—"

She stopped. The tips of her first two fingers had gone white, a faint frost-bloom, there and then deeper. Rohan's eyes went to them and came back to her face.

"That's partly a lie," she said. "I'll start again."

"There is no need—"

She held both hands up between them. The white did not fade. It would sit in the tips for an hour, as it always did, and nothing she said now could hurry it.

"Don't look at those," she said. "They're no use to you for an hour. They'll vouch for nothing I say, and they'll look like a liar's whatever I say." She made herself steady. "So you'll have to take this without them. A girl died this morning and I want to be held, and that's not the whole of it, and it's not the reason. I want this. I want you, tonight, in this room. I've wanted it since the hut and I've been angry about it for days. Is it yours too, or am I the only one who's been counting?"

He looked at her white fingertips, and then he did not look at them again.

"Then I will take it unverified," he said, "on your word, as I would from anyone I trusted." His voice was low and not entirely under his control. "It is mine. It has been mine long enough that I stopped trust-

ing myself in rooms with you." The corner of his mouth moved. "But you have asked me one thing. May I ask you one back?"

"Ask."

"What do you want?" He said it carefully, as you ask the way across a snowfield. "Not whether. I have the whether. I would like the what. I have a rib that will not allow me to guess."

She laughed, startled, and it broke something loose. "You're going to make me say it."

"I would like to do it right."

"Then slowly," she said. "And not on your left side. And I want your coat off, because I've watched that coat steam over the hut fire every night since the Saddle." She put her white-tipped hand flat on his chest, over the good side. "And you tell me if it hurts, and you don't do the thing where you pretend it doesn't."

"Those are rules I can keep." His own hand came up over hers, over the cold tips, and did not flinch. "I will tell you."

*

They untied the rope, because it tangled. The mountain's distance still held them, and neither forgot it, but there was freedom in the length of it, eight spans of slack to be as near as two people can be.

The coat came off in stages. The brown pattu. The shirt, which she eased over his left arm herself, because he could not lift it, and then stopped. The bruise ran from his armpit to his hip, yellow-green at the edges, black at the centre where Jassi's cord had bound him. She laid her fingers beside it, not on it.

"Does this—"

"No. Not there." He caught his breath. "That. Yes. That is fine."

She learned his ribs as she had learned the Teeth, by feel and by patience. Where she could press, where she must not. His good hand moved over her carefully, as if she might be taken from him at any moment, and when it found the burn-scar on her forearm he stopped and kissed it, and she made a sound she had not planned.

"Tell me," she said. "If it's wrong."

"I will tell you." His mouth was against her wrist. "Meera. It is not wrong."

They were clumsy. It was cold, and then it wasn't. At one point she had to stop because he had gone grey and was breathing through his teeth, and she lay with her hand on his chest and her forehead on his shoulder until it eased. She did not feel cheated. He said, without being asked, in a voice that shook, that nobody had ever looked after him like this, and that it frightened him far more than the Teeth had.

She moved over him then, on his right side, where she could take her own weight, and studied his face. She had seen it in the dark of the hut, in fever, in fear. She had not seen it open like this. When he said her name, it was not the formal voice or any voice she had heard from him. It was unguarded and almost surprised, and she answered it, and for a long while there was nothing in the storehouse but the brazier ticking and the two of them.

*

Afterwards she lay with her back against his good side and the blankets pulled to her chin. The rope was tied again, because it was easier. A single red line lay across the straw between their wrists. Her fingertips had come back to their own colour while she wasn't looking.

"I should say it plainly," said Rohan, into her hair. "I have shared your fire since the waystone. That was harbouring, and I told myself the mountain gave me no choice. Tonight I did it with my eyes open. I know what the law calls it and I know what the rope is for." He was quiet a moment. "I wanted you to hear that from me."

"I heard."

"My writ still orders me to deliver the Salt Fox at the thaw."

"I know."

"I do not know what I will do." His arm tightened a little. "That is the truth. I will not say anything tonight that I cannot hold."

She waited for him to go on. He did not. His hand had found hers under the blanket and his thumb had been moving along her knuckle, slowly, over the goat fat. It stopped.

"Is this only the cold?" she said.

It came out lighter than she meant, a joke with a hook in it, and the rope was quiet. He had gone still behind her.

"No," said Rohan.

She turned her head. His hand lay on the blanket beside her face, open. The fingers were warm, rosy at the tips, as they had been all evening, and they did not move.

"Look at them," he said. "Whatever you want to ask, look first."

She looked. Then she took the hand and held it against her mouth, and said nothing else.

*

Through the wall, Kiran's cough stopped.

She was awake before she knew why. The lamp had burned low and the brazier was ash. She lay listening to the particular quiet where a sound had been, like a goat-bell stopping on a ridge.

It had gone on all night, the wet low bark she had learned like a song she hated. It was not going now.

She was up, with her shirt half on and her boots in her hand and the rope tight at her wrist. Rohan, already awake, had a hand on the wall and his coat across his shoulders. Neither spoke. She went out through the door in her stockings, across the frozen yard and in by the back, the rope running behind her and his footsteps in her ears.

The room was grey with early light. Nimmi's chair was empty. Kiran lay on the pallet on his side with the quilt thrown back.

His chest was moving.

Slowly. Evenly. His hair was plastered dark to his forehead, and the quilt was soaked through. When she put her palm on his brow, it came away wet.

Cool. His skin was cool and slick with sweat, and under it his pulse went on, slow and steady, like a man walking.

"Didi," he said, without opening his eyes. His voice was a rasp. "You're dripping on me."

She was. She hadn't known. She knelt and put her face against the quilt and shook.

A hand settled on her hair, light and clumsy, and she laughed into the wool. Then the hand went still.

She lifted her head. Kiran's eyes were open, clear for the first time in days, and they were not on her. They had gone past her shoulder to the doorway, where Rohan stood at the end of the rope in his half-buttoned coat.

The joke that should have come died on Kiran's mouth. His gaze dropped to Rohan's hands, the split right knuckles, the fingers hanging open, and stayed there. His other hand slid under the pillow, slowly, the way you reach for something in the dark that you are afraid someone will see. She heard the faint scrape of brass on linen. His fist closed around it, the knuckles pale, and stayed closed.

Meera had seen that edge before: brown, with a small dent in the rim. She did not know whose it was.

Rohan had not moved. He could not see the hand behind her. He could see only the boy's face, and the boy would not look up from his hands, and would not let go.

Chapter 21

Six Days

The first thing Kiran asked for, on being alive, was that someone take the warden out of his sister's pattu.

"It's brown," he said from the pallet, propped on three sacks of walnut leaf. "It's Didi's second-best brown. It has her hole in the hem. Why is a captain of the queen's pass-wardens wearing it?"

"Because the grey one is at the bottom of a sack of leaf," said Rohan, "under the command of your healer. Twelve riders are looking for a man in grey."

"And so you came as a goatherd's wife."

"A goatherd. The sleeves are short."

"They are." Kiran's grin came slowly, as if it had a long way to climb. His face was the colour of tallow and a wool cap was pulled down over both ears, but the eyes were clear. He had slept two days and half a night, and Nimmi had stood over him with a lamp and pronounced the fever broken, and then said it again, as if she did not trust it. "It suits you. Don't take it as a kindness."

Rohan sat on the upturned water bucket by the pallet, with the rope running out through the door behind him. Meera was in the yard with Nimmi's second pot. He could hear her counting cups under her breath.

Nobody had asked him to sit with the boy. He had come in to see that the broth was warm, and found that he did not want to leave. Kiran

had Meera's face in a younger cut, with the same quick mouth. Rohan found it hard to be stern with it, and harder to stop looking.

"You'll want to eat," he said.

"I'll want to be sick, first. Then eat." Kiran took the bowl in both hands. "Do you people ever laugh? Wardens? I've watched you at the Kothi gate for three winters, and I've never once seen it."

"We practise in private."

"That was almost a joke."

"It was entirely a joke. It was a poor one." Rohan looked at the bowl, steaming between the thin hands. "I had a warden once who could not be stopped. He sang a hymn at every watch and believed it was a love song. He had no tune. Dilan used to say that the stones had the better ear."

The spoon stopped.

It was a small stop. Kiran's hand held the spoon in the air above the bowl, and his face went smooth and still, the way a pond does when the wind drops. The pallet creaked once. Then he looked up, and the grin was back, a little too bright.

"Is that salt in the broth, or is Nimmi trying to kill me? Tell me it's salt."

"It is walnut leaf, mostly."

"It's vile." He took a sip and made a face. "My sister says you carried water. Eleven trips. She told me on the way in, as if you'd walked on it."

"I carried it badly. The rope made it slower."

"It would."

Rohan let the talk turn. The boy was tired, he thought, and wary of a warden in a small room, as any smuggler would be. A dead man's name was a hard thing to hear from the likes of him. He put it away and fetched the second blanket.

*

Nimmi caught him in the lane, a bucket in each of his hands, and she had no patience.

"The grain carter came up the lower road this morning," she said. "First one in a month. The regent's men let him through because he had only turnips." He set both buckets down on the frozen mud. "He talks. I let him. He says there's a woman at Garh Neshar, a crown surveyor with a brass tube and a roll of linen, who's been shut up in the guesthouse since the first snow. The regent calls it his hospitality. She calls it something else, loudly. She has measured the whole yard and says the north wall is two spans out of true."

Rohan did not move. He could not.

"Is she tall?" he said.

"He said she laughed in the carter's face when he told her the wall was older than the regent. Then she corrected him on the date." Nimmi looked at him. "You know her."

"I know her." His mouth was dry. "Her name is Ila. She is my sister."

He had named her to Meera only once, in anger, at the stone fold. Ila was a line in a surveyor's roll. She was a girl on a stone wall with a plumbline, thirty years old and certain the world could be measured. Last spring she had written to him that Neshar was lovely, and that the passes would be fully drawn by midwinter.

Winter had come a month early.

"Then you'll want to be at that Fair," said Nimmi, "rather more than before."

"Yes." His voice came out level. It was the voice he used for bad news. "A crown surveyor who has watched the regent's court all winter and writes everything down is the worst thing for him if the seal is pressed. If it is not pressed, she is the first person he will make disappear. She cannot keep from saying things."

"Is that a failing?"

"It is a family one." He picked up the buckets, because his hands wanted something. "Nimmi. How many days to Garh Neshar?"

"A day on the road for a sound man. A day and a half for you." She glanced at his coat. "You should have gone yesterday."

"I know."

He stood in the lane with the ash handprints on the doors on either side of him, and the rope pulled quietly at his wrist. Wherever he went, Meera went. He could not reach his sister without her.

*

"No," said Meera.

She said it without heat. She was sitting on a sack in the storehouse with the count open, and had finished writing before she answered, which was how he knew she meant it.

"Hear it first," said Rohan.

"I heard it. You have a sister at Garh Neshar and five days till the Fair and a day and a half of road, and you want to go at first light tomorrow." She capped the ink. "That's a good plan. It's the plan I'd make. I'm still not going."

"Then I cannot go either."

"I know that too."

"Meera." He kept his hands open on his knees, where she could see them. "If the assembly sits and I am not in it, Pritam is invested on the claim that the queen is dying. Neshar passes into his hand, and Ila with it. I think he has already decided what to do with her."

"I believe you. Look at me. I believe you." She laid her hand flat on the book. "There are forty-one sick in this village. Eighteen courses. Nimmi can brew six cups at a time, so they go in waves. The first wave is the three youngest and Bholu's mother. They need a third dose, and then a second course for the worst of them, and that's six days, Rohan. Six, to do it properly. If I go tomorrow, every child on the list is half-treated, and half-treated is a very good way to bury someone."

"Six days is longer than the Fair."

"I know what it is." Her voice thinned. "I'm not asking for six. I'm telling you what I'd do if I were free, so you know what I'm giving up."

He had not seen it that way, and he was ashamed of that. He had heard a refusal. She was laying out a cost.

"What can you bear?" he said.

"What can *you*?"

It was not the question he expected. He thought of his sister standing in some stone yard with a measuring tube. He thought of Sunni's mound, and the row of them going up the slope.

"Show me the waves," he said.

She turned the book. She had ruled it into boxes, day by day, with a name in every box. He read it slowly, the way he read an order he was about to sign. Near the bottom of the page the two worst cases sat in a bracket, with a small mark beside them.

"The ones with the mark. When do they take their last dose?"

"Dusk tomorrow."

"And after that Nimmi can carry the rest herself. She has done it for thirty years."

"She hates being told that."

"She will hate it less than a fourth winter." He took a breath around the rib. "One more day, then. We leave at first light the morning after. A day and a half of road puts us at Garh Neshar with one day in hand before the Fair, and time to find where Ila is kept. It is less than I wanted. The road may take the spare day, and I am giving you this one."

She did not answer at once. Her fingers moved along the bracket.

"The patrol," she said. "Sixth day, their rule bites. No one in or out of a marked house without a pass. So I leave at dawn, and by the next night Nimmi finishes my waves behind a shut door, with no one to carry water, and I can't come back to mend what goes wrong. Put that in the cost, Rohan. It's mine and I'm paying it."

"Then I put it there."

"One isn't six."

"No."

"It's the dusk dose for the two with the mark." She breathed out. "I can live with those."

"Then you will give me something," said Rohan.

He had not meant it to come out as a bargain. But it was one, and she set the pen down and sat forward on the sack.

"Name it."

"At Garh Neshar you do not wait at the gate while I go in. You come with me to the meadow. In daylight, in front of the assembly, with the seal in my hand." He held her eye. "I know what that costs you. A smuggler in the open, in front of the bell. I would not ask it if the rope did not make it so, and I would not ask it if I did not think you could do it."

"You want me to walk the seal."

"I want you beside me when it is pressed. You carried it first."

She said nothing for a long time. The brazier ticked. Through the wall, Kiran coughed once and was quiet.

"If I walk it in," said Meera slowly, "I'm in the Captain's keeping, in front of the whole valley. And the writ."

"I cannot promise you the writ." He had known she would come to it. "I will not say a thing I cannot hold. The rope would know it, and so would you. I can only say that I will not take you at the gate, and that I do not know what I will do at the thaw. That is the whole of what is true."

"It's more than I expected." Her mouth twisted. "Fine. Yes. I'll walk it in."

"Meera."

"One day," she said. "I'll hold you to the dawn after. If you pull the rope at tomorrow's dusk because you're frightened for her, I swear I'll put you in the well."

"I will not."

"You'll want to."

"I will want to very badly," said Rohan, "and I will not."

Meera went still. Her head tilted, as it did on the Saddle when she listened for the wind to change. Her left wrist turned a little against the red wool.

"It's humming," she said. "Low. It hasn't climbed."

She uncapped the ink and wrote a line under the bracket, then turned the book so he could read it: *One day. R. promised.*

Then she put out her hand, and he took it.

"Done," she said.

*

He drafted the speech that night, by the lamp, on the back of one of Nimmi's tally sheets.

Meera slept on the blankets with her wrist on the rope, curled round the count like a guard round a gate. She slept as she did everything, with a hand ready.

Elders and lords of Neshar, he wrote. *I come under the queen's hand, with the queen's seal.*

That was easy. So was the fact of the regent's claim and the proof that the queen was alive. He was a man who wrote reports. He wrote it as one, in short lines, and was pleased with the shape.

Then he came to the law.

The Closing Law has stood sixty winters, he wrote. *It was made to keep the passes from those who would buy them.*

That was true. He read it over and felt the old wall of it, solid under his hand.

It has also, he wrote, and stopped.

The lamp hissed. What had to come was not hard to know. *It has also kept medicine from Ranu, three winters, and I signed the order.*

He set the pen on the paper and could not make it go.

He did believe it. He had said it in this room with his hand open, and the rope had let it stand. But that had been a confession to one pair of ears. This was a sheet of paper, to be read aloud in front of Pritam's guard and every elder at the Fair. The moment he wrote it down, it was evidence. The regent would take the page and say: *the queen's own captain confesses that the wardens have killed Neshar.* The seal would be pressed in the ruin of its bearer. And Meera, who had written the worst of him into her book, would have to watch him do it.

She had trusted the book. That was more than he was doing.

He wrote, *It has also,* and struck it. He wrote it again. Three times he got as far as the pen touching, and three times he lifted it.

Beside him, Meera stirred. She did not wake. The rope lay quiet, a thing that wanted no lies from him and was not asking for any now.

He folded the sheet small and put it inside his coat, next to the clean-cut end of Dilan's rope.

*

The next afternoon, in the grey light, the last of Nimmi's first wave finished their dose, and Rohan went in to Kiran with a decision he did not know how to make easy.

Kiran was sitting up without the sacks. He had walked to the window and back on his own that morning, hand on the wall, and was insufferable about it.

"You look like a man about to bring bad news," he said.

"I am about to bring awkward news. Which is a thing a warden does badly."

"Go on, then. Do it badly."

Rohan sat on the bucket. The rope ran out behind him through the open door, taut and still, which meant Meera was in the yard or on the step, no more than eight spans off. He could hear the clink of the brazier pot. It gave him a courage he had not thought to ask for.

"I am going to ask you to forgive me for something," he said. "Perhaps not now. You are Meera's brother, and the Kothi people are yours, and what I say will not be pleasant for them."

Kiran's face did not change. Only his hands moved, drawing the quilt a little higher.

"Two winters ago I lost a warden on the Saddle. Dilan. I told you about the hymn." Rohan looked at the clean line of the boards. "He was chasing a smuggler in a storm. The smuggler's rope was with his, and the smuggler lived. Dilan did not. I have the end of the rope in my coat. I swore before eleven wardens that I would find the one at the other end of it."

The room was very quiet.

"I told myself it was the law. It was not. It was Dilan." He drew breath. "And I have lived on your sister's mountain for half a month, and I have been fed, and mended, and written in a book, and I have begun to think that when I find that smuggler I will not know what to do. I have never said so to anyone. I wanted to say it to someone who might know the crews. If you know whose rope—"

Kiran had stopped hearing him.

His eyes were on the doorway, over Rohan's shoulder. His face had gone the grey of ash, with the colour dragged out of it from the mouth upward. He made a small sound that was not a word.

Rohan turned.

Meera stood in the doorway with the water jug against her hip, her hair coming down, a question on her face. She looked from one of them to the other.

"What did I miss?"

The quilt went back. Kiran was on his feet, which Rohan would not have said he could manage, one hand clawing at the wall. He went past the bucket and past Rohan's reaching arm. He went past his sister's shoulder so close that the jug struck the frame and slopped, and then he was out across the yard in his stockings, the wool cap jammed low over his ears, running down the lane on the frozen mud.

"Kiran!" Meera dropped the jug. The rope went tight across Rohan's wrist as she turned to follow. "Kiran, *stop*—"

He did not stop.

Rohan stood in the empty room with the sentence still open in his mouth. *If you know whose rope.*

Chapter 22

The Badge

Kiran made it forty paces.

Meera ran the lane with the rope snapping out behind her, and Rohan's footsteps came fast and uneven at the other end of it. She found her brother where the lane ended, behind Nimmi's goat shed, folded over the woodpile in his stockings. He clung to the split logs with both arms, as if the ground were tilting.

Ten paces back, the storehouse door stood open. The rope ran from her wrist to the doorway and no further. Eight arm-spans. The line went hard at her left wrist and then stopped.

"Stay in there," she called. "Rohan. Shut the door."

A pause. Then the door scraped to, leaving a gap for the rope and no more. He did not argue. He had heard what was in her voice, and he stayed on his side of the plank wall as a man holds still beside a trap.

She knelt in the frozen mud, pulled her pattu off her shoulders and put it round her brother. He was shaking in long hard waves. His cap had slid back. The left ear, the bad one, was a lump of puckered grey-pink, its rim eaten away.

"You'll lose toes," she said. "Put your feet in my lap."

"Didi."

"Feet."

He did it. She took them in her hands, the wool stiff with ice, and rubbed. It gave her something to do with her face.

"What did he say?" Her voice came out flat. "At the end. *If you know whose rope.* I only got the last of it. Whose rope, Kiran?"

He did not answer. He put a hand inside his shirt, slowly, as he had under the pillow, and drew out the badge. It was brass gone brown, palm-wide, the queen's goat head stamped on it, a small dent in the rim. He had worn it against his skin on a string. The string had left a pink line on his neck.

He held it out in his fist, and it shook.

"Take it."

"Whose is it?"

"Take it, Didi."

She took it. It was warm from his body. On the back, scratched with a nail point by an unsteady hand, were three letters. She read them with her thumb before her eyes.

DIL.

She knew the name. Rohan had given it to her in the hut, and the rest with it. A warden who sang a hymn at every watch and had no tune. A rope end in a coat, cut clean. *I swore my oath over that rope.*

"Say it," she said, very quietly. "Say who he was."

Kiran's mouth moved. Nothing came. She watched him try, as she had watched him at nine try to say the word for the thing that had frightened him in the dark. His jaw worked. He looked at the sky over the goat shed, then at the frozen ground, then at the badge in her hand. His eyes filled.

"I can't," he said. "I've never. I tried at the cairn last winter, on my own, and it wouldn't come out. It's like a stone in the throat."

"Then don't. Tell it without."

He nodded. He drew his knees up under her pattu, and she thought he would be sick. Then he began, in a voice with all the quickness gone out of it.

"It was the storm night. The one two winters back, the one I said was a bad crossing. I had four loads of salt for the Dev people, and I went up alone. I know. I *know*. I lost the line inside an hour, just like they say you

will, and I turned back the way I'd come and found the waystone by feel." He swallowed. "There was a warden there. He'd been following my tracks, and he'd lost the line as fast as I had. His hands were as white as mine. He was young, Didi. Not much older than me. He had no business out in that, and he came right at me, and I thought, that's it, that's the rope. And he didn't even draw. He said, *You're going to die up here, you idiot. Come down with me and be hanged in the morning like a sensible person.*"

A sound came out of her that was nearly a laugh. It hurt.

"He bound us," Kiran said. "Right there, at the stones. His rope, grey wool. Knot on my wrist, knot on his. We said our names to the waystone, and he named the third bend for where we were going, the nearest road with a roof on it. He said it was so I couldn't run. I felt it take. The blue came up on the stones, and I thought, I'll live." His voice cracked. "We were on the line, Didi. We were safe from the mountain. It was the ice that wasn't. We got to the shelf above the third bend and it went. Not a big slide. Just the ground under his feet, and him going, and the rope coming tight, and I went flat and started to slide after him on the glaze. My axe was gone. I could see the lip. I could see him past it, hanging, with the whole weight of me coming down the ice. And he looked up at me, and he said—"

He stopped. His breath came in short bursts.

"He said something," Meera prompted.

"He said *sorry about the hymn.* I don't know what that means. I've never known what it means." Kiran put his fist against his mouth. "Then he had his knife. He cut his own rope close to his wrist, and it went slack, and I stopped. Right at the lip. I stopped with the cut end in my hands. And he was gone."

The goat shed ticked in the wind. In the storehouse, on the other side of a plank wall, a boot shifted on a floor.

"We'd slid clear down onto the road ice, below the bend," said Kiran. "That's why I'm here. The line was gone, with him. I was off the pass, on a plain road, and a man alone can live on a road. I lay there. I couldn't

make my arms move. The ice had my ear. It froze to the glaze while I lay on it, and when it got light I had to tear it loose. That's the bad crossing. I told you a bad crossing. You never asked for the rest."

"I should have."

"I'd have told you a lie. I was very good at it by then." He laughed, a dry rattle with no joy in it. "There was a brass thing in the snow by my hand. His badge. The string had broken. I took it. I couldn't leave it on the ice with him down there. And I walked home with it, and I haven't spoken his name since, and I haven't put it down."

She sat with her brother's feet in her lap. The badge was a small cold weight on her palm.

She knew the rest already, and for a moment she let herself not know it. The ice shelf. The hymn. The warden who died with a rope cut clean. Rohan, in the lamplight, retying and untying the same rope end. *To find the one who stood at its far end.* An oath in a warden hall, two winters of searching, and the far end of the rope had lain in the next room of her own house, joking about wardens' laughter.

It had been in her ledger all along. Her brother, beside her, an arm's length from the man who was hunting him.

"He's in there," said Kiran. His voice had gone small. "The captain. I knew when I woke and saw the sleeves. I knew who he was before he opened his mouth, and I thought, if I don't look at him, if I just keep talking about the broth. Then he said the name, and said it so gently. He said *I swore.*" His hand closed on her wrist, hard. "Didi. He doesn't know. He asked me if I knew whose rope."

"I heard."

"A death on an unlawful crossing hangs. The warden died chasing a smuggler in the closed season. That's the law. It doesn't matter that I never touched him. It doesn't matter that he cut it himself. They'll say I led him up there. They'll say I ran." He was weeping now, without sound. "I'm not afraid of dying. I'm only afraid of the deodar at the gate. You know the pegs. I used to count them, going past."

"I know."

"Don't tell him. Please. Didi, I've never asked you for one thing."

She did not say yes.

Her whole body wanted to. The word sat behind her teeth, warm and easy. But she was on the rope. The rope did not distinguish between a promise made to a brother in a woodpile and one made to a lover in a hut. A promise was a contract with the mountain. If she gave it and one day broke it, she would pay as for a great lie, and the cold would not ask her reasons.

"I can't promise," she said. "Listen to me. I can't, and you know why. If I swear and it goes wrong, it takes my hands."

"Then—"

"But I can choose, and I'm choosing now." She took his chin and turned his face to hers. "I'm not going in there tonight to tell him. I'm not saying I never will. That's all I can give you, and I'm giving it with my eyes open."

Kiran's wet eyes searched her face. "That's not *never*."

"No."

"You picked it careful."

"I did." She had. She had built the sentence as she would build a handhold on rotten rock, so the mountain would find nothing in it to grip. Tonight was a thing she could do. Never was a thing the cold could hold her to. "Quiet is free. It always has been. And if he asks, then it'll be a different day. Don't make me have that one now."

He let his head fall against her shoulder. He was thin as a fence-post under the pattu. She held him, and in her other hand the dead boy's badge dug into her palm.

Rohan would have to be told, someday. That was plain, and she made herself look at it. He was a man who signed the blockade and said so. Told the truth, a man like that could do one of two things. He could report Kiran, as the law demanded and as he had demanded of himself for two winters, and see the boy hanged at the peg beside the notice. Or he could break his oath before eleven men, and the law with it, and everything he had built his face around.

If I bend once, nothing holds. He had said it in the hut, and the rope had agreed.

She could force him to choose tonight, with Kiran barely mended and the Fair four days off. Or she could say nothing and let him walk on toward the seal and his sister. He had a thing he must do before the Fair. He did not need this on top.

It was not a choice between telling and lying. She would not lie. It was a choice between speaking and keeping quiet, and for as long as he never asked, the quiet cost her nothing.

That was the part that frightened her. It cost her nothing at all.

*

She got Kiran back on his feet. His cap stayed in the mud by the woodpile. They went in by the back of Nimmi's house, her arm round him, his stockings leaving wet prints on the boards. The passage ran by the storehouse, and the storehouse door opened before she reached it.

Rohan stood there with one hand on the frame. He had not slept, she could tell, or had not wanted to. The rope lay slack across his boots.

Kiran kept his head down and shuffled past, and the bare ear went by at the height of Rohan's chest.

Rohan's eyes followed it.

Meera watched them go. They went to the puckered rim, the missing curl of it, and stayed one breath too long for chance. He had a warden's report in his head, she knew. Blood on the ice, and a curl of frozen cartilage no longer than a fingernail. Had the two come together behind his face? She could not tell. His face gave her nothing but a tired man looking at a sick boy. She was afraid they had.

Then Nimmi came out of the sickroom, took one look and took the boy, and said nothing, which for Nimmi was a speech. The door shut. Rohan's eyes came back to Meera's.

"Is he warm?" he said.

"He's warm. He'll keep his toes."

"Good."

That was all. She waited for the rest. He stood there with a question close to the surface of his face, and it did not come. She saw him lay something down, like a man setting a heavy sack on a shelf, with care, and stepping back from it. He had seen something. Whether he knew what it was, she could not say. He had chosen not to ask.

"He ran from me," said Rohan. "I know why a smuggler runs from a warden. I should have known better than to speak of crews in his hearing, while he was ill. I put him in fear, in a bed he could not leave." He looked at her. "Whatever it was he heard, it is his. If he wants to say it, he will. I will not go in and ask him."

"Rohan—"

"You do not have to tell me anything." His voice was low. "You made that rule in the hut. I keep it. I would be a poor sort of man if I only kept it when it suited me."

She had braced for probing. She had not braced for this. It would have been easier to hate.

She stepped in and put her forehead against his chest, on the good side. His hand came up and rested on her back, light, as if she were a thing he had decided not to break.

"Thank you," she said into his coat. It was true. Her hands, against his ribs, were warm. That was what shamed her.

*

The dusk dose went round at the proper hour. Meera carried the cups herself, steadily, two at a time. Rohan walked at her shoulder in the borrowed brown pattu and took the pot when it grew heavy. Neither of them spoke much. Nimmi counted the two marked cases through, one by one, with her lips moving, and wrote the number in chalk on the lintel beside the ash.

Kiran slept through it, or let them think he did. The badge was cold against her ribs.

Later they lay on the blankets in the storehouse with the lamp out and the rope tied between their wrists. Rohan had settled on his right

side with his back to the wall and his arm over her waist. His breathing slowed. After a while it stopped trying to be even, and she knew he was asleep.

She lay awake and looked at the dark.

Eight inches from her lay a man who had told her his sins in plain words with his hands open, and carried her water, and said *I do not know what I will do*. Every true thing he had given her, he had given while exposing his own throat. And she, who had asked him for them, now held in her shirt the one thing that was entirely about his wound.

Seven nights ago she had thought honesty was the whole of the rope.

She understood now that it had a shadow. Silence was free, but free was not the same as clean, and this silence would sit between them every hour that he reached for her. He would be tender, and she would feel the badge, and she would know what he did not. Or what he might. She did not know which was worse. Somewhere ahead was a day when he would stop being kind and become a captain again.

She went through the possible questions as she went through a cornice, looking for the one that would take the ground.

He could ask what the crew did. He could ask about Asha. Either she could meet with a held tongue and a burned stick.

Only one had no way round it.

Was Kiran on Dilan's rope?

If she said yes, her brother hanged. If she said no, it was a great lie, about the one thing that would change every choice he had left to make, and she knew what a great lie did. It did what the frost had done to Hakam's hand in the yard of Kothi Shilak: three fingers where there should have been five. And if she said nothing, and burned a stick, and looked at him, he would know that, too.

He did not have the name yet. When he got it, it would be the only thing he needed to ask.

He slept beside her. His thumb moved once against her hip in his sleep, a small, trusting motion, and went still.

Outside the wind came down off the Saddle and rattled the ash-marked lintel. Somewhere beyond the wall, her brother was breathing, slowly, like a man walking.

She lay with her eyes open and counted the one thing she had left to count: how many days there were until he asked.

Chapter 23

Knots for Children

Meera had spoken six words since waking, and Rohan, who counted what mattered, had counted every one.

Warm enough. No. Later. Yes. Eat. The last had been for Kiran, through a wall.

The snow had come in the night and lay knee-deep in the lane. They had meant to be gone at first light. Nimmi came in stamping her boots and said the lower road had drifted shut at the gully bend, that the carter had turned back before dawn, and that no sound man would walk it until tomorrow. Rohan did the sums twice, the way he did them for a burial roll. He told Meera what the delay cost: a day he did not have, spent. She nodded and went on rolling blankets.

She was holding something inside her coat. He had watched her do it all morning, a flat hand pressed to her ribs, as a person holds a bruise they have decided not to mention. She had not shown him what it was. He had a notion about it, and he did not pick the notion up.

He could have asked. The rope would have let him, and she would have answered true or burned a stick for it. That was the rule she had made in the hut, and it was the one thing in this house that was entirely hers. So he handed her the water jug, left his questions on the shelf, and found that holding still cost more than the climb had.

Nimmi laid the last of the redbark on the table.

It was not much to look at: the bottom of one packet and the creased waxed paper of another. "Three doses, what Sunni never finished," she said. "The Dev boy's father. Kamla's two, who came up out of that sleep on walnut leaf and spite. After that I brew walnut leaf and I swear at it."

"Twenty-three went without," said Meera.

"Twenty-three would have gone without if you'd never come. Don't." Nimmi folded her arms. "There's a buyer. Masked. Pays the lower-lane runners for any medicine that crosses, last winter and the one before. Silver, no haggling. Some of it found its way up my back road. I never met him."

Rohan's mind wrote the charge down before he could stop it: *traf-ficking*, then *harbouring*, in a neat clerk's hand. He watched his own fingers not reach for a pen.

"Does the lane still carry for him?" Meera asked.

"The lane carries for anyone who pays. Kiran's lot tie a cord on my latch when they want a meeting. Two knots, plain, no tail. It means the grove behind the house, by night." Nimmi looked from Meera's face to Rohan's. "I can get word down the lane. I won't promise what comes back."

"Do it," said Meera.

*

At midday Nimmi let the three well enough to sit up into the kitchen, where the chulha was, and told Rohan to keep them off the floor and out of the cold. He had no talent for it. He sat on the bench with a coil of Nimmi's spare cord and the red rope running out of the door at his wrist, and three pairs of very serious eyes watched it.

Kamla's girl was five and had lost her front teeth. "Is that for hanging?"

"It is for walking."

"It's tied to a lady."

"It is tied to a guide," said Rohan. "She is in charge of me. This is called being in the care of an expert."

The Dev boy, who was eight and had the look of someone who had decided to be unimpressed, said, "Wardens tie people up. Everybody knows."

"Some of us tie knots. Some of us are tied by them." Rohan took the cord and made a bight. "Recruits at the Shilak post learn a game before they learn the real work. One of you ties me. The rest watch for the trick. If I can slip it, I win. If I cannot, you do."

Nobody had asked for a game. But the girl came off the bench and put her small wet hands on his wrist, and he showed her the turn and the tuck, and she tied him with the fierce care of a child wrapping a gift.

He slipped it in four breaths.

"*Again*," said the Dev boy.

They tied him four more times. He taught them the half-turn that looks locked and isn't, and the one that holds against any pull, the double hitch he tied on everything he valued. The Dev boy got it on his second try and turned it over with grim satisfaction. Kamla's boy, who had said nothing and eaten the whole bowl of broth, wound the rest of the cord about Rohan's good wrist and the bench leg and sat on the knot.

"You're arrested," said the Dev boy.

"On what charge?"

The boy thought about it. "Sleeves."

Rohan looked down at the borrowed brown pattu, where the cuffs stopped a hand's width above his wrists. "I admit it," he said. "I plead guilty."

Someone laughed in the doorway.

It was not a polite laugh. It came out rough and surprised, and it bent her over the frame with a hand on her stomach. Meera stood there in the cold with a pot against her hip, laughing until she had to wipe her eyes on her wrist, looking at a captain of the queen's pass-wardens pinned to a bench by a child of three.

He had not heard it since Sunni. He had not known he was waiting to.

"Don't," said Rohan. "I am a prisoner. Mocking me is undignified."

"Plead guilty," she gasped. "To the *sleeves*."

"It is a serious offence."

The children shrieked. The little one bounced on the knot. And Rohan sat there, tied by a child, and let himself look at her face with the colour in it. It lasted perhaps as long as a held breath. Then he saw her catch herself, a hand coming flat against her coat again, the laugh going out of her.

She put the pot down. "I'll see to the water."

He freed himself. It took one pull, because the child had tied it as he had taught her to, and it held.

*

They packed in the storehouse in the grey afternoon. It took no time at all. There was little enough to carry: the count, the dry sticks of a fire they no longer needed, two sacks of Nimmi's walnut leaf for the lower road. His grey pattu came up from the bottom of its sack smelling of camphor, and he rolled it at his belt.

Meera knelt on the blankets with the red rope across her knees, checking it from end to end for wear. She checked it every night. This time she checked it twice.

"Meera."

She looked up. The distance was already in her eyes. It was not hostility, only a care in how she held herself, a person walking over a floor she knew was thin.

"May I say a thing that is not a promise?"

Something moved at the corner of her mouth. "Those are the only kind that are free."

"I intend to petition the queen to strike the clause from my writ that names the Salt Fox." He said it slowly, so it would all be there. "I will put my name to the petition. It will say the writ was drawn on a false report, and that the Guide of Shilak carried my life across the Saddle and my seal to the Fair. If the queen is in a mood to be offended, it will cost me the

post. Perhaps more. I cannot tell you she will grant it. I cannot tell you I will be alive to ask." He held his hands open on his knees. "So I do not promise. I would rather give you a sentence that is true than a larger one that is not."

The rope lay across her knees and made no sound. A promise would have hummed. This did not, and he saw her feel the difference, the small stillness in her wrist as she listened to nothing.

He had weighed the word for an hour that morning, over the dull task of packing. A promise already rode this rope, made in a hut in a storm, to not let her fall. He was careful about adding to it. A man who swears what he cannot guarantee has the cold for a bride, and he had seen how that went. He had watched her hand go white on the Saddle over a lie the size of a pebble.

"You said *I intend*," said Meera.

"Yes."

"You could have made it prettier. You could have said *I swear it* and let me hold it." Her voice was low, and not as steady as she meant it to be. "You said it so I could stand on it."

"I thought you would prefer something that would bear weight."

"I do." Her thumb moved along the wool. "Rohan. Your career. The writ is the only thing you've got besides the seal, and you've just—"

"I know what I have just done."

She put out her hand and laid it over his wrist, the bare skin below the short sleeve. Her fingers were warm. He remembered the pitch above the waystone, when she had taken his cold, and what it had cost her.

"Thank you," she said.

It was the right word. It was said with her whole face. And somewhere beneath it, he heard a door that had been open a hand's width close to a finger's. She looked at his coat, where the cord of the seal and the end of a dead man's rope lay folded together, and then away. She drew her hand back.

He did not reach after it. It was hers to take back.

*

Night came early. Meera sat with Kiran through the wall, the rope threading the gap in the boards between them, and Rohan took the lamp and the back of a tally sheet and wrote to his sister.

He did not know how it would reach her. The carter was gone and the regent's men held the road. He had written to the families of seven buried wardens on much worse terms than these. A letter was a way of putting a thing in order.

Ila, he wrote. *I am alive. I am coming. The snow has taken the day I held in hand, so I will reach Garh Neshar only on the evening before the Fair. If the road takes another, I will push through the night and come to the meadow on the morning itself. Say nothing in the yard about me to anyone who sits at his table. You will want to correct someone. Do not.*

I carry a thing I will not name in a letter. I have been wrong about a number of things this winter, and I am learning to say so aloud, which is harder than the climbing. There is a woman here who has taught me some of it. I will tell you about her when you have sat down.

I will tell you about Dilan's rope as well. I think you would have liked him. He could not carry a tune.

He read it over. It was not a report. He did not know what it was. He struck out *a woman here* and wrote it again, and left it.

Mind the north wall. It offends me to think of it two spans out of true.

He folded it into his coat, beside the speech he could not finish. On the other side of the boards, Meera said something low to her brother, and Kiran answered, and Rohan caught the rhythm of it without the words. Siblings, talking low in a dark room. He had gone without that sound for a long time.

*

The knock came as he was banking the brazier.

Nimmi stood in the passage with her shawl over her head and snow on the shoulders of it. In her hand was a length of undyed wool cord with three hard knots near one end and a long tail ending in a loop.

"On my latch," she said. "A moment ago. No tracks."

Meera was through the door before the rope drew taut. She took the cord from Nimmi's fingers and ran her thumb along it, counting the knots as she counted everything.

"Three," she said. "And a tail." She frowned. "Kiran's crew stop at two, Nimmi, and cut the end square. I've tied it that way myself. This isn't ours."

Rohan knew the two-knot cord. It was in a file at the Shilak post, among the seized things of three winters: *crew signal, two knots, meeting by night.* He knew this one too, from a lesser page: *unknown signal, three-and-tail, twice found on lower-lane latches, never answered.* He had written *seen* beside it more than once. He had never found anyone at the other end.

"Then it's the grove all the same," said Nimmi. "The loop points that way. The runners have a pouch tied just so when the silver comes, and not one of them will say who from." She looked at the cord. "It's him."

"The buyer."

"Nobody pays for medicine and asks nothing," said Nimmi. "Nobody ever has."

"No." Meera's hand closed over the cord. "He doesn't send for me for free. Moonrise."

She tucked it into her coat, beside the thing she had been holding there all day. Rohan watched it go. Then she looked at him across the lamp, and he saw her wait for him to say what a captain would say.

"Then we go to the grove," he said.

It had come out too fast, and he made himself slow down. The cord had hung on lower-lane latches for three winters and no one had answered it. That was what made it a fine thing to leave, if a man wished to learn who would come. The regent's people were hunting a man in grey, and they could hardly ask for better bait than a sick village's need, with the one woman on the mountain who would walk toward it.

"It may be set for me," he said. "Nobody has ever answered it. I would like you to hear that said aloud."

"I heard it the moment Nimmi did." Her mouth was thin. "He still has the medicine."

"Yes."

So he went on, because the next thing was worse. In the hut he had sworn he would not let her fall on this mountain, and the rope had hummed. If he now stood behind a wall with his tongue held while she met a stranger in the dark, those two vows could pull against each other. If they did, one would break and strike him as a great lie strikes. He knew which one he would break. He knew what it would cost him, and he judged the price was his to carry, not hers.

"I will keep behind the wall, at the full length of the rope."

"You know the length."

"Eight spans. I have carried it fifteen days." He did not look away. "I will not interrupt you, and I will not ask afterwards what was said."

The rope hummed.

It was low and level, and it ran up the wool into her wrist. He saw her feel it. Her hand went to her coat and stayed there, flat over the place where the cord had gone, and her face closed, quietly, like a shutter drawn across a lit room. He could not read what lay behind it. He could read only that his promise had weighed more than he had meant it to.

It was a long moment before she nodded, and her nod held less than the one before.

He took the lamp and put it out. In the dark, the red rope drew taut between them and held, and he could not tell whether it was she who pulled.

Chapter 24

Cut-Corner Silver

The wall ran along the bottom of the grove, dry-stone and chest high, and the red rope ran over it.

Meera walked until the line went taut at her left wrist, then took one more step so the wool bit. Eight arm-spans. On the far side of the stones Rohan sat in the snow with his back against them. She could not see him. She could feel him on the other end, still as a post.

Ahead, the walnut trees stood black under a rising moon. Beneath the largest sat a man on a folded blanket, as if he had come to watch a fair. A pale wool scarf covered his face from the nose down, and a hood hid the rest.

"Guide of Shilak," he said. "You came alone."

"I came with a wall. Don't ask what's behind it."

"Should I?"

His voice was low and unhurried, a voice taught in a good house. She stopped where the rope allowed, a long stride short of him, and kept her hands out of her pockets so he could see them.

"You pay the lower lane for medicine," she said. "For two winters. Why?"

"Why does anyone pay for medicine?"

"That's not an answer."

"Would you trust it if it were?"

She almost smiled. She had dealt with Taravan factors who talked in circles, but they circled toward money. This man circled toward nothing, and he did it politely, which was worse.

"Twelve packets of redbark crossed Shilak in my pack," she said. "Nine came through sound. They're in Ranu. You'll want to know that."

"Am I owed them?"

"No. They were never for sale."

"Then what do you call it, when a man pays for what he was not sold?"

A light was bobbing in the trees behind her.

She turned, hand dropping toward the knife she did not wear. A clay lamp swung up through the walnut trunks at the height of her hip, held in two small mittens, and under it came a face she knew. Nimmi's grandson. Six years old, in his grandmother's second shawl, with the fringe dragging in the snow.

"Pinku," she whispered. "Go back."

"You went out," said Pinku. "Everybody said stay. Nobody said why."

The masked man was already on his feet. He did not hurry, and he did not loom. He folded down onto his heels in the snow so his hood sat below the boy's eyes.

"Does your grandmother know where you are?"

"She said stay."

"And you are a person of great independence." He took the lamp, gently, and held it where the wind would not reach the flame. "Then walk back in my footsteps, so the snow keeps your secret. Can you do that?"

Pinku considered. "Are you a robber?"

"Do I look like a robber?"

"You look like a scarf."

The man's shoulders shook. He put something in the boy's mitten, and when the fingers opened it was a walnut, whole and dark, with a rib-

bon of red thread knotted round the shell. “For the long walk. Open it when you are inside.”

The boy went. The lamp’s glow dwindled down the trees, and the buyer watched it all the way, his head turned so Meera saw only the line of his hood.

She had meant to dislike him. She put that down for later.

“Well,” he said, rising. “Your silver.”

He took a purse from his coat and tipped it into her glove. The coins were thin squares, heavier than lowland bits, and each had one corner clipped off clean, as though a mouse had bitten it. She turned one in the moonlight. The cut was neat. Someone had made it with a tool, forty times in the same place.

“What’s wrong with them?”

“What would be wrong with silver?”

“Nothing is wrong with silver. Something is wrong with this.” She counted. Nineteen. She closed her fist on them and, from habit, fixed the cut in her mind as she would fix the shape of a face. “I’ll write it in the count. I write everything.”

“Then write that it spends.”

Next he lifted a canvas sack from behind the tree and set it between them. It was heavy and square, bound with tarred cord. On the cloth, inked in black, was a bell: a small brass assembly bell, the seal of a house with a brass bell in its hall.

She did not touch it yet.

“That is the regent’s own,” she said.

“Is it?”

“It’s his store mark. The grain sacks in Ranu carry the same.” Her throat had gone tight. “That’s his redbark. From his cellar.”

“Does a cellar care whom it feeds?” He pushed the sack an inch toward her with his boot. “Twenty-three go without in that village. I would rather they did not. There is enough here to finish them and some over, if your healer does not stretch it into water.”

The wall behind her was silent. She could feel Rohan listening to nothing, doing exactly as he had sworn. It was worse than if he had spoken.

"There's more," said the masked man, and the lightness went out of his voice for the first time. "You won't like it."

"I don't like any of this."

"The captain's lieutenant. A tall man, handsome, polite about regulations. Did you think the mountain kept him?"

The cold went through her faster than the wind. "Varun."

"He crossed the Saddle eleven days after you, bound at the Shilak Cairn to a salt-road man who would speak his own name for the price. They came down through Garh Neshar. He sleeps in the regent's guest wing." The wool of the scarf moved with his breath. "A woman called Asha rides with him. The regent has put a warrant in his hand. It names a seal-thief and a traitor, and it names a captain of wardens. They leave Garh Neshar tonight with twenty men. They will reach Ranu at dawn."

She heard the number and could not make it mean anything. Then it did. The drift at the gully bend had turned the carter back, but it would not turn twenty men with shovels and a warrant. The lower road was reopening behind it, dug out for the crown's riders by the regent's own hands.

"Dawn," she said.

"Dawn."

"How do you know?"

"Do you think a regent's hall has thin walls?"

"Do you always do this?" she snapped. "Everything I ask, a question back. People are dying in that house."

"Yes," he said quietly. "That is why I came myself."

It was not an answer, and it silenced her better than one.

"Your name," she said.

He went still.

"I want it. I'll carry your sack into a sick village. I'll spend your silver. I'd like to put a name in the count beside it."

"Why does a smuggler want names?" He tilted his head. "Names are what the pegs in the deodar at your gate are for. You know that better than any woman living."

She did. A deodar full of pegs, and every one begun with a name.

"A debt is a reason," she said.

"Is it?"

"Not for you, apparently."

"Then keep the debt," said the masked man. "It's easier to carry than a name." He bowed, the short bow of a man who had been taught it as a boy and had never found a way to stop. "Walk quickly, Guide. Mind your wall."

He was gone through the trunks before she had finished lifting the sack. She stood with nineteen clipped squares in her glove and a regent's bell on the cloth. Her left hand was pressed flat to her coat, over the brass badge Kiran had pressed into her hand at the woodpile, and the hand was cold with plain night air and nothing else.

*

Rohan stood when she came over the wall. He had stood before she cleared it, so the rope would not drag her, and his hand was out to take the sack.

He did not ask.

She watched him not ask. It showed in his mouth, in how he held his weight, in how he turned the sack over and saw the bell and read it. His eyes came up with the question plain in them and his lips shut around it. The promise lay on him like a coat he had chosen.

"You said you wouldn't ask," said Meera.

"I did."

"I'm going to tell you anyway." Her voice was steadier than she was. "That's allowed. It's the only part I get to choose."

She told it plainly, and in order. The questions, the silver, the bell. When she reached Varun, his face did not move. Only the hand on the sack tightened until the cloth crackled.

"Alive," he said.

"Twenty men. Dawn."

"Then the slide did not keep him." Rohan said it as a man reads a figure from a roll, flat and low. "I knew it in the Rope-Hut. I think I wanted it to be a thing I only knew in the hut."

"We could be gone in an hour." She had already counted the road. "Not the lower lane. There's a goat track over the shoulder above the walnut terraces, high and bad, and it comes out well away from the road they're digging open. Garh Neshar's a day and a half with you on foot. If we're off the slope before their horns, we've the long start—"

"And Kiran?"

She stopped.

"You mean to leave him behind," Rohan said. His voice was very gentle. "Under that warrant, he is a smuggler in a marked house, and he cannot stand at the woodpile without the wall to hold. He is too weak to flee. You know it. Twenty men will ride whichever road we take, Meera. They will not need to find us. They will find him."

"The soldiers will mark every door."

"Then we will do what is possible before they come." He set the sack down on the wall. "Nimmi can brew six cups to a pot. Four pots before light. Between us, we can carry them."

She looked at him. He had weighed it already, she saw, in the minutes it had taken her to climb a wall. He had counted, the sums did not come out in his favour, and he had set them down anyway.

"If I stay, it may cost me the Fair," he said. "A warrant strips a writ. By noon I may be a prisoner with no paper to show a gate, and the meadow will go on without me. Hear the rest. The seal does not need me to reach the Fair. It needs hands that are not in irons. If it stays on my body, it is Varun's by noon and the mission dies with my arrest. If it is hidden, it outlives me."

Then he put two fingers to the nape of his coat.

The seam gave to the small knife he had once stirred sattu with. He worked the stitches loose without hurry, his good hand steady, and drew

out a thing she had held once in a fever hut and had given back. Lapis, blue as a shut eye, the goat cut fine on its face. It hung from a cord tied off in the double hitch.

He held it out on his palm.

"Take it."

"Rohan—"

"Varun will search me. He knows exactly what to look for, because I told him." His mouth moved, bitterly. "I told him in the post room, and I thought it was loyalty. If it is on me, it is his. If it is on you, it may be hidden. Hide it where I can't lie about it."

"You can't lie to me."

"To anyone else I can, and will, and the rope will let me." He did not look away. "I would rather be searched honest. Do not tell me where. If I do not know, I cannot give it up, and I cannot be made to say."

She understood what he was putting in her hand. Not a stone. The whole Fair, every mile of it. He had carried it alone through an avalanche and a fever, and the one time she had held it, while he burned, she had sewn it back into his coat unasked. Now he gave it to the woman he had been ordered to deliver at the thaw, as simply as passing the salt.

She took it. It was cold from the night and warm from him.

The cord had come loose from long wearing. She slid the stone through her fingers, found the standing part, and tied it again, two turns round, a tuck, and the locking half-turn. She did not snug it as hard as she had in the hut, when she had been afraid and angry. She tied it as he did, with a little slack to let it breathe. Three children had learned it from him at midday on a kitchen bench.

He watched her hands.

"You've learned it," he said.

"I was shown by an expert."

His eyes creased, briefly. It did not stay.

Her left hand, the one that held the cord, pressed against her coat, and under the wool she felt the edge of the badge. She did not move it.

The rope said nothing. He had not asked her a question, and nothing she had said was false.

But she knew exactly how much she was holding, and in whose hands.

"Now," said Rohan. He turned to the wall, set his forehead near the stones and shut his eyes. "I will count aloud. Go the whole length of the rope. I will not look."

"Rohan."

"One," he said. "Two."

She went. The rope paid out behind her, and he would feel its pull and know which way she had gone. A direction was not a place. At the end of the eight spans lay three choices, each ordinary and none safe: the house wall with its cracks, the goat shed with its loft, the woodpile with its hundred hiding gaps. She thought about who would turn out what first. A soldier checks a loft before he lifts logs. He checks a house before either. She weighed it the way she weighed bales on a salt-house floor.

"Forty," Rohan said behind her, to the wall, in the flat voice he used for burial rolls. "Forty-one."

She chose the woodpile behind the goat shed. She knelt at the third stack, where the split ends faced the wall, and pushed the lapis deep into the gap between two knotted deodar rounds. Then she pulled a curl of loose bark across the hole and set a billet of walnut over it. It took less time than she wanted and more than she could afford. When she came back along the rope her hands were empty and her face was set, and the count had reached a hundred and sixty.

He opened his eyes and did not look at her hands.

"Go and see to Kiran," Rohan said. "I will wake Nimmi and heat the water."

*

They brewed four pots before light.

Nimmi pinched the redbark out of the new sack with her lips pressed so thin they vanished, and said nothing about the bell on the cloth.

Meera carried cups two at a time down the passage. Rohan carried the pots. By the third round the Dev boy's father had colour in his lips, and Kamla's girl had been spoken to sharply for sitting up.

Kiran drank his dose propped against the wall, his eyes on Rohan's back all the way across the room. Meera stood between them for a breath and then moved, so that the line ran through her.

"Didi," said Kiran, very low. "What's that noise?"

"Nothing yet."

"Is it a nothing that's coming?"

"Drink."

The sky in the high window had gone the grey of an old pot. Nimmi was chalking the last tick on the lintel when the sound came down the lane from the lower road, thin and far, rising through the snow-dull air.

A horn. Two notes, falling.

She knew it. She had heard it on the Saddle's lip, climbing out of the dark with a line of torches behind it. Rohan lifted his head at the same moment, and across the passage their eyes met, and neither of them said a word. The red rope between their wrists went taut and quiet.

More horns answered. Boots. The slap of harness on frozen air, and the bells on many shoulders, a thin brass jingle running up the lane like water.

Then a voice, carrying and cheerful, friendly as a neighbour's at a gate. It came from the lower road, and she had last heard it giving orders at a post-room table.

"Captain-ji! Captain-ji, are you in there? It's only me!"

Chapter 25

Captain-ji

The soldiers were fanning out before the horns had finished, and Rohan counted the doors they were walking toward.

Seven marked houses on the lane. Forty-one sick, twenty-three of them one night into the buyer's redbark, and every one of them lying behind a wall of planks. He had seen what a search did to a sickroom. Boots on the floor. A blanket lifted off a child with the grey cough, to see what lay beneath.

"Meera."

"I heard." She was beside him at the storehouse door, her wrist level with his on the rope. "Goat track. We could still—"

"No. Listen." He kept his voice low and even, the one he used on a burial detail. "You are a guide I hired at Kothi Shilak. You are not a smuggler, you are not the Salt Fox, and you know nothing of Varun. You came because the rope took you. Every word of that is a lie to Varun, and lies to him are free. Say them as if you were bored."

Her mouth twisted. "I've never been bored in my life."

"Then borrow mine."

He stepped out into the lane and raised both hands to the height of his shoulders. The left one would not go higher. He let them see that too.

The lane was full of grey wool and small brass bells. Twenty men, perhaps more, with the red-moustached captain from the first patrol

standing at the front. Behind them, at the edge of the trampled snow, stood a knot of people in onion-ochre canvas. Lalit with his spyglass. Two roped pairs. And Asha, arms folded and face turned half away, like a woman waiting for a ferry she had not paid for.

In the middle of them all, on a tall bay horse, sat Varun.

He looked well. That was the first hard thing. His old coat was brushed clean, the pewter buttons dull in a row, the one brass button among them catching the light. He had slept in a guest wing. He swung down with the ease of a man stepping out of a carriage and came across the snow with both arms spread.

"Captain-ji!" He seemed truly glad. "Gods, you look dreadful. Sleeves too short. Is that a woman's pattu?"

"Lieutenant."

"Not anymore, I'm afraid." Varun drew a paper from inside his coat. The wax was red and stamped with a small bell. "I have a duty, and you'll forgive me. I'd rather be reading it to you in the post room over tea."

He read it aloud, in the clear voice of a man who had been praised for reading. The warrant named Rohan, captain of the Shilak wardens, as a thief of the queen's seal and a traitor to the regency of Neshar. It commanded him taken, searched and held for judgment at the Fair.

Rohan looked at the doors. At the soldiers waiting at them with their hands on the latches.

"I surrender," he said.

Varun's eyebrows rose. "I haven't finished the last line."

"I know it. It says all houses harbouring the accused may be searched." Rohan kept his hands where they were. "I am the accused. Search me. Keep your men out of the sick rooms and I will not give you an hour's trouble. You have my word as a captain of wardens, for what it is now worth to you."

"It's worth a great deal." Varun said it kindly. Then he turned his head and raised one finger, and the soldiers at the doors stepped back, and Rohan let out a breath that was only breath.

It had cost him nothing yet. He knew that. It was the first coin of a long account.

*

They searched him in the lane, in front of everyone.

Two soldiers stripped him of his borrowed brown pattu and his coat and ran their hands down every seam. They found the speech on the back of Nimmi's tally sheet, the folded writ and a flat tin of wax. Varun read the speech, smiled, glanced at the rest as a man glances at a lock without its key, and slid it all back into the lining. They found his knife. They slit the nape of the coat where the stitches had already been picked loose, found the empty pocket, and held it up.

"Nothing, sir."

Varun took the coat. He turned it over and put his thumb in the pocket and felt about, slowly, as if it might be shy. Then he found the last thing, folded in the lining: the forearm's length of grey wool, rolled and tied with its own cord, one end whipped in neat black thread.

"Ah," he said softly.

Rohan did not move. He did not let his face move. But the wool in Varun's hand was Dilan's, and Varun knew it, because Varun had stood in the warden hall with ten others and watched him swear on it.

"I remember this," Varun said. "You wept, a little. You tried to hide it." He studied the clean-cut end. Then he held it out, almost tenderly, and Rohan took it with a hand that did not shake. "Keep it. I'd never take that. I thought it was the stone, Captain-ji, truly. I thought you'd be the sort to hide it in the thing you love."

And then Varun smiled.

It was not the smile of a man who had lost. Rohan watched it spread and knew it for what it was, as a surveyor knows the true shape of a hill once the mist lifts. Varun had not wanted to find the stone on him.

"It's not on you," Varun said. "That's rather lovely. If it were, I'd hang you at noon on the nearest tree and be back in Garh Neshar for supper. But you've put it somewhere." He tapped the empty pocket.

"The regent pays for the stone. Not for you. A lordship, you know. The Walnut Terraces, and the deed's already drawn, to be signed when the thing is in his hand. So I need you breathing, and near, and worried." He glanced at the lane, at the doors, at the grey faces behind the shutters. "And I need this village to stay exactly where it is, with all its little hiding places."

Every house in Ranu is a hole in the ground, Rohan thought. *And he has just told me he will turn out every one.*

Rohan did not know where the stone was. He had made sure of that. It was the only comfort he had, and it was cold.

"Jassi's second," said Varun. "You walked the gully ahead of me. What are you doing here?"

Meera had come to the storehouse door and stopped at the end of the rope, her face as empty as a plate.

"A guide. Hired at Kothi Shilak."

"Hired, and tied to you by wool?" Varun's gaze dropped to the red rope, running from Rohan's wrist to hers, and he whistled. "A jogini binding! I wore one myself to come over, but I never thought to see you in one." He walked the length of the cord with his eyes. "And it holds you the way it held me? She can't leave you?"

"Eight spans," said Rohan. It was true, and free to tell. "Past that we both freeze."

"Then she's no use to me loose, and no use to you gone." Varun pondered it as a man studies a convenient shelf. "Chain her to your belt, then. Two spans of iron. The rope can stay, I wouldn't dare cut it. Hired guide." He tipped his head to Meera. "No hard feelings, my dear. You're the best-informed witness in the valley, and I'd hate to lose you to a cold night."

"Whatever you pay," said Meera, in a voice so bored that Rohan nearly believed her.

Varun's eyes passed over her without a flicker. He was looking at Jassi's second, a woman in a stained and frayed pattu, and nothing more.

He did not know what she was. Rohan saw how thin the single thread of her safety was, and that it ran through him.

The irons were cold. A soldier with a wet cough locked one cuff around Rohan's left wrist, then the right, and a short chain to his belt. Meera got a single band around her left forearm, pulled over her glove, and a length of chain that ended at his waist. She did not look at it. She looked at the middle distance, with the same flat patience she gave a bad rope.

*

"Now," said Varun. "Everyone's out, I think. Everyone who can stand."

They had come to the doors. They always did, in the end, the sick-house people, the nursing ones with grey faces and knotted shawls. Nimmi stood in her own doorway under the fresh-chalked tally. Pinku was at her skirts, mouth open. Behind her, along the lane, a dozen more.

Varun mounted the lowest step of the nearest house and raised his voice, so it would carry.

"Good people of Ranu! I am your regent's officer, and I have come to protect you. I'm sorry for the soldiers. A man in this valley has stolen what belongs to the crown, and he's stood in your kitchens and eaten at your tables." He swept a hand toward Rohan. "That's one. But there's another thing, and I think you ought to hear it, because it concerns your dead."

The lane went still.

"There is a runner of Kothi Shilak," said Varun. "Kiran. His crew sells to a middleman I know well, and I've had many a long winter of their talk, over many a pot. There was a night two winters ago when a young warden died on the road ice below the third bend." He turned to Rohan, and his face softened in the way of a man handing over a hard gift. "Dilan. You remember him, Captain-ji. You loved him. The men I buy from told me the runner who was on his rope that night was Kiran. A boy of twenty-two, with his ear frozen to the shelf, who walked away alive and left your Dilan dead."

Nobody breathed.

"He's in that house." Varun pointed, with the open palm of an honest man. Nimmi's house. The third marked door. "He has been sleeping in your sickhouse, Rohan, on your side of the wall. The smuggler who killed your boy."

Rohan heard the word *Kiran* and the world did a very slow thing.

He saw an ear with its rim gone. He saw a cartilage curl in a warden's report, no longer than a fingernail. He saw a young man's eyes go to his face on the first day and flinch, and a boy asleep with a fist closed on something. He saw a woman's flat hand pressed to her coat all through a snowed-in morning, as over a bruise she would not name, and the notion he had had about it, the one he had not picked up.

He picked it up now. It was heavy.

He turned his head. He could not help it.

Meera stood a chain's length away with her eyes on nothing. Not the ground. Not the sky. She was looking at a spot in the air between a soldier's shoulder and a roof post, a place with nothing in it, and her face had the stillness of a woman holding a full cup on a staircase.

She did not look at him. That was the answer, or it was not. He could not tell.

A soldier shifted. A child began to cry. At the end of the lane Nimmi said, very clearly, "He's a sick man in my care, and you'll not lay a finger on him," and Varun, with a small bow, said that of course nobody would. A man too ill to run did not need to be chained. A guard on the door would do, and Nimmi could keep her ward.

"For now," he added, lightly, and stepped down.

*

Rohan had thought he would be furious.

He was not. He stood in the trampled snow with Dilan's rope in his hand, and a kind of silence came up in him, the silence of the morning after a burial. There was a name in it now, and a face attached to the

name, and the face had been asleep in a room on the other side of a plank wall while he laughed at a bench with three children.

He chose not to ask, he thought. *In the passage. He saw the ear and chose not to ask. Why did he choose?*

Because he did not want the answer.

He made himself look at the rest of the lane, because it was what he did with things he could not carry. The soldiers had brought buckets of ash. Three of them were working along the row of marked houses, wetting the old handprints with a rag and pressing new ones over them, plate-wide, grey, fresh. The patrol's rule made sense of it. A week's work, done in an hour, for the pleasure of seeing it done.

Nimmi's door took the last print. The soldier smoothed the fingers with his thumb.

Asha stood ten paces off, watching.

She had not said a word since the warrant. She stood with her thumbs hooked in her belt, at the edge of the ochre canvas, and her eyes went to the ash. Then to the lintel, where a child had scratched a lopsided goat into the wood. Then to Varun's back.

The brash set of her mouth slackened, and she went quiet, the way people do who have just done sums and don't like the total.

She had been paid to track a stone, he thought. She had not been paid to stand in a lane of marked doors.

Her eyes met his, briefly. They were hard and pale and unreadable. She looked away first.

*

The lockhouse was a squat stone store at the foot of the village, built for grain. It had one door, barred outside, and one slit of a window. Someone had swept it for the occasion. The floor smelled of damp oats.

A soldier shoved the door shut and the bar fell, and then it was dark, and then it was not, because Meera had found the slit and stood in the thin grey light with her back to him.

The chain ran from his belt to her arm. It was two spans, and slack, and it lay between them on the oats.

She sat, slowly. He sat. Neither spoke.

He had given his word at the grove that he would not ask what had been said there. He had kept it, to the letter, all night. He turned that over now as a man turns a coin he is afraid is bad. The promise concerned the grove. It did not concern Dilan. It did not concern her brother's ear. It left him free to put a question, and the freedom was no kindness, because the answer scared him.

He knew the rope. He knew its price. A lie would take her hand.

A truth would take her brother.

He could see her breath in the light. She had pulled the left hand inside her pattu, as she had all morning, and was holding it there against her ribs.

"Meera."

"Don't." It was barely a sound. "Not here. They'll hear."

"Then I will keep it low." He moved a little nearer, until the chain lay across his knee and he could speak into the dark beside her ear and no one on the other side of the door could hear a word. He had spent his life asking precise questions, and he made this one the most precise of all, because he found that he could not say it any other way.

"Was Kiran on Dilan's rope?"

Chapter 26

No

The question sat in the dark between them, and Meera did the sum.

She did it the way she did every sum, fast and in a column. Three lines. Silence, truth, lie.

Silence first, because silence was free. She had leaned on it for sixteen days. But silence given to this question, by this man, in this room, was not silence. It was a yes with the sound cut off. Rohan read a quiet the way he read a ledger. He would hear it and know. Then he would carry it, because he could carry nothing else. He would stand before the assembly with the queen's stone in his hand, and when they asked him what he knew, he would say it. He had never learned how to do anything else with a fact.

The truth was shorter. *Yes.* One word, and a boy who could not stand at a woodpile without a wall would hang from a deodar with a peg hammered in for him. Rohan had sworn on a rope end before eleven wardens to find the man at the far end of it. Varun had already pointed at the house.

Then the third line.

A lie about this would be a great one. She knew the scale, because she had taught it to children at the Shilak Cairn for ten winters. A great lie killed flesh. The cold would go to her hands first.

She had two hands, and she was a guide.

Two fingers, she thought. *Three at the worst. I can still hold a rope with the right.*

It was not courage. It was bookkeeping. Kiran's life stood on one side of the ledger, and a part of her body stood on the other, and the numbers were not close.

"No," said Meera.

The word came out flat and ordinary, and she hated how well it sounded.

For a heartbeat nothing happened. Then the rope on her wrist went to ice.

It did not feel like cold. Cold she knew, the plain honest kind that came off the Saddle and could be argued with. This came from inside the wool, from the knot, and ran down her left hand in a single pull, as if someone had drawn a wet thread through her bones. Her palm went numb. Her middle finger stung and let go. The ring finger and the little finger did not sting at all. They simply stopped being hers.

She did not look. She did not need to. Inside the glove, under the iron band they had clamped over it, two fingers had gone white and hard as candle wax, and she could feel exactly where her hand ended.

She made her breath go in through the nose. In, two, three. Out.

She drew the hand off her knee and into her lap, under the fold of her pattu, and laid the good one over it like a lid.

*

Rohan did not move.

She could not see his face. The slit of window threw its grey light along the wall, not across it, and he sat on the dark side of the chain with his shoulders square. He had gone so still that she heard oats shift under the iron.

She waited for the sound. Something would say it, the wind in a stone, a note climbing. It was what the cairns did. But there was no cairn in a grain store, only the rope, and the rope was only wool, and it lay

between them as quiet as a snake in winter. He had not asked for a promise. There was nothing to hum.

Say something, she thought at him. *Say you don't believe me. Say anything.*

Her shoulders had begun to shake.

She had not given them leave. It came up through her ribs in small hard jerks, the shaking of a body that has been told a great lie and is trying to throw it off, and she clamped her teeth to keep the noise in. The good hand pressed down on the bad one. Under the pattu she felt nothing at all through the glove, and that was the worst of it. Not pain. A gap, where a hand had been.

In the dark, the chain moved.

It was a small sound, iron on oats. She turned her head. Rohan's right hand had come up off his knee, slowly, the cuff dragging, and it hung in the air in front of her pattu with the fingers a little open.

She knew what it was. She had done it herself, in a hollow under the Saddle's lip, for a man with a bad rib and a worse story. He only had to find her bare skin. A wrist, the soft place under the thumb. He would take the cold off her and into himself, and he would know the whole shape of it in one breath: *she lied, and it was great.* Not what the truth was. He would not need to learn it. The size of the lie would tell him.

She did not pull her hand away. She was too tired and too cold, and part of her wanted to be known by him more than it wanted to be safe.

His hand stayed where it was for three breaths.

Then it went down. It lay flat on the oats beside his knee, palm to the floor, as if he had put it somewhere to keep it out of trouble.

"Thank you for answering," said Rohan.

His voice was low and perfectly level. She would have known nothing from it if she had not listened to him lie to himself for three weeks.

"Don't," she said. It scraped. "I didn't do it for you."

"No." A pause. "That I believe."

It was true. She'd said it clean and the rope took it clean, and she was grateful for the one small thing that was free.

He said no more. He moved his weight a hand's width away on the oats, no further than the chain allowed, and sat looking at the wall. It was the courtesy of a man leaving a room without leaving it.

She could not tell what it was. She turned it over, and over, and it would not settle. Either he had decided she was telling the truth, and had spared her the shame of being tested, or he had known she wasn't, and had let her keep the lie because the alternative was a rope end and a boy with half an ear. She had no way to find out. Asking would cost her another lie, or another truth. And he would not say, because he would not say what he did not mean.

Mercy, she thought, *or belief.*

Both of them look the same from here.

*

The light moved.

It came slowly up the wall, a long grey bar, and stopped on the lintel, and sat there. The lockhouse smelled of damp oats and iron and, faintly, of his coat, which he no longer wore. They had taken that. He was in his shirt and a borrowed felt jerkin, and he had not said he was cold.

She did not say she was.

Her left hand had stopped being a thing she could picture. The numbness had climbed past the knuckles and was working in at the wrist, under the iron band. The metal was colder than her skin now, which was a strange thing to know. She pressed her elbow against her ribs and felt the brass badge under the wool, Dilan's, with the nail-scratched letters on its back. She pressed it with her arm because she could no longer feel it with the hand.

She hoped the dead boy had understood her. She had never asked him anything.

Outside, boots crossed the frozen snow. Two men, by the sound, coming to stand at the door and settle. One had a wet cough she knew. He was the soldier who had locked the cuff on Rohan.

"Gods, I'm froze," said the cough, and spat.

"Then stamp. You'll be warm soon enough."

"Tonight, they're saying?"

"Pasang says tonight." There was a pause. She heard a stopper pulled, a swallow. "Not the lieutenant. The captain's got the other paper, the sealed one, from the hall. Lieutenant wants it all held till the stone turns up. Captain says the paper doesn't care what the lieutenant wants."

"What's the paper say?"

"Burn the cough."

Meera's good hand went still on the bad one.

"Burn it how?"

"How d'you think? Houses are marked for a reason. Ash on every lintel, so we know which to light and which to leave." The man laughed, short and without much in it. "Pasang says it's the cleanest way. A fire takes the sick and the sickness both. And whoever's been sitting up with them. Healer, the woman, the hired hands. Anyone who's seen what the regent's grain sacks look like in a house where the children are dying."

"Seen what?"

"Ask the regent."

"I'd sooner not."

"Aye. Me neither."

They stopped talking. She heard the cough go, and the stopper again.

Seven houses, she thought. Forty-one sick in the lane, and the ones who tended them. Kiran, in the third marked house, on a pallet by the plank wall with a guard on the door and a chalk tally overhead that Nimmi had made herself. Pinku, six, with a clay lamp and a walnut tied up in red thread. A woodpile behind a goat shed, and in the third stack, between two deodar rounds, a stone as blue as a shut eye.

Fire would not burn lapis. But a cord could burn. A shed could come down across a woodpile. A soldier with a torch had no reason to be gentle with logs.

She had lied to save a boy from a rope. Tonight they would put him in a furnace, and she had spent two fingers.

That's not how the count goes, she told herself. *You don't get to say it was for nothing. Not until the night's out.*

Beside her, Rohan said in his burial-roll voice, "Seven houses."

"I heard."

"Forty-one in the lane. Nimmi has eight she would not have moved at all." The chain made a small sound. "There is no way to move them."

"Then we don't move them."

"Meera—"

"I'm thinking." It was a poor answer, and she heard how it sounded. Her breath fogged in the slit of light. It went up pale and thin and hung there.

He turned his head toward her. In the dark she felt the look land and did not meet it, and then she did.

He was looking at her face, not at her hand. His eyes were dry, very steady, the colour of slate at dusk. There was a question in them, the same one, but different now. He had asked it once and had his answer. This one was of another kind. It asked whether she was cold.

"I'm here," said Meera.

Nothing happened. No flare of white, no climb in the air. A small thing. It was true by the measure of the rope. She was here, and breathing, though she was a long way from well, and she had not said *well*. She had picked the one word the mountain could not argue with.

His mouth moved. It was not a smile. "You have a gift," said Rohan, "for the kind of truth the cold can't catch."

"I've had practice."

"Yes." He studied the oats between his boots. "So have I."

It was the nearest he came. He did not say *I know you lied.* He did not say *I believe you.* She waited for it, hungry as she was, and it stayed unsaid, and he went back to looking at the wall.

*

Time went strangely in the lockhouse.

The bar of light slid across the lintel and down the far wall. Somewhere a bell rang once, a goat's, tinny and unconcerned. Nimmi's voice rose in the lane, sharp, and was silenced. A cart rolled past with something heavy in it. She heard the soldiers grunt and counted twelve strokes of a mallet, a hammering sound she could not place until she did. They were nailing planks across Nimmi's goat shed door. They were sealing it for the night.

At some point the wrist went.

She knew it the way she knew a crossing going bad, by the thing that was missing. The iron band had been cold against her skin, and then it was no colder than the skin. She tried to flex the hand inside the glove. The thumb moved. The first finger moved. The middle, slowly. The other two lay as if they belonged to a stranger sleeping.

Ring and little, she thought. *Left.*

She'd tied her last knots with the right. Hadn't she? She'd drawn a knife in the Rope-Hut one-handed, swung an adze on the Teeth, written the count. She'd been right-handed for twenty-nine winters. It would be a nuisance. It would be less than a nuisance. Hakam in Kothi Shilak had three fingers and ran a goat string with a quickness that made young crossers swear.

Hakam's were the mountain's doing, said a small cold voice. *Yours are your own.*

She shut her eyes and put the voice in a column. Not now.

The shaking had stopped. That, she knew from experience, was not good. The body threw the cold off in shudders as long as it could afford them. When the shudders stopped, the heat for them had run out.

Fire does not warm lie-cold. She'd told that to a hundred crossers. She'd told them as one tells children not to lick the iron post, a small clean fact with a lesson in it. Only time or the loophole would do it, and time was a thing she did not have, and the loophole was a hand lying flat on the oats an arm's length away.

She did not ask for it.

Rohan had not offered. She would remember that, whatever it meant. Twice in one day he had stood at the edge of a thing and turned his own hand back. Each time he had given her the dignity of keeping her own skin. It might be love. It might be a man declining to open a door he did not want to see behind. It might be the pure cold courtesy of a warden who knew the law and would not lay hands where he'd been told not to.

You could ask him, she thought.

And he'd say he doesn't know. And that would be true too.

Her head had begun to swim. She put her back against the stone and made herself look at the slit again. The grey had gone to blue at the edges. Dusk, then. How many hours since the question? Six? She had thought it was three.

Count.

It was what she did. She'd counted goats and sacks and fingers and graves. She counted breaths now, because they were the one thing nobody had taken.

One. The oats smelled of mouse and damp.

Two. Iron lay cold against her forearm.

Three. A boot scraped. The sentry shifted on the other side of the door.

Four. Somewhere past the walls a child coughed, a long wet rattle, and was hushed.

Five.

She breathed out, and the fog of it was thinner than before. She watched it go.

Six. The brass badge pressed her ribs where she could still feel it.

Seven. There was a seam of warmth along her right side where Rohan's shoulder was, an arm's width off, not touching.

Eight.

Nine. They would come with torches after full dark. She tried to think what Nimmi would do, and could not; her thoughts slid like wet wool on a slope.

Ten.

Keep counting, said the guide in her, the one who had walked a hundred people over the Saddle in a whiteout, who knew that the thing that killed you was not the mountain but the moment you stopped naming steps. *Name them. Don't let go of the number.*

Eleven.

Twelve.

The light in the slit went from blue to black, and Meera counted on.

Chapter 27

Torches

Meera's counting stopped somewhere past four hundred.

Rohan had been listening to it for an hour. It was a whisper at the edge of hearing, the numbers falling further apart, like water from a failing roof. Four hundred and eleven. Then a long gap. He counted ten of his own and nothing came.

"Guide."

"Mm." It was the sound of someone answering from the bottom of a well.

He got up. The door was four paces off, inside the chain, and he went to it with the iron dragging at his belt and struck the planks with the flat of both cuffed hands.

"Sentry."

"What." The wet cough, thick and sour.

"The woman is dying of cold. Your lieutenant wants me breathing, and I am chained to her." All of it was true, and he said it in the voice he used for burial rolls. "Give me my coat and the brown pattu. If you're asked why, say a captain of wardens gave you an order and you chose to hear it."

A silence on the other side. A swallow from a flask. Then the bar scraped, the door opened a hand's width, and a bundle struck him in the chest. The door shut. The bar fell.

His coat. The borrowed pattu with its hole in the hem. And in the right pocket, where he had left them three days ago, his gloves.

He put them on with the cuffs in the way, working the leather over the iron one finger at a time. Then he went back across the oats and knelt behind her.

*

She sat against the wall with her chin on her chest and her good hand clamped over the bad one. He touched neither.

"I am going to move you," he said. "I will not touch your skin. If I do by accident, say so and I will stop."

No answer. He took that for leave.

He laid the coat over her shoulders and drew the brown pattu across it. He tucked the folds under her knees, then slid in behind her, his back to the stone, and pulled her gently between his knees until she lay along his chest with her head under his chin. Layer on layer, wool and leather and his own body. His gloved hands closed over the front of the coat, and he kept his mouth well off the bare nape of her neck.

Skin is the door, he thought. *Keep the door shut.*

The iron band was the worst of it. It lay around her left forearm over a hand she could no longer feel, and the metal had gone colder than the night. He tore a strip from the hem of the pattu, where the hole already was, and packed it between the iron and her sleeve with the tips of two gloved fingers. The band sat looser. She made a small noise, not a word.

Fire did not warm lie-cold. He knew that as well as he knew the Closing Law. Only time or a hand could draw it off. But everything around the lie-cold could be kept away from her: the draught under the door, the stone at her back, the plain cold that would finish the work the rope had begun. If he kept that out, the rope's share might stay a share. It might not kill her.

It was the only arithmetic he had.

"I will talk," he said. "You need not answer. You need only stay on this side of my voice."

For a long time there was only her breath, shallow, and shallower than it had been.

Then, thin and almost cross: "Talk about what?"

She asked. He closed his eyes. "True things. They cost nothing tonight."

*

"Dilan laughed like a goat sneezing," said Rohan. "It came before the joke did. He'd be laughing at a sentence he hadn't finished, and then he'd have to apologise to us for ruining it. He laughed in the middle of the oath at the post, in front of the post commander. I gave him a week of latrine duty. He sang the whole week."

A small movement against his chest. He could not tell if it was a shiver.

"That hymn. You've heard me say. He sang it every watch, because he thought it was a love song. He could not carry a tune in a bucket. It went up where it should have gone down and the men used to cover their ears. And he'd look hurt, and then do it again." He stopped. His throat had closed on the last word and he waited for it to open. "I miss it. I did not know that I would. I expected to miss the boy. I did not think I would miss the noise."

Her right hand moved inside the pattu and found his gloved one, and held on to the leather. He let it.

"Ila measures," he said, after a while. "My sister. When she was seven she paced our house in her bare feet and told my father the kitchen was a hand shorter than the builder promised. She was right. He never forgave her or the builder. If she were in this room she'd have your chain at two spans and four fingers, and she'd say so aloud and laugh so loudly the sentries would think it was at their expense."

"Which it would be," said Meera. It was a thread of a voice, and it was entirely hers.

"Which it would be." He felt his mouth move. "She names the mountains for people she likes. There is a ridge on the survey sheet she

calls Tamar's Shoulder, after a cook. I have asked what the cook did. She says, 'Fed me.'"

He told her about the old post room before it had a stove. He told her what his father said about the rope end, the one time he saw it: *Burn it, or carry it, but don't turn it into a kind of priest.* He told her he had carried it. He did not say *and now I have lost the man who stood at the other end of it,* because he did not know yet if that was true.

"My grandfather," he said, "went out in a storm to look to the cairns, for a party that was lost. They found him at the thaw. My father told it as a kind of prayer, and I never asked what it was like to find him." He breathed. "But he told me one thing once, when he'd been drinking. They found my grandfather's gloves lying on a flat stone beside him, one on the other, very neat. I've never worked out who he was tidying them for."

Silence. Then he heard it at the very bottom of the quiet, the way you hear a thread in a cloth: her breathing slowing.

"No," he said. "Meera. Stay."

He did the one thing he had not done since the Saddle. He hummed.

It was Dilan's hymn, and it came out badly. It rose where it should have fallen and cracked on the high note. He had no voice. He had never had one. But he knew the tune the way he knew his own boot size, and he went through the verse that began *keep me till the morning, love,* and into the next, flat, and getting flatter.

"That's," said Meera, against his collar, "flat."

"I know."

"It's a hymn." A pause, and a breath. "You can't help it. It's not even... it's not a love song, Rohan."

Rohan.

"He didn't know that," said Rohan, and went on humming.

*

It began in the ends of his fingers.

A pinch first, as when you carry cold iron too long. It was inside the gloves, in the pads of all ten fingers, a tightness that spoke of blood being asked to go somewhere it didn't want to go. He flexed them. The tips had a dull, wooden quality.

He had told no lie. He had touched no skin. This was neither of the two doors the cold used.

He went through the third.

I will not let you fall on this mountain.

He had said it in the Rope-Hut on a night of storm, with her mouth still warm against his, and the rope had hummed low and level under it. A promise made while bound. If it broke, it would strike him as a great lie struck. And Meera was slipping, and the slipping was a fall, and the rope, which had no opinion on how far Ranu stood from the mountain, was beginning to count.

The spirits' jurisdiction is wider than I'd like, he thought, dry as dust. It was the nearest he came to a joke that night.

He could end it. He had only to shuck a glove and lay his bare hand on her wrist. The cold would run up his arm, and he would know her lie in one breath, and its size, and the whole thing would be borne and ended.

And he would know. Not the truth, but that the truth was large.

He sat with his hands knotted over her coat and his fingertips going white in the leather, and he did not take off the glove.

"Four hundred and twelve," said Meera, very faintly. Then, a long time after: "Thirteen."

"Fourteen," said Rohan.

*

The first light came through the slit window at some hour past midnight, and it was orange.

He had not meant to look. The shutter was a ruin of warped slats that let a stripe of the lane through, and he held very still, because she

had gone limp against him again and he did not want to wake the thing in her that was holding on.

Torches.

They came down the lane in a slow file, soot and sparks, and spread along the marked houses like a string of beads being laid out. A man to each door. A man at each corner. He counted forty before he ran out of the stripe to count them in. Behind them came a handcart with straw on it, and a second, and men with their arms full of bundles, which they stacked against the planks, up to the sill, up to the lintel where the ash handprints showed pale.

Straw against the wall. Forty torches held steady. The red-moustached captain stood at the front with a paper in one hand, waiting for the hour.

Behind the walls, a child coughed. A woman said something low. Rohan could not hear the words and did not need to.

Seven houses. Forty-one sick. The ones who tended them. A boy named Kiran, on a pallet by a plank wall.

Thirty-two new graves, he thought, *and I signed the road shut that put them there.* He had not said it aloud yet. He had meant to say it before the assembly, with the speech in his coat. Now he sat in that coat, in a grain store, with a woman dying in his arms and a lane of torches, and nobody on earth to say it to.

In the middle of the lane, outside the third marked door, Nimmi stood.

She had come out with no lamp and no shawl. She stood on her own step with her arms at her sides, beside the lintel with its fresh grey hand, and she did not plead and she did not run. She looked at the line of torches the way she looked at a patient who would not be saved. She was counting them.

"Don't," he said, softly, to no one. "Go in."

She did not go in.

*

The horse came down from the upper road at a walk.

It was a tall grey, not hurried. Its rider wore a plain cloak the colour of old slate, with no bell stitched on the shoulder, and he sat the saddle like a man long used to it. He rode into the circle of torches and stopped between the captain and the first house. He had a grey beard cut close, and the hard, tired face of a man who has done a great many things that someone else wrote down.

"Captain," he said.

His voice was low. It carried the way a good officer's does, without being raised, across the whole frozen lane.

"Sir." The red moustache had straightened. "The order's under the regent's own hand, sir. Burn the cough. I have it here."

"I know whose hand." The grey beard did not look at the paper. He looked at the houses. He looked for a long time at the straw, and the lintels, and the small shape of a woman standing very still on a step. "How many are in them?"

"The sick, sir. And whoever's nursing."

"Children."

"Some, sir."

"Yes," said the rider. He spoke the single word as though he were setting it down on a table. Then, with no change at all: "Lower the torches."

A shuffle. The captain's mouth opened. "Sir, the order—"

"I will answer for the order. Lower them."

For a breath no one moved. Rohan had seen that breath at the edge of a hanging, the moment before a man steps up or does not.

The nearest soldier put his torch to the snow.

It hissed. Then the next, and the next, down the long file, a ragged hiss of fire going out, until the lane was full of grey smoke and the smell of wet pitch. Somewhere a man coughed. Somewhere another began dragging straw back into the carts, with the slow, grateful, ashamed motion of a man putting down a load he was glad not to have had to light.

The rider stayed on his horse. He did not look at the captain again. He looked once, directly, at the woman on the step. Nimmi looked back at him, long and level, as if she were learning his face by heart.

He turned the grey and walked it back up the lane, into the dark.

Nimmi watched the place where he had gone until the smoke covered it. Then she turned and went in, and the door closed.

*

Rohan found that his hands had closed hard on the coat.

It was not a pardon. It was a night. At dawn the captain might send for a different officer, or the paper might be carried to someone with a harder face, and the straw would come back out of the carts. He knew that. A stranger had spoken one word and a lane had put its fire out, and Rohan did not know his name.

A man obeyed his conscience in the regent's grey, he thought. *Here, in this valley. On this night.* He had not thought it possible, or had not wanted to believe it, and it undid something in his chest that he had not known was tied.

He had spent twelve years believing that if he bent the law once, nothing would hold. He had just watched a man bend a sealed order, and forty torches had held, and had gone out.

Meera lay against him with her breath a ribbon. The orange was gone from the slats. The lane was a smudge of smoke under a lid of stars.

He bent his head until his mouth was a finger's width from the wool of her hood, and not a hair nearer.

"Live, Guide," said Rohan. "I won't ask you anything else about that rope."

The rope on his wrist hummed. Low, and level, and steady as a held note.

He felt it all the way up his arm. He had made another contract with the mountain, and this one he knew he could keep. It cost him a man's name and a promise made over a rope end before eleven wardens. His

thumb found the clean-cut wool inside his coat and rested on it. He did not draw it out.

"Rohan," said Meera, from very far down.

"I'm here."

She said nothing more. But her good hand tightened on his glove, and the numbers came again, one by one, as faint as breath on glass, and by the time the stars paled behind the slats his fingertips had begun to ache with returning blood.

*

The blue came before dawn.

He had not slept. The sentry's cough stopped first, which was wrong, and then he heard nothing at all from the other side of the door. No boots. No flask.

A key slid into the bar's iron lock.

Rohan eased Meera against the wall, tucking the coat under her chin, and rose with the chain dragging at his belt. The bar lifted. The door swung out on the blue of the hour before the light, and the cold came in around the shape standing in it.

Asha. Onion-ochre canvas, her hair lank with the night, her face drawn and pale. A heavy iron key in one hand and a long knife in the other, the blade held low and loose.

She looked at Rohan. She looked past him at the shape in the corner, wrapped in a coat, and the sound of its breathing. Her eyes did not soften. They narrowed, as if she were adding up a column she did not want to add.

Behind him, Meera's boot scraped the oats. She was trying to stand.

"Don't," said Asha, "do that, Guide. Not yet." She did not step inside. She held the key where Rohan could see it, and she held the knife where he could see that as well.

"Price first."

Chapter 28

Asha's Price

"Price first," said Asha, and she did not move out of the doorway.

Meera got her back flat to the wall and stood, because she would not bargain from the floor. The stone slid under her shoulder blades. The room tilted, righted itself, and tilted again. Rohan's coat hung off her like a tent.

"You have a key," she said. "That's a good start."

"It's a start." Asha glanced at the chain between them, then at the red rope under it. "A crown pardon is what I came over the Saddle for. A paper with my crew's names on it." She said it flatly, as if reading a bill. "I stood in the lane last night with my four. I watched the torches go down the line."

"We saw them," said Rohan.

"Then you saw a man with a paper tell forty men to burn children." Asha's knife hand did not shift. "I took Varun's silver because he paid on the nail and never haggled. I thought that was manners. It's just a man who'll never need to pay the full bill." She breathed out, and it smoked. "That pardon is the same noose with a nicer rope. When he's done with the seal, he's done with me."

"So you don't want the pardon," said Meera.

"I want my crew alive. Lalit, the ochre four, the girl on my second rope." She ticked them off on the fingers of the knife hand without lowering the blade. "And I want my name out of his books. He writes

every payment in a tidy hand, because he believes in tidy hands. While my name's in it, I'm a hired knife for a traitor. I want it somewhere else."

"A warden can't pardon," Rohan said. "I'll not say otherwise to you."

"I know the law."

"Only the queen can. What I can do is stand before the assembly and say that you came in the dark, with a key, against the man who paid you. That is true. I will say it as loudly as I'm able." He kept his voice level and his hands still. "I can't promise what the assembly does with it."

Asha studied him. "By my grandmother's left boot. You've got a face that doesn't know how to say a fine thing it can't back."

"No."

"That's rare. I'd charge extra for it, if it weren't so inconvenient." She looked at Meera. "And you?"

She wants a pledge, Meera thought, *and I am bound.* A promise made on the rope and broken would strike her like a great lie, and she had one good hand left to spend. She would not say a word she could not stand behind.

So she did the other thing.

She put her right hand inside her shirt, past the brass badge, and drew out the count. The wax cover was warm from her skin. It had survived the chain, the iron band and the sentries, who had never thought to look where a woman kept a thing she loved. She opened it on her knee and found the page by feel.

She tore it out along the stitching, with her teeth and one hand.

"Dates," she said. "The middleman. Ten winters of drops, the day and the hour, in my hand. Crate marks: a bell scored through the stamp, then the stamp scraped off with a spoon, and the scrape is always a left-handed one. Where I paid, how much, what I was told when I asked who sold." She held it out. "It's a ledger. It's the only kind of evidence I've got."

Asha did not take it. "That's your neck."

"It's his." Meera turned the count over and set her thumbnail to the spine, where the binding thread ran in tight little stitches. She had

bound the book herself, ten winters back, and stitched the button under the binding the morning the wardens came, so that nobody would find it unless he meant to take the book apart. She picked the first stitch loose. Then the second. The thread was waxed and fought her. She worked the third out with a tooth and the point of her nail, while Asha watched and Rohan did not breathe, and the binding gaped like a mouth. A little thing slid out onto her palm. Brass, domed, plain, with a stiff new shank.

"And this. The crate man left it when I paid. His courier was meant to carry the twin. I never saw the courier. I never saw the man."

Asha stared at it. Her whole face changed.

"I did," she said slowly. "I watched Varun thumb a button like that on his coat the day he hired me. New among the pewter ones. He said a pedlar sold it to him."

"Say it plain," said Rohan. His voice had dropped.

Asha said it plain, to him, not to Meera. "Varun paid me. Four silver a week and a promise of a paper. And the lowland man who sold your guide her bark was his runner, a thin one with a bad left foot who drank in the salt-road inns. I've seen the two of them at the same table." She took the page then, folded it twice and slid it into her sleeve. "That's the bill. A name for a name."

"Take the button too."

"No." Asha pushed Meera's hand closed over it. "You'll want it in front of a regent." The knife went into her belt. She fitted the iron key to the cuff on Rohan's wrist, and it turned with a click Meera felt in her teeth.

*

Both sentries sat against the lockhouse wall with their hands tied in three nested loops, snug as a bird's nest. The wet cough had a strip of ochre canvas in his mouth and the resigned look of a man who'd rather be tied than asked.

Meera stopped. She knew that knot. Three loops, one inside the next. It had hung in the juniper outside the Rope-Hut with sattu and apricots in it. It was carved on the cairn's inner face, two hands and a rope. *Same as cairn,* she had written in the count, and had not known why she wrote it.

"Asha," she said. "That knot. It's the one on the—"

Asha's glare came round, sharp as a nail. Not here, it said, and not before him. Meera shut her mouth. Silence was free. She put the question in a column and left it there.

Lalit stood at the corner with his spyglass hanging from his neck and a pony's lead in his fist. A heap of taken gear lay by the wall. He dragged her pack and her knife out of it with his boot, and held them out. He did not look at the captain of wardens. He looked at Meera, once, and then at the ground.

"The lane's quiet," he said. "The red moustache is asleep in a chair. The lieutenant went up the Garh road at midnight, with his twenty. He thinks the village will be ash by morning. He wanted to be seen far away."

Asha's key took the forearm band off in two turns. The iron slid from Meera's arm with a clank, and the torn strip of pattu fell out with it. Cold air touched her sleeve, and she could not feel it on the left hand at all.

She put the hand in her coat and said nothing. She slung the pack on her good shoulder, and the knife went into her boot.

"There's a door I want," she said. "Nimmi's house. The woodpile behind the goat shed."

Rohan said nothing. He had never asked her where she put it.

*

Nimmi opened before she knocked.

She stood in her doorway in her night shawl, grey hair loose, with a stub of candle. She looked at the four of them one at a time, the way she

looked down a bed of the sick. Then she stood aside, and the smell of boiling walnut leaf came out into the cold.

"You'll not find it in the logs," she said. "Pinku saw you from the tree, when you hid it behind the shed. He told me at dusk that the lady had left a blue egg in the woodpile." She sniffed. "Wood is for burning. A shed can come down on it. I took it out last night, after the torches came down the lane, and I put it where nobody burns anything."

The chulha corner. The big clay pot sat on its stones with a cloth over the lip, the dark tea steaming gently. Meera crossed the room and lifted the cloth.

Nothing but leaves and brown water. She shoved her right sleeve to the elbow and reached in anyway.

The heat bit. Her fingers closed on a cord, and then on cold stone, thumb-joint long and smooth, with a shoulder where the cord was threaded. She drew it up streaming. Lapis, the blue of deep ice, cut with a goat finer than any coin's.

"Nobody lifts a lid on a healer's tea," said Nimmi. "They'd think it was a cure."

"It is," Meera said, and heard the shake in it.

She turned. Rohan stood in the doorway with his gloves in his hand. At the shed he had faced the wall and counted to a hundred and sixty, and he had kept his word and never asked where. She let the stone hang from her fingers by its cord, dripping, and held it out at the full length of her arm.

"You'll want that dry," she said. "And on your own neck."

He took the cord by the very end, with two fingers, and the wet stone swung between them. His hand did not come near her skin. He had kept it away on purpose, and she saw that he had, and saw that he saw her see it. The cord stayed taut between their hands a breath longer than the stone needed.

Then he let her go. She took the cord back to tie it herself, in the warden's double hitch, the knot she had once untied and made again.

The left hand lay in her lap, loose, with nothing to give the cord. The right alone made a mess of it.

"Here," said Rohan quietly.

He reset it himself. Two turns round the standing part. A tuck. A locking half-turn. He had it done before she could find a way to be cross about it.

Nimmi was already looking at the coat sleeve, at the way the left arm hung. "Sit," she said. "Lamp."

Pinku held it. He was in his nightshirt with a walnut tied up in red thread around his neck, and he looked at Meera's hand with great interest and no fear. Nimmi eased the glove off.

Meera watched the child's face. He wrinkled his nose.

"Ring finger," said Nimmi in the voice of someone naming a price. "Little finger. No colour. No feeling. Waxy to the second joint, grey-blue at the root, and the skin has begun to loosen like a cooked onion. Middle finger has blood in it. It'll live." She laid the hand back on Meera's knee as if returning a book. "Those two are dead. They'll not be anything else."

"I know."

"Not off today. You'd bleed to feed a Fair. You'll have the hand for the pen, and the knot, and whatever else you're about." Nimmi sat back on her heels. "After the Fair. A day after, no more. If the rot goes up into the wrist, it takes the arm, and I've no redbark for that and no wish to learn."

After the Fair. Two fingers. A day.

She raised her eyes then, and met Rohan's.

He stood very still, looking at the hand. He had asked her one question in the dark, and she had answered it, and he was looking at the size of that answer. She watched him work the sum. She watched it go all the way down and come up with nothing he could say.

He did not ask. His mouth worked, once, and shut.

"Later," said Meera.

"Whenever you like," said Rohan. His voice was rough. "It will keep."

*

Kiran was on his feet in the back room, holding the plank wall.

He had put on a coat that was not his and tied his boots with the care of a man not sure he could bend again. His face was the colour of wet ash, and the torn ear stood out against it like a sail rag. His eyes were bright and clear and, for the first time in days, quite sane.

"Don't," said Meera. "Sit."

"Didi." He did not sit. "You're going to Garh Neshar, with him, with the stone, and you're going to stand in front of the regent's bell." He glanced at Rohan and away. "I'm coming."

"You're a day from a fever."

"I'm nine hours from a fever. Nimmi counted. Tell her."

Nimmi sniffed. "He's had two courses and a day of sleep. He'll not die of walking, if somebody puts him on a pony."

"We have one," said Asha from the door, in the tone of a woman noting a debt. "Salt-road pony, ugly and stubborn. It will take a boy." She looked at Rohan and Meera and the stone at Rohan's neck. "The lane road's watched. The salt road isn't. It goes up the back of the walnut terraces and over two spurs and down the dry side of Garh Neshar, and it hasn't seen a warden in fifty winters." She tilted her head. "You'll like it, Captain. It's illegal in nine places."

"I'll write them down," said Rohan.

Asha snorted. It might have been a laugh.

*

They left by the back of the house while the blue was still thin. Pinku stood in the doorway beside his grandmother and did not wave. He held up the walnut on its red thread instead, as though it were a message. Meera held up her good hand.

The salt road climbed behind the terraces, through bare walnut trees and out onto frozen scree, and the first sun made the far peaks the colour of apricot skin. Asha went ahead with her four. The pony came after

with Kiran on it, wrapped, swaying and talking, because he could not bear a silence. Meera walked next to the rope. Walking made the cold in the hand into something she could ignore.

By noon she could not.

Her pack sat on her shoulders like a second person. Ten winters of habit said not to take it off. A guide did not set her load down in front of a client. The load was the point of her.

The slope steepened. She stopped on a stone, breath going in and out too fast, and put her good hand on her knee.

"Guide," said Rohan.

He had come up beside her. He wasn't looking at her face, which she was glad of. He was looking at the pack, and at the way the strap had cut a groove into the shoulder of his borrowed coat.

"May I—"

He stopped. She watched him hear it. His mouth closed on the word as if on a hot coal, and he stood a moment with a muscle working in his cheek. He had promised her no more questions about that rope, and he meant to give the promise a wide berth. Then he said it again, flat and plain, the way a man gives an order to himself.

"Give it here. I'll take the left strap."

She opened her mouth. She had the answer ready, the dry one she had given everyone for ten winters. *It's fine. I've got it.* It had never once been a lie.

It was not true now. She could feel the rope against her wrist, waiting.

"You stopped," she said instead.

"Nearly a question. I thought it best to be nothing at all."

"Nearly's free." She took her arm out of one strap, and the pack came off her shoulder with a sigh of leather. "The oilcloth roll's at the bottom. Nothing in it now. The count's in my shirt. The rest is rope and a pot and sattu for two." She held it out on her good hand. "It's heavy on the left. Mind the left."

He took it. He did not make a speech. He settled it high on his back, over ribs that were still not whole, tested it with one shrug, and walked on at her side.

It was the smallest thing she had ever handed anyone. She walked light, for the first time in years, and her whole body knew the difference and did not know what to do with it.

"Thank you," said Rohan, after a while.

"Don't. I'll start charging."

"I will pay it." He did not smile, but the line of his mouth was warm. "In sattu."

*

The sun slid behind the second spur. The shadows went blue and stretched out ahead of them, and the pony's bells rang thin on the cold.

Asha called the halt in a hollow below a lip of rock, out of sight of the road. Her four made a fire the size of two fists, juniper, and nobody complained. Meera sat on a flat stone with the count open on her knee, its spine gaping, and the fire on her right side. Rohan set the pack beside her, and it took him longer than it should have to straighten.

Kiran got off the pony by himself. He stood holding the saddle, swaying. Then he let go and crossed the snow to where Rohan stood with the lapis stone at his chest, and stopped an arm's length away.

He didn't joke. He did not call anyone Captain-ji. Meera watched him square his shoulders and close his hand on a place in his coat where a badge had lain until his sister took it.

She started to rise. "Kiran—"

"No, Didi." He did not look at her. "You paid for this. Let me."

He looked at Rohan. His voice shook once and held.

"Captain," said Kiran. "I have to tell you what happened on that rope."

Chapter 29

The Cut End

Kiran did not look at his sister, or at Asha's four standing around the fire like people pretending not to listen. He looked at the lapis stone on Rohan's chest, because it was easier than looking at his face.

"I went up the Saddle alone that night," he said. "Four loads of salt for the Dev people. I knew the line. Then I didn't."

Rohan said nothing. He had learned in twelve years of questioning men that a silence left open does more than a question.

"I lost it inside the hour. I turned back for the waystone with my hands gone, and your warden was there." Kiran swallowed. "He'd followed my tracks. Alone, in that. He had his rope out already. He looked at me and I thought, this is where I hang. And he said, 'Wrists, then. Names.'"

The fire popped. Somebody shifted a boot.

"He bound us at the stone. Both names, the third bend for the destination. He knew what that was, a warden roped to a smuggler. He said, 'I'll hand you to the road and we'll never have met.'" Kiran's mouth twisted. "Then he walked me down the line, and he sang."

Rohan's hands were very still at his sides.

"All the way. Wrong, every note. I told him to shut up. He said it was keeping us off the ice." Kiran laughed, one cracked breath of it, and stopped. "The shelf above the third bend went. It took us both down onto the road ice. The dead weight of it was dragging him toward the

drop, and the rope was dragging me after. I saw him take out the knife. I screamed at him not to."

"What did he say?" said Rohan. His voice came out level, and he did not know where he had found it.

"'Sorry about the hymn.'" Kiran said it flat, the way a man says a thing he has said to himself a thousand times in the dark. "Then the rope went slack in my hands, and he wasn't on the end of it. I lay on that road till light. My ear was frozen to the glaze. In the morning I found this by my hand."

He held out his palm toward Meera, without turning.

She was already drawing it from inside her coat. The brass had gone brown with age and wear, palm-wide, the queen's goat stamped on it, a dent in the rim. She laid it in her brother's hand. Kiran closed his fingers once, hard, then crossed the last arm's length of snow and put it in Rohan's.

It was warm from two bodies. Rohan turned it over. On the back, scratched with a nail point, were three letters. *DIL.*

He did not say the name. He found he could not, and neither had Kiran, in all that telling. *Your warden. Him.* It was the only way the boy could have held it up without dropping it.

*

Meera had handed his coat back at the halt. Rohan opened it.

The rope end lay where it had lain for two winters, rolled and tied with a scrap of its own cord. He undid the tie with his thumb. One end was whipped in black thread, small and neat. Dilan's work, the only knot he had ever done well.

He turned the other end to the light.

A rope that parts under strain frays like a broom. It leaves a beard of fibre a hand long. This had no beard. The strands lay flat and slanted, sliced through in one stroke by a good blade, from the near side.

He had read it the first night. He had read it every night since. And every morning he had told himself that ice could do this, and rock could

do this, and a smuggler could have done it to run. Because if a smuggler had cut it, Dilan was abandoned, and Rohan knew whom to hang. If Dilan had cut it himself, there was no one to hang at all.

He had sworn before eleven wardens, with this in his fist, to find the man at the far end. He had found him. He was a boy in a borrowed coat with half an ear, who had lain on the ice until dawn, and who had carried a dead man's badge against his skin for two winters because he had nowhere to put it down.

"He cut it," said Rohan. "I knew that."

Kiran's face went white. "Captain—"

"I have known it since the first night, and I have never once let myself say it." He closed his hand around the wool. "It is a clean cut. Nothing else on this mountain cuts like that. He chose it. He chose you, and I have spent two winters hunting you for his sake and calling it loyalty."

Nobody breathed. Then he turned his head.

Meera had not moved from the flat stone. Her face was grey with the day's walking, her right hand open on the count, her left held against her ribs inside the coat. She watched him the way she had watched the ice shelf on the Saddle, to see where it would give.

Was Kiran on Dilan's rope?

No.

He looked at the coat sleeve, at the way it hung. He knew the size of that lie. He had watched Nimmi name it by lamplight, two fingers, grey-blue at the root, and he had done the sum standing in a doorway and come up with nothing to say. A lie that large was paid for only by a truth that would have changed what he did.

She had stood in a lockhouse with the cold climbing her arm and refused him this, to the bone, so that he would never stand where he stood now with a rope end in his hand and a boy in front of him.

"Meera," he said.

"Yes." She did not look away. "I lied to you."

The rope on his wrist stayed warm and even. It was a true answer, and the mountain agreed.

*

"Well," said Asha, from the fire, "the Captain's face is doing something."

She had her knife out, but only to cut a strip of smoked goat. Lalit had put down his spyglass. The girl from the second rope watched Rohan with her mouth a little open.

Kiran drew himself up. He looked like a man walking to a post. "Do it, then," he said. "I was on the rope. I crossed the closed pass. It's all true and it's all mine. Not her. She said no to you for me, so put it on me."

There, thought Rohan, with great clarity. *There is the law.*

He knew it to the letter. A known crosser, taken or not. A warden who let one walk was a harbourer, and hanged by the same rope. For twelve years he had believed that if he bent it once, nothing would hold. He had watched a stranger on a grey horse bend a sealed order, and forty torches had gone out. The law had not fallen down in that lane. A night had held.

He put the rope end and the badge into his coat, side by side, and closed the flap over them.

"No," he said.

"Captain, the—"

"I know what it says. I have it by heart." He did not raise his voice. He turned so that Asha's four could see his face. "You are witnesses, all of you. I know of an unlawful crossing, and I do not take the man who made it. By the letter, that makes me a harbourer. Let it be said so. If anyone asks who let him walk, it was me."

His hands, he noticed, hung open at his sides. He did not know when he had unclenched them.

Asha chewed her goat. "I'll have that cut on a tooth," she said at last. "Nobody will ask. Who'd dare?"

Kiran stood very straight, and then not at all. He sat down hard in the snow, as though the string had been cut, and put his face in his hands. His shoulders shook. No sound came out.

Asha stepped over, gripped him by the collar, and hauled him up. "Fire. Eat. You look like a bad candle." She steered him off with her shoulder under his arm. He went, and at the edge of the light he looked back.

"I'm sorry," Kiran said. "It isn't enough."

"It isn't meant to be." Rohan found the words were already in his mouth. "He decided you were worth it. I would thank you not to argue the point with him."

*

They walked a little way along the ridge to where the rock made a seat, eight spans from the fire, as far as the rope allowed. The stars were coming out over the second spur. The cold was the clean kind.

Meera sat. She did not speak. For once she was not counting.

"I did not reach," said Rohan.

Her head came round.

"In the lockhouse. You said no, and the cold took your hand, and I sat there with a glove between us and told myself it was courtesy." He kept his eyes on the dark ridge. "It was not courtesy. I could have taken your hand and learned that you lied. I did not, because I was afraid of what I would have to do if I knew. I have a law and a writ and a sworn word, and I could see exactly where the knowing would lead me. So I chose not to see. You paid for it, and I let you."

"Rohan."

"You lied to protect your brother from me." He said it plainly, and it was not an accusation. "A reasonable person would. I had hunted that rope end for two winters. I had a name for the man at the far end of it, and none for what I meant to do to him. That is on my law, not your hand."

She was quiet for several breaths.

"It's my hand all the same," she said. "It lied." Her good fingers worked at the edge of the count. "I decided what you'd do with the truth

before I gave you the chance to do it. I'd have been wrong, and I didn't let you prove me wrong. That's mine."

"Then both are true."

"Both." She opened the count on her knee. By the last light she wrote, in her small exact hand, and tilted the page so he could read it. *R. did not reach. M. lied. Both stand.*

He read it twice. It was the most serious document he had ever been shown.

"May I?" he said, and nodded at her left sleeve.

She hesitated. Then she drew the gloved hand out of her coat and laid it across his palm. It was loose, and weighed nothing, and it did not feel him. He held it the way you hold something that has been carried a long way.

"The Fair," he said, after a time, because there were things that could wait and things that could not. "At first light we reach the dry side of Garh Neshar. By midmorning the assembly is on the meadow, and the herald asks if any contest the regent's claim. I do. I press the seal."

"And I stand up after you," said Meera, "and give them the count. Ten winters of drops. The crate marks, the scrape of the spoon. The button." Her voice was steady. "Asha says what she saw at Varun's table."

"It will have your name on it."

"I know what it will have on it."

"They will hear it from your mouth in front of the bell." He turned the dead hand over, gently, in his. "I will not move."

"I know." She almost smiled. "I've watched you not move. You're very good at it."

"I will also speak," said Rohan. "Of the road. Thirty-two new graves above Ranu, and the blockade that put them there. I signed it. I have the speech in my coat and not the line it needs, and I think I have it now."

Her eyes went to the coat, to the place where his writ lay, orders folded in cream paper. The thaw, and the Salt Fox, and a delivery. Neither of them said so. Silence was free, and tonight it was all either of them could afford.

"Tomorrow," Meera said instead.

"Tomorrow," said Rohan, and did not let go of her hand.

*

They walked the last of the night by the faint blue of the winter line, which ran beside the salt road as if the mountain had decided to be polite. Kiran slept on the pony. Asha's four went ahead and behind in a loose ring.

Dawn came up gold on the far peaks and grey in the valley. They crested the second spur as the light reached the bottom of the world, and there lay Garh Neshar below them, a heap of grey stone with a smoke of cookfires about it, and the white loop of the frozen river beyond. A long pale meadow lay along the ice. Small figures were already moving on it. Drums began, very far down, a slow pulse.

Day twenty. He had ridden into Kothi Shilak with a warrant and a ruler, and a plan that had no place in it for a woman with a red rope.

Somewhere in that yard, his sister was pacing the north wall and calling it two spans out of true. He found that thought warmer than the sun.

Then the bell spoke.

It rolled up the valley, a long brass note that did not so much sound as arrive. He felt it in his back teeth first, then in the bones of his jaw, then in the stones under his boots. Asha swore, in an oath he did not recognise. The pony flicked its ears. The note ran on and on, until the whole mountain seemed to hum with it.

"That's the call to assembly," said Lalit quietly.

"Yes," said Rohan.

Meera had come up beside him. Her hair was stiff with frost and her left hand was tucked in her coat, and she was looking down at the meadow as she looked at every crossing, counting the ways it could go wrong. He knew the look now. He would have known it in a crowd of a thousand.

"Rohan," she said. "How many do you suppose?"

"Several hundred. Fewer who will listen."

"Enough," said Meera.

He took the first step downhill. The rope drew taut between them, eight spans of red wool, and she came with him.

Chapter 30

Watch My Hands

The drums were already going when they came down onto the meadow, and Pritam already had his hand raised.

He stood on the dais at the foot of the river ice in a coat the colour of good butter. Barley roasted on a hundred braziers and the smoke went straight up into a white sky. Several hundred people stood on the frozen grass in their best pattus. Beside the regent stood a lean man with a prince's circlet, looking like someone told to sit who was thinking of standing. Kunal, the herald had called him. One pace behind Pritam, hands folded, stood Varun.

He had shaved. The pewter buttons on his coat shone, and the brass one among them shone more.

"The claim stands read," said the herald, a thin man with a voice made for brass. "Does any here contest the regent's investiture?"

Meera stood at the back of the crowd with her good hand locked on the rope. Rohan stood at her side with the lapis stone outside his coat. She counted the soldiers around the dais. Forty. A man in a plain slate cloak, grey in the beard, stood off by himself near the front.

"Now, then," Meera said, very low.

"Now," said Rohan, and walked into the crowd.

It parted for him. The warden's grey was gone, but the walk was the same, straight as a plumb line. She went with him, eight spans of red wool between them, and people stared at the rope and then at the stone.

"I contest," said Rohan, and the drums stopped as if someone had put a hand on them.

*

Pritam smiled. It was the smile of a man who had counted everything. "Captain Rohan. We heard you were lost on the Saddle."

"I was delayed." Rohan reached the foot of the dais. A woman near the front gave a short, startled sound, and Meera knew the shape of the face before she knew why. Same jaw. Same stillness. The woman wore a surveyor's cord at her belt and looked ready to run at him and measure him at once.

Ila. Meera put her in a column for later.

"Seize him," said Varun pleasantly. "That man is a seal-thief. He broke custody at Ranu yesterday with a smuggler's help."

No one moved. Rohan took a flat tin from his coat and opened it. Inside lay a wafer of wax the dark red-brown of old wine, and folded beneath it a single line of paper.

"This is the queen's wax," he said. "She mixed it herself, with her own blood, so that no man could say another hand sealed for her." He held the paper out to the herald. "And this is her line, in her hand. Read it."

The herald took it. His lips moved. His face went slack, then careful.

"'Pritam holds Neshar for us and not for himself. We so say.'" His voice cracked on the last word. "Signed Sarala."

"She is not dying," said Rohan. "She is ill, and she sent me."

He set the wafer on the herald's book and warmed it a moment in his palm. Then he pressed the lapis goat into the wax with the heel of his hand, and held it there for the length of a slow breath.

When he lifted it, the goat stood clean in the dark wax, finer than any coin's. Beside it, from a vein of the mix, a thread of red ran in the shape of a thumb. People near enough to see made the sign against evil. No one laughed.

"The regent's claim is revoked," the herald said, as if reading a bill. "By the queen's own seal."

Pritam did not move. Only his smile did, and it went like ice on a river.

*

"That seal was stolen!" Varun's voice rose with a fine, injured warmth. "My captain has been bought. I have the proof. He travelled these twenty days with the Salt Fox's own guide, chained to her by his own choice, sharing her fire and her bread. Harbouring, by the law he swore to keep!"

Here, Meera thought. *Here is the door.*

For ten winters she had walked through doors that opened on a drop and a hanging tree. She had never once put her hand on one that opened on the people who judged it. Her hands were cold. Not lie-cold. Plain fear.

She could stay a face at the back of the crowd and let Rohan speak for them both. Or she could say the one true thing she owned, and every soul on the meadow would hold it.

Instead she stepped out beside him and went to the herald's book.

The count came from her shirt, its wax cover warm, and she laid it open on the page. Then she turned to the meadow, and her voice carried farther than she had meant.

"He did travel with the Salt Fox. She is here. My name is Meera of Kothi Shilak, called the Salt Fox." The dead fingers of her left hand did not shake, because they could not. "I have crossed the Shilak closed, ten winters running. I have carried two hundred and six people over it, and I wrote down every one." The crowd made a sound like wind in stacked stones. "That is a hanging, by your law. I put it in the crown's record, under my own name, so that no one needs to guess."

"Seize her!" said Varun.

Two soldiers from the dais came down fast, and this time they did not stop. One took her good arm and one the dead one, and the grip on her left she felt only as a pull on her shoulder. The herald's pen hung over the page. His eyes went to the dais, the book, her. Then he wrote, slowly,

as if the ink were heavy: *Meera of Kothi Shilak, called the Salt Fox. Held pending the queen's judgement.*

Rohan did not move. He stood with his hands open at his sides and the rope drawn straight between them, and the whole of him was a man holding a promise by the throat.

"Take her to the lockhouse," said Varun. "Now."

"Hold," said the prince, quite softly.

The two soldiers did not take a step. They did not let go either. Meera hung between their hands and kept talking, because the hands might be gone in a breath and the words would not.

"Ten winters of crates. Every drop, in my hand. The stamp scraped off with a spoon by a left-handed man." She found her breath. "My crew is written by marks, not names. They stay out of it. I stand in for them. The redbark that fed my trade was crown stores, stolen. The man who sold it to me through a runner is standing behind the regent in a clean coat."

Varun laughed. It came a half beat late. "A smuggler's ledger. My lords, the woman admits to hanging crimes."

"She does," said a woman's flat voice from the crowd. "I'm one too."

Asha came out with Lalit at her heel, her knife left in its belt. She did not look at the dais. She looked straight at Varun, and she spoke as if reading prices.

"Varun paid me four silver a week to track the seal over the Saddle. I have the weeks written, and the runner's name, a thin man with a bad left foot." She drew a folded page from her sleeve and laid it beside the count. "That's the guide's page back, torn from her book, and every date on it matches mine. I watched him share a table with that coat in a salt-road inn." She nodded at the buttons. "And I watched him thumb the new brass one on his chest the day he hired me."

Meera could not reach the binding. "Rohan," she said. "The spine."

He moved then, three steps, the only ones he allowed himself, and drew the little domed button from the count's binding. He laid it on the herald's book.

"His courier carried the twin," said Meera. "The crate man left me this. The rule was, no twin, no crate."

The herald studied the button, then Varun's coat. A clerk was sent down, unwilling and quick, and held the two close together: same dome, same stiff shank, same nick filed in the rim. He said nothing at all. He lifted his eyes to the dais and nodded once.

In the quiet that followed, Meera heard Varun breathe.

*

"The assembly will hear one thing more," said Rohan.

He spoke not to Varun but to the meadow, to the hill people in their grey and brown and the traders of the lower road. He had not planned the voice, she thought. It came out of him plain and slow, the voice of a man saying the bad number.

"Thirty-two graves stand above Ranu that were not there at first snow. I counted thirty-one, and I held the rope while the last was dug. They were dying of a cough that redbark cures, and redbark could not cross, because the Closing Law shut the pass and I signed the order that kept it shut." His hands were open. "I enforced that law twelve winters. I hanged two men under it. One was seventeen, and carried salt to his mother. I thought a rule that bends once breaks. I say to you now, in front of the bell, it is the rule that broke, and they paid for it."

No one coughed. No one shifted. Far at the back, a woman began to cry in the flat way of someone who had been waiting a long time to be told.

"I am a warden of this crown," said Rohan. "I say the blockade killed them, and I say my name is on it."

Meera did not look at him. She could not. She stood between the two soldiers and held on to nothing.

The grey-bearded man in the slate cloak moved first. He unbuckled his sword belt, unhurried, and laid it on the grass. Then he stood beside it with his hands empty, as if he had settled something with himself in a lane two nights before. Everyone near him took a step back.

The hill council men, who had been standing in the crowd as ordinary as sheep, closed on the dais. Pritam did not look at them. He turned to the officer of the forty, and when he spoke his voice stayed smooth.

"Officer. The herald reads under a stranger's hand, with a thief's tin and a smuggler's confession. Hold him until the matter is tried." Two more soldiers stepped toward the herald. A spear came down level. "And let the assembly remember that Neshar owes me eleven hundred measures of winter grain, entered and unpaid. Take me, and who feeds the valley till the thaw?"

The herald stood very straight with the point a hand from his throat and his pen still in his fingers.

"Eleven hundred measures," said Rohan. "Those are the crown's measures, and each one carries your store-bell. You held them back all through the closing and sold them to Ranu at famine price. Neshar does not owe you that grain. It has paid for it twice."

For a moment the meadow was silent. Then a heavy man in hill grey, one of the council, said loudly, "I paid for a sack myself. Four times the autumn price. Ask me for the bell on it."

"I paid," said another voice. "And another. And another."

The prince said nothing, and let that stand. The officer looked at the sword belt on the grass. His eyes went to the herald's throat, to the guide held by two of his own men, to the faces of the hill men closing in. His spear wavered. The point went up, then down, and he gave one order at last, which was to the pair at Meera's arms. They let go. The soldiers at the herald stepped back. Two men took Pritam by the arms, politely, as one might take an elder across ice. He began a sentence about a count of grain, and it died there.

Varun ran. He got three paces toward the river before Lalit's boot found the back of his knee and Asha sat on his chest with a calm face, like a woman at market.

"I'll want that button back," she said, "when you've done with it."

Meera stood rubbing her good arm. The herald lifted the count in both hands and wrote the number of it on a clean page, with her name

beside it. The entry above it did not change. *Held pending the queen's judgement.* The prince, coming down from the dais, stopped before her.

"It is entered," he said. "Whatever the law does with it, the assembly heard it spoken, and it will not be unsaid." He glanced at the count, then at her, with the expression of a man deciding which of two secrets to keep. "That was well done, Meera of Kothi Shilak."

*

Afterwards the meadow was drums again and barley and people who would not stop touching her sleeve. Ila crossed the grass at a run and seized her brother's face in both hands. "You are eight days late and a belt-hole thinner," she said. "You wrote before the snow." She laughed loudly and wiped her eyes on her cord. Kiran, grey and upright on a pony, was being fed soup by a stranger.

Meera stood at the end of the rope with her legs going soft under her. She did not slip away. She could not have, and she did not want to. She took the red wool in her good hand and pulled once, long.

Come.

Rohan was in the middle of a word to his sister. He stopped. "Ila," he said, "forgive me," and left her with her mouth open and her hands in the air. He came across the grass, and the people between them made a lane.

They walked together along the river ice to the lee of a half-fallen wall. She sat down on it. Her legs were shaking. She let them.

He stood a little way off, and she saw he had taken off his gloves.

"I said I wouldn't move," said Rohan.

"You didn't."

"I did not move." He came nearer. His face was open in a way she had not seen before, the way a door is open when someone has taken the bar down and thrown it in the river. "Meera."

"I used to think the law was only ever a noose for people like us," she said. "It's a rope. It depends who ties it."

"Then we will tie it well."

"Rohan."

"I love you."

It was no soft thing. He said it as he said everything, the full sentence, the exact number. The rope on her wrist lay quiet. No ring came from the stones, for there were none to ring, and the wind in the dead grass did not rise.

He held up his hands. Bare. Wide-fingered. The cold air lay on them like an accusation.

"Watch my hands," he said.

She watched. Ten seconds. Twenty. His fingertips stayed the colour of living skin. There was no white at the nail, no grey creeping at the knuckle. They were only a man's hands, a little scarred, steady in the winter light.

"Warm," she said, and her voice failed in the middle of the word.

"Yes."

"Rohan." She took off her right glove with her teeth. Her left she could not feel, but she took that glove off too, the loose dead hand, and held both up in the white air beside his. "I love you. I think I have since you climbed out of that gully on my count with your ribs screaming."

She watched her own fingers. All eight that were still hers. She watched them in the wind with the whole of her attention, as she had once watched the Saddle for a crack.

They stayed warm. The three living fingers of the left. The five on the right. Pink and aching and warm.

He made a sound she had not heard before and closed both his hands round hers.

*

Ila had found them a room in the guest-house of Garh Neshar, two floors up, with a bed and a lamp and a window onto the river. The latch was sprung and nobody mended it. Meera had left the door standing open. She had never in her life sat in a room with the door open for anyone's sake but a customer's.

"I'm not asking leave of anybody," she said.

"I would not dream," said Rohan, and kissed her.

It was slower than the kiss in the Rope-Hut, which had cost a promise. This one cost nothing, and the lack of price made her dizzy. He undid her coat with great care, as though it were a seal. When he came to the left sleeve he stopped, and looked at her, and waited.

"Yes," she said.

He took the hand in both of his and bent and put his mouth against the back of it, above the dead fingers, where the skin still had a pulse. She felt that. She felt the hum of his breath on the living part of her, and she closed her eyes.

After that there was not much talk. His ribs, not whole yet, made him laugh at himself, and she took the lead, which suited them both. She took her time. He let her. She learned that he said her name when he was close to something, low and ragged, no *Guide* in it any more. She said his in return, and it came out ten different ways.

Afterwards the lamp burned down. The river made its ice-sounds outside. She lay with her head on his shoulder and his good arm round her, and she did a thing she had done every night for ten winters. She went looking for the count.

Packets. Prices. Days to the thaw.

She found nothing to tally. She was warm all through, and for once there was no column to put it in. She simply lay there and was held.

"What are you counting?" said Rohan into her hair.

"Nothing." She turned her head, to test the word on the rope. It sat quietly on her wrist. "Nothing at all. It's strange."

"I will not add to it," he said, and tightened his arm.

She smiled against his collarbone. Then her eyes, drifting, found the chair by the window where he had thrown his coat. The flap hung open at the collar. Out of it, in the grey lamplight, showed the corner of a folded cream paper with a red seal on it, the orders of the pass-warden of Shilak. *Deliver the Salt Fox at the thaw.*

She had said her name to three hundred people today, and the clerk had written it in a book. *Held pending the queen's judgement.*

His arm round her did not loosen. It did not tighten either. She knew without looking that he had seen where she was looking, and that he was awake, and not saying anything, and that silence was free.

She did not ask. She lay very still, and listened to the river, and for the first time since the Rope-Hut she could not tell how many days were left.

Chapter 31

The Winter Crossing Law

Nimmi came down from Ranu on the second grain cart the hill council let through, and she laid her kit on the guest-house table before she had unwound her shawl.

"Left hand," she said. "Ring finger and little finger. Grey to the root, as I told you at Ranu, and it has not improved by being ignored."

Ila had cleared the table and boiled the linen. She stood at the window with her measuring cord wound tight round one fist, as if she could survey her way out of the room. Rohan sat on a stool at Meera's right and took her right hand in both of his.

Her grip was already hard. "Don't talk," Meera said. "I'm going to count."

"Count what?"

"Everyone." She looked up at the ceiling beams. "One. Hakam's cousin, the winter I was nineteen. Two. His wife."

Nimmi bent over the left hand. The small bright knife moved. Rohan kept his eyes on Meera's face.

"Three. The tanner's boy." Her voice thinned and held. "Four."

By the ninth he was counting with her, saying only the numbers, half a beat behind. He had thought the count was a ledger. It was more like a rope she climbed, one hold after the next, and every number was a face. She needed no mark for any of them. Her knuckles ground his split ones together and he let them.

"Ninety-one," said Meera.

"Done," said Nimmi.

"I'm not stopping at ninety-one."

"Then count slower while I bind it. I have never lost a patient to arithmetic."

They went on, the two of them, up the long stair of strangers she had walked over the Saddle, while Nimmi wrapped the hand in clean linen and lamb fat. Somewhere past a hundred and forty Meera laughed, shakily, at a goatherd who had paid in cheese. At two hundred and six she stopped and breathed.

"And one," she said. She turned her head and looked at him. "Two hundred and seven."

He understood where he had been entered. His mouth opened. Nothing came out of it.

"I'd have put you in anyway," said Meera. "I only wanted to watch you hear it."

"Head between your knees, Captain," said Nimmi, tying off. "Grey face, damp hands, a stare. I have seen it on fathers."

*

The law took six weeks to write, and when they finished it ran to eleven lines.

Hill council men came and went with their opinions and their tea. Kunal came twice, spoke with care, and left each time looking like a man who had given away less than he meant to and more than he expected. Nimmi stayed nine days before Ranu pulled her home, and she dictated the second clause as though listing symptoms. "Medicine passes. Not 'may pass.' Not 'passes on payment.' It passes, and the warden who stops it answers for the cough."

The first clause was Rohan's, and it cost him more than a morning. Licensed bound guides, crossing in winter, under a licence that carried two seals: the post's and the hill council's.

Old Bhim of the council read it twice and laid a thick finger on the post's seal. "Strike that one. It hanged our people for sixty winters. Why should it sign for them now?"

"Because the queen's law runs through it," Rohan said. "Strike it, and the crown will call the whole paper a rebel's."

"Then let it sign second. And let it sign what the council has sealed, with no more to say."

Rohan had held the only seal on that road for ten winters. The right to refuse a crossing was the whole of his office, and he was proud of how seldom he had misused it. He looked at the line. Across the room Meera lifted her bandaged hand from the sill and did not speak.

"Second," he said. "The post may read a licence. It may not refuse one the council has sealed."

He wrote it in. The pen did not shake, but when he set it down his fingers had gone stiff from gripping it.

"You gave away your veto," Meera said afterward, low, on the stair.

"I gave away the thing I was proudest of." He found, somewhat to his surprise, that he could say it lightly. "It was never a good thing to be proud of."

Ila corrected everything.

"'A bound rope: about eight arm-spans,'" a council man read out.

"Exactly eight," said Ila, striking the word *about*. "Whose arm? I measured Rohan's against the post door before the snow closed the road, and it runs a hair over the common. Write eight spans of the guide's own arm and let the guide be the standard."

"The jogini allow twelve," Rohan said. "Eight is what one guide can hold on a slide."

"Then somebody should measure the jogini's twelve. I want to know whose arm they used." She laughed, loud and sudden, and a council man dropped his cup.

In the second week he set a parcel on the table beside the count. Meera unwrapped it with her right hand: a left glove of felted wool, lined with lambskin, cut for a thumb and two fingers.

"You measured me," she said.

"With a cord, while you slept. I should have asked." He kept his voice level. "The hand cannot tell you when it is cold. You check its colour every hour, the way other people look at the sky."

She drew it on. It fit. She flexed the three fingers and looked at the glove for longer than the glove deserved.

"Don't be kind in front of the council," she said.

"They are in the next room."

"Then be kind quietly."

He was. It took no effort at all.

The last clause he wrote on a grey afternoon with Kiran at the end of the table. Kiran had been told to rest and had asked, instead, to be in the room. It was the only thing he had asked for since the Fair, and he had not made a single joke. He sat wrapped in a blanket, his torn ear tucked under it, watching the pen.

Dilan's rope end lay by the ink. Rohan had put it there without deciding to.

No person shall be hanged, nor held to blame at law, for a death upon a bound crossing.

He wrote it in one stroke and sanded it. The scratch of the nib was very loud.

"You spelled 'crossing' right," said Kiran. His voice cracked on it. He pulled the blanket higher. "Good. It's good."

"It is for the next one," Rohan said. "Whoever it is."

Kiran nodded without looking up and stayed where he was until the ink dried.

*

The news came in pieces, with the dispatch riders.

Varun lay in irons in the cellar of Garh Neshar and would go down to Taravan in chains when the passes opened, to answer in the queen's court. Pritam was held in his own grey seat, with the hill council signing

for his grain stores. And the regent's general, said the assembly's finding, had been exiled across the border with his horse and one saddlebag.

"The paper says exiled," said Nimmi, who had not yet gone home. She had a cup of walnut tea and no patience. "The torches went down in my lane on the order of a man on a grey horse. I stood on my step. I watched him do it. Write what you like. Ranu will say otherwise, and it will go on saying it long after the paper rots."

Rohan thought of a sword belt laid on cold grass, and of a man who stood beside it with his hands empty. He wanted the name. He knew it was not his to ask for. He set down his pen, wrote nothing, and let the whisper stand.

*

On the last night, when the fair copy was done and sanded, Meera sat with it under the lamp and did not read it.

"It's paper," she said. "Good paper. Until her hand is on it, in spring, I'm still a name in the assembly's book with a hanging written beside it."

"The assembly has no gallows the queen has not lent it."

"Your wardens do."

"Yes." He did not look away from that. "A warden cannot pardon. Only the queen. But my writ is her own hand, and a warden may name his guide upon it for the crossing home."

She was quicker than he was. She always was. "The Closing Roll."

"You know it."

"I've known it since I was nineteen. A name on the Roll is a name that comes when it's called." She counted it on her good hand, one finger at a time. "For life. Winter service whenever summoned. And I can't say no to a warden."

"Mine, while I wear the grey. After me, whoever holds the post."

"That's the part I don't like."

"No," said Rohan. "I would think less of you if you did."

She was silent. The river ground under the window. He had spent his life being the one who said, *it is the law,* and he had never before offered someone the law and wished it were smaller.

"I'd be selling it to you," she said. "My freedom. To the man whose job was to take it."

"To the crown. I am one of its clerks." He tried the dry tone and it nearly worked. "I do not mean to abuse the call. I believe I never will. But I will not swear to it, and you should not take my belief for a vow."

"I know you wouldn't." She turned the fair copy so the lamp lit its first line. "I'll owe them winters. I'd give them anyway."

He had thought it would feel like a loss. It felt like watching her step off the bank onto ice she had tested herself.

"And the orders in your coat," she said. She did not make it a question.

"I have not found how to make the paper say no to them," said Rohan. "I am looking."

Her eyes went to his wrist. The rope lay there, quiet and slack. No note, low or otherwise.

"That isn't a promise," Meera said.

"No." He made himself hold her look. "If I swore it and the paper failed me, the mountain would take the price out of me, and I would be no use to you at all. I will not dress a hope up as a vow."

For a moment she only studied him. Then the corner of her mouth moved. "Good. I'd have been watching your fingers." She tapped the fair copy. "You can keep looking at the cairn."

He gathered the pages to carry down to the clerk. "I will leave you to sleep."

"Stay."

He stopped with the papers against his chest.

She was not looking at the lamp or the law. She was looking at him, and her hand lay flat and still on the table.

"I've given all winter," she said. "Orders. The count. My hand. I've never in my life asked anyone for a thing that was only mine." Her fin-

gers stayed warm; he could see them. “Stay. Tonight. I’m not finished asking after the thaw, but I’m starting with tonight.”

He set the papers down. “Yes.”

Ila had mended the latch at last. Meera crossed the room and shot the bolt, and the small iron sound told him more than the word had. She had left the door open once, to prove she could. This was the other thing, and it was hers.

He undid the new glove for her, one stall at a time. She watched his hands do it.

“Watch mine,” she said, low, and drew his face down.

“Here,” she told him against his mouth, plainly, as she gave orders on the Saddle. “Slower.”

He did as she said. She made a small sound in her throat that he meant to earn again. Her bandaged hand lay against his shoulder, careful and warm, and the lamp burned lower, and the river went on grinding under the window.

*

Afterwards she lay with her head under his chin and laughed, once, at nothing.

“What?”

“I want it again tomorrow.” She said it to his collarbone. “I’m going to keep wanting things. I thought you should be warned.”

“I am warned,” said Rohan. “I will stay.”

The rope hummed against both their wrists, low and level, one held note with no climb in it. Her fingers moved on his chest; she felt it too. A small promise, and one he could keep by lying still. He had never made one that felt so little like a weight.

*

The thaw came early to the south slopes and late to the north, and by the time they left Garh Neshar the snow on the road had gone to grey porridge by noon.

Ila stayed behind with her cord and her unfinished map and a ridge she had not yet found a name for. She gripped her brother's shoulders at the gate and told him he walked a degree off true, and he told her he knew.

Kiran stood a pace behind her in the doorway, wrapped in his blanket, too weak for the road and too stubborn to be left inside. He said nothing at all. His hand crept up under the wool to his torn ear and stayed there, and he watched Rohan as if memorising a map.

They crossed back as lawful as paper could make them. The writ ran, in Rohan's hand and the queen's, to the Captain of the Shilak post and his named guide, Meera of Kothi Shilak, and no one at the Neshar post asked a question after the first look at the seal. Meera carried the writ case in her coat. She said it weighed more than the redbark had.

They passed the Rope-Hut on the second morning. The nail above the door stood bare. Nobody had hung a new sprig there, and Rohan knew whose hands had used up the old one. The felled tree below it had put out green at the tips. Neither of them went in. He was glad to have seen it from outside.

They travelled in the dark hours and the early light, when the crust held. By day the whole mountain talked: water running under the snow, ice settling, the slow wet crack of cornices letting go somewhere out of sight. The winter line was fainter in the thaw, a pale blue thread in the grey, but it held. Rohan walked behind her and uphill, as she had taught him, and anchored the rope. She never once looked back to see if he was there.

On the fourth morning they came down off the Saddle to the waystone. Meera stopped. Four small stones sat where they had left them for Jassi, three of hers and one of his. She added a fifth, set it carefully, and stood a moment with her good hand flat on the pillar.

"For the goats," she said. "He'd say I'd forgotten the goats."

That afternoon they topped the last ridge. Below them lay the roofs of Kothi Shilak, the tall old salt house with its goat pen and its thin smoke, and nearer, on the slope at the foot of the pass, the small grey

ring of the cairn. Goat bells carried up the hill, faint and wrong-pitched and entirely alive. Snow lay along the cairn's north side, heavy and white. On the south side, where the sun reached, it had begun to darken.

Meera stood very still. He knew she was counting. He did not need to ask what.

"Two nights," she said. "Maybe three."

"Yes."

The rope hung loose between them, eight spans of red wool gone soft with use. It had held him on a gully wall and in a lockhouse. It had told her every truth he had ever said. Once meltwater ran at the cairn it would be only a rope.

He did not say what he wanted. He worked the knot at his wrist loose, as far as it would give, and held the slack end out to her in his open palm.

Meera looked at it. Then she put her mittened hand over his and closed his fingers round the wool.

"Come on, Rohan," she said. "Let's go down and find out how far we walk when nobody's measuring."

Chapter 32

First Thaw

Eleven drips a minute fell from the snow cap on the top stone of the Shilak Cairn, and none of them counted.

Meera had been counting since dawn. The drips fell on the flat slab and spread into a dark coin, and the coin dried in the wind before the next one came. A drip was not meltwater running. The rule was exact. The bond ended when water first ran at the cairn, and the mountain had never been generous with its definitions.

"Twelve," she said. "Twelve a minute now."

"You said that a quarter hour ago," said Bindu.

"It was eleven a quarter hour ago."

Bindu hummed a knot-count under her breath and went on winding her spindle. She had come up from Kothi Shilak before light with half the village behind her. Hakam, the three-fingered old man, sat on a flat stone with his pattu over his knees. Roop and Chand stood with the goatherds and their wives in the wet snow. They pretended not to stare at the wardens, and the wardens pretended not to stare back.

Eight wardens in grey stood on the north side of the ring. Rohan stood with them and not among them, the red rope between his wrist and hers. It was the only thing about the morning that was entirely clear.

Meera slid her good hand into her coat and brought out the bell.

It was the big bell, the brass drum Badami had worn through nine winters of crossings, green at the seams, with a tongue worn thin as a

leaf. She stepped to the cairn's inner face and hung it by its thong on a jut of stone beside the carved hands. The wind found it at once and gave it one note, flat and plain, and not the note the stones made.

"Jassi," she said. "This is Badami's big bell. Your small one lies with Sunni at Ranu, where I told it to lie. And Badami is with your sister Leela, in the apricot orchard, forty trees, just as you planned." She stopped. "That's all. I counted you in the book the day you came to us, and I'm not taking you out."

Nobody spoke. Hakam took off his cap.

*

"Captain."

The senior warden did not say it loudly. He was a square man called Gopal, grey at the temples, who had walked behind Rohan for nine winters and who stood now at a correct distance with his hands at his sides.

"Gopal," said Rohan.

"I carry no orders of my own, sir. But I have read your writ." Gopal's eyes went to Meera and came back. "It says deliver the Salt Fox at the thaw. The ice is going. I'd be failing you if I let the hour come and said nothing."

The rope went very still on Meera's wrist. She did not look at Rohan. She had told herself on the last ridge that she would not, and again in the night, and she had been right both times.

I am looking, he had said. He had not said *I promise.* She had liked him for it under the lamp, for the honesty of it. She did not like it now. Looking was not finding. If the paper had failed him, then a captain's duty stood where his hope had been, and she would learn it in front of three hundred stones and a village.

Silence is free, she thought. It had never felt so expensive.

The wardens stood in a half ring. Some looked at their boots. One young man looked at her left glove, with its two missing stalls, and then at the sky.

"You are not failing me," said Rohan. "You are doing your duty, and I want it done clearly, before the meltwater runs. So that nobody here, on either side, has to wonder what was said."

He turned to face the whole cairn: the wardens, the crew, the goatherds with their children on their hips. His voice was the plain, slow one of the meadow. Meera knew it as the voice he used for bad news.

"The writ names the Salt Fox, and I know who she is. She is Meera of Kothi Shilak. She wrote her own name in the assembly's book before three hundred people, and the clerk wrote it again." The wind rang Badami's bell. "I am not arresting her. I am walking to Taravan beside her, with the law in her hand."

Meera had the fair copy in the writ case on her chest. The eleven lines weighed nothing, and she felt each of them. He had not found the way. He had simply chosen, out loud, where no paper could take it back.

"The queen may say otherwise," said Gopal.

"She may. Then she will say it to my face, and I will stand where I stand now." Rohan's mouth moved, the dry corner of it. "If you wish to enter that in the post book, Gopal, please spell it right."

Gopal was silent for the length of a breath. Then he put his fist to his chest, an old salute, the post's own, and stepped back into the line. The young warden who had been looking at the sky was looking at Rohan.

"Sir," said Gopal. "It's entered."

Behind her Bindu began humming again, louder, and cut it off with a cough.

*

The drips came faster. Sixteen. Eighteen. She could no longer count them.

Then came a small, ordinary sound at the foot of the cairn, like a spoon dragged through a cup. A thread of water the width of a barley stalk had found its way off the slab, down the south face and into the gap between two stones. It ran. It caught the light. It ran again.

The rope on her wrist went slack.

It did not fall. It just stopped being a thing that listened. The knot that had sat tight on her pulse since before midwinter was a knot and nothing more, a bit of red wool she had bought from a woman in Taravan.

Rohan breathed in. The stones stayed silent.

"Well," Meera said. "Count that."

She untied her wrist. Her fingers did it without being told, the old flat reef with its half hitch. She laid the rope in Bindu's hands and turned and began to walk.

She counted aloud, because it was how she did things. "One. Two." Past the end of the eight spans, where the rope would once have drawn her up like a leashed goat. Her stride did not change. "Nine. Ten." The cold that had waited at that distance all winter, the cold she had known since a mitten at fifteen, never came. The wind blew and it was only wind. Her own breath smoked and it was only breath.

She went on to the herders' fold below the ring, and the creak of its gate told her she had gone far enough. Twelve spans, fourteen, she did not know. She had never been this far from him by choice.

She stood there, the whole of the Shilak below her and the road to Taravan going away in mud, and she could walk on. Nothing held her. She could have gone down to the lowland and been nobody.

She turned around.

He had not moved. That was the first thing she saw: he stood exactly where she had left him, hands open, as he had stood on the meadow. He had not taken a step after her, and she knew what it had cost him. His fingertips were the colour of living skin.

She walked back. Every step of it she chose.

"Fifteen," she said, when she reached him. "I stopped counting after the gate. It's very odd."

"I counted," said Rohan. His voice was not steady. "Sixteen and a half."

"You never took your eyes off me."

"No."

"That," said Meera, "is the last time you get to check."

*

Bindu had the new rope ready. She had spun it herself over the winter, in the evenings when the others slept, undyed cream wool with the lanolin still in it, and she held it out in both hands as if it might be refused.

"It's not red," she said, going pink. "There isn't any red in it. I thought you'd not want the same one."

"It's short," said Meera.

"It's two spans. Nobody needs more than that if they're standing close."

The goatherds laughed. It was the first laugh of the morning and it went round the cairn like a drink.

Meera took one end and held it up. Rohan took the other. For two months and more they had touched no rope that wasn't tying them to a cliff or to each other, and neither of them knew quite what to do with one when no one had made them.

"The mountain's done," she said. "Nobody's asking us. There's no distance, and no cold, and I can lie to you all I like."

"You cannot," said Rohan.

"I could. It'd be free." She tied the knot on his wrist, the warden's double hitch he had tied on the seal's cord: two turns round the standing part, a tuck, a locking half-turn. She did it snug, the way he snugged it, not the way she had. "There. Yours."

He looked at it. Then he took the other end and tied hers: the flat reef with a half hitch, Bindu's knot, taught to a five-year-old with a rope round her fist. His fingers were not quite steady, and he did it well.

"Say it to the stones," said Hakam, from his rock. "It's usual."

"The stones have heard enough from us," said Meera. She looked at the man in front of her. "Say it to me."

"My name is Rohan," he said. "My road is the one you walk. I choose it."

"Meera. And mine is the one you walk." The thin wool settled on her pulse, a rope that held because two hands held it. "I choose it."

Gopal had stepped forward, his fist half raised. "Captain, if I may—"

"Rohan," said Meera, before Rohan could. She said it to the wardens, the goatherds, Jassi's bell, the dripping slab. "Not Captain. Not today."

Gopal's mouth twitched. "Rohan, then," he said, and saluted anyway.

Somebody cheered. Chand, it was, a big shy man, who went red as soon as he did it. The cheer broke, and half the village was suddenly laughing and wanting to touch her sleeve. Bindu wept openly into the spindle. Rohan stood in the middle of it with the cream rope on his wrist, looking at his hand, and at her, and at his hand again.

"We're betrothed, I think," he said, as if he were checking a column.

"Yes. I've done the sum."

"Then I should say that I love you."

"You've said it." She held up her bare right hand, and the left in its felted glove. "Look at me, Rohan. Look at my hands. Nothing's watching them now. Nothing's checking. You'll have to take my word."

"I do," said Rohan.

The rope had never let them have that: belief with nothing to prove it.

*

The wind dropped.

She felt it before she heard it. Everyone did. The laughter thinned from the outside in, a wave going out of a room. Bindu's spindle stopped. Even Badami's bell fell still, hanging from its thong with the tongue held, as if a hand had closed on it.

The stones began to ring.

It started low in the south face, where the water ran, and climbed. She knew that note. She had heard it a hundred times, the stones answering a lie inside the ring. This was the same note and yet not the same. Where it once stopped at a liar, it rose and kept rising, until the whole cairn shook with it and the snow on the top stone shivered into the air.

"Nobody lied," said Hakam, very quiet, and put his hand on his chest.

The cold came into her palms.

This was no lie-cold. She would have known that anywhere, the dead white climbing from her fingertips. It came to both hands at once, to the five of her right and the three of her left, and to the two that were gone. It was clean and sharp as frost on a window, and where it lay it wrote.

Nothing had ever spoken to her through her skin. It was not words, yet it was plain as words.

The bargain is owed.

All around her people were gasping. A goatherd's child began to cry. One of the young wardens had dropped to a knee in the slush with both hands pressed against his coat.

It was made at this stone. It was never paid.

Rohan's hand closed on hers. His was shaking. She held it back.

When the fourth winter ends, the pass closes. Forever. Unless someone pays.

The ring held for a long moment. Then the note fell, stone by stone, and the cold left her palms and the wind came back across the slab as though it had been waiting at the door. Badami's bell gave one flat clank.

Nobody said anything. Meera looked at her hands. They were pink. They were only hands.

"I felt it," said Gopal. He was grey. "Every word. Did we all?"

"Every word," said Bindu, in a small voice. The whole crowd made a low sound, an animal one, of people who had known winters all their lives and had never been told one would be the last.

"Who is to pay?" said Chand. "What bargain? Nobody told us of a bargain."

Meera thought of Kiran, still at Garh Neshar behind Ila's door, wrapped in his blanket. The word would reach him. A bargain was made on a rope, and her brother had lain on the ice at the end of one that was cut. He had nodded at *for the next one* and said nothing until the ink dried. Now he would hear *unless someone pays,* and he would go looking

for a debt to settle. Her stomach turned over, cold with something no mountain had put there.

"The chronicle says two brothers crossed bound," said Rohan slowly. He had not let go of her. "And that the pass has stood open to the faithful ever since."

"Ever since," said Hakam, "isn't forever."

Meera was looking at the carving on the inner face. She had touched it as a girl, for luck, as every child of the Shilak did. Two hands, one rope. She had never looked at how the hands were made. One was broad and thick at the knuckle. The other was long and narrow. Brothers in arms did not come out so unlike. The chronicle had lied about something, and she had counted enough ledgers to know when a total did not come out.

"Sixty winters ago," Rohan said, low, as if to the stone. "The spring they wrote the Closing Law. My grandfather was found at the thaw with his gloves laid one on the other on a flat stone. My father told it when he drank. A man who is lost in a storm does not fold his gloves." His throat moved. "Someone set them down tidily. As you would leave a thing you will not need again."

"As payment," Meera said. It came out barely a sound.

"I do not know. I have never known." His hand tightened on hers, the cream rope pulling a little at both their wrists. "Ila stayed in Neshar to finish her map. The queen will want it. She will want it very much."

Meera heard what he did not say. She had the habit of it now. *She will want it, and I do not yet know why.*

"Then we'd better get to Taravan," she said. "Before somebody else decides what it is we owe."

She kept her eyes on the two unequal hands, and behind her the thaw ran on, and somewhere under the mountain, in the dark, it ran toward a place she had never been.

Also by Mira Sangla

The Winter Passes

1. *Bound till the Thaw* (this book)
2. *The Winter Oath*
3. *Salt and Snow*
4. *The Last Crossing*

Coming next

Ila has measured every ridge in Hemkot except the ones that matter.

She is thirty-one, the queen's pass-surveyor, and brisk enough to correct a general's distances in front of his soldiers. Winter has shut her inside Neshar with a half-finished map, a commission with the royal archive's seal on it and one rule she has never broken: a map is true or it is false. It is never good or bad. It is never anyone's weapon.

Kunal knows better. He is thirty-three, a prince of Neshar with a courtier's smile and a rebel's habits, and he keeps three hidden routes in his head because whoever knows the way owns the people. He has read her commission. He thinks she is the queen's cartographer, sent to open his valley to garrisons.

She thinks he is his uncle's kind of prince.

Then the mountain gets a vote. A rope, a cairn, and a closed pass bind them together until the thaw, with ice that booms like a drum beneath their feet. Every true answer he gives about the hidden ways becomes a line on a crown map. Every true answer she gives about her orders tells him what she is drawing against his people. And somewhere below the Shilak Cairn, in the dark, is a debt that two courts have worked very hard to keep off every map.

Ila can draw the passes so exactly that no one will ever lose them again. She can also draw them so exactly that no one can ever hide.

Will Ila map the hidden passes for the queen, or hide them for Neshar?